

THE SEVENTH COURTYARD

A Novel

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Chapter One

The Photograph That Should Not Exist

The first photograph Ayaan Mirza took of Naina Rao in nine years was one she did not know existed.

She was standing beneath the arched entrance of Surya Garh Palace, one hand pressed to the loose end of her ivory dupatta while the late-afternoon wind tried to carry it into the lake. Behind her, two porters argued over a suitcase, a child in a sherwani chased a peacock, and the bride's uncle shouted into his phone about a missing harmonium. Nothing in the frame was arranged. Naina's face was turned away from the arriving guests and toward the western wall, where rain-dark clouds gathered above the Aravalli hills.

For half a second she looked unobserved.

Ayaan lowered the camera.

He had spent enough years waiting for faces to become honest that he recognized the instant before performance returned. He also knew he should delete the image.

Instead he marked it with a star.

"Naina."

Raghav's voice came from somewhere behind her, cheerful and already impatient. "They've put us in the lake wing. Apparently that is good. Or inconvenient. I couldn't understand the boy."

She turned, and the expression Ayaan had caught vanished so completely that he wondered whether he had imagined it.

Raghav Rao came through the entrance with a leather weekender over one shoulder and both their room cards held between his teeth. He was still wearing his airport blazer despite the humidity. Travel never made him untidy; it merely made his neatness look heroic.

"Give me one," Naina said, taking the cards.

"You have your phone?"

"Yes."

"And the jewellery bag?"

"In my handbag."

"Meera's gift?"

"In the blue suitcase."

Raghav smiled. “See? This is why I married you.”

It was the kind of sentence that had once made her feel chosen. Now it landed like a receipt.

She did not blame him for that. A sentence could not know how many times it had been used.

The palace rose in honey-coloured tiers from the edge of Lake Kalyan, its balconies catching the last diluted sun. It was not an ancient royal estate, as the wedding website suggested, but an ambitious nineteenth-century imitation built by a merchant prince who had wanted a lineage impressive enough for his money. Naina had looked up the original plans on the flight. Four principal courtyards. Two service courts. A zenana wing altered beyond recognition in the 1970s. The restoration photographs on the hotel website showed too much polish and too little restraint.

Even so, she loved it immediately.

Not the velvet ropes or the brass lamps arranged for photographs. She loved the irregularities: a repaired crack that wandered through three generations of plaster, a rain spout shaped like a crocodile, the shallow mismatch between the left and right colonnades. Buildings told the truth through what refused to align.

The journey from Udaipur airport had taken two and a half hours through villages rinsed clean by an early shower. Raghav had spent most of it on a conference call, one earbud in place, while Naina watched roadside shrines flash between neem trees. Whenever the signal failed, he had muted himself and pointed out something he thought she would like—a crumbling haveli, a stepwell sign, a herd of goats occupying the highway with complete authority.

He still noticed what interested her. That was part of the difficulty.

At a tea stall outside Rajsamand, he had bought her a paper cup without asking and added exactly half a spoon of sugar. He had known the amount for eight years. Then his call resumed, and he walked to the far side of the car while she drank alone beside a painted wall advertising wedding tents.

Their marriage had not become cold. Coldness would have been easier to diagnose. It remained warm in dozens of practiced places: morning coffee, shared passwords, his palm against the small of her back in crowded lifts, the automatic message when either of them landed safely. What had thinned was surprise. They had become experts in each other's maintenance and amateurs in each other's change.

Naina had promised herself the wedding would interrupt that. Three days away from Hyderabad, no office commute, no parents dropping by, no unfinished proposals spread across the dining table. She had packed the blue dress Raghav liked and the perfume he

had once bought her in Singapore. On the flight, she had rested her head on his shoulder and imagined they might remember how to be curious about one another.

Then Surya Garh had placed Ayaan beneath the entrance arch.

“There she is!”

Meera Khanna descended the entrance stairs in a saffron lehenga, gathering the skirt in both hands. She collided with Naina in a cloud of jasmine and perfume.

“You came,” Meera said into her shoulder.

“You sent seventeen reminders.”

“Because you decline happiness unless it arrives as a calendar invitation.” Meera pulled back and inspected her. “You look exactly the same. Annoying.”

“You look like a bride who has not slept since June.”

“Correct. Raghav, I am stealing your wife.”

“Everyone does,” Raghav said. “Just return her by checkout.”

Meera laughed and dragged Naina toward the registration table. Raghav followed more slowly, already answering a call.

Before they reached it, two women in red odhnis blocked their way with a brass plate. One circled a lamp before Naina's face while the other pressed vermilion beneath Raghav's hairline. A drummer struck a rapid welcome rhythm. Rose petals fell from an upper balcony in a fragrant, excessive shower.

Raghav caught one on Naina's shoulder.

“We have been here four minutes and the building has already blessed our marriage,” he said.

“It charged Meera's father for the petals.”

“Still counts.”

He tucked the petal into the edge of her dupatta. The gesture was ridiculous and tender. Naina smiled before she could examine the feeling.

For one second she saw the weekend she had expected: Raghav stealing sweets from ceremonial trays, both of them laughing in unfamiliar rooms, desire made possible by being temporarily relieved of their ordinary life.

Then Meera glanced past her toward the photographer, and expectation altered shape.

Naina noticed the photographer only because he stepped aside to let them pass.

At first he was merely a man in a charcoal kurta with two cameras strapped across his chest, taller than the assistant beside him, his hair shorter than she remembered. Then he lifted his head.

Nine years did not disappear. They folded.

She felt the dry heat of a ruined stepwell. Dust beneath her nails. A steel cup of over-sweet tea passed between them on a railway platform at dawn. The blue notebook in which she had drawn arches while he wrote down the names of women who still collected water from places the government had declared abandoned.

She heard herself say his name before deciding to.

“Ayaan.”

He did not look surprised. That was worse.

“Hello, Naina.”

Meera’s hand tightened around hers. Not enough to restrain her. Enough to register that something had happened.

Raghav ended his call and joined them. “You two know each other?”

There were at least seven possible answers. Naina chose the smallest.

“We worked on a project years ago.”

Ayaan extended his hand. “Ayaan Mirza.”

“Raghav Rao.” Raghav shook it warmly. “What kind of project?”

“Documentation,” Naina said.

“Stepwells,” Ayaan said at the same time.

Raghav glanced between them, amused by the difference. “Of course. For Naina everything becomes architecture.”

“Not everything,” Ayaan said.

The words were neutral. His expression was neutral. Only Naina seemed to hear the old argument inside them.

Meera stepped into the silence with bridal authority. “Ayaan is Dev’s cousin and my official tyrant. He has forbidden anyone from asking him to make them thinner.”

“I can make people thinner,” Ayaan said. “I can’t make them less themselves.”

“See? Tyrant.”

Raghav laughed. “You’ll have no trouble with Naina. She hides from cameras.”

Ayaan’s gaze rested on her for one beat too long. “I remember.”

Naina turned toward the lake.

The wind had risen. It carried the mineral smell that came before rain, though the sky above the palace remained bright. Across the water, a narrow causeway connected the main hotel to an older cluster of buildings beneath the western wall. Most of the windows there were shuttered. One upper jharokha stood open like a dark eye.

“What is that wing?” she asked Meera.

“Closed, supposedly. Dev says it is unsafe. His grandmother says it is haunted. The hotel says it doesn’t exist.”

“Hotels don’t usually deny entire buildings.”

“This family can deny anything with sufficient confidence.”

Ayaan adjusted the strap on his shoulder. “It used to be called Neel Mahal.”

“Used to be?” Naina asked.

“It was removed from the plans during the restoration.”

Something in his tone made her look at him again.

“Buildings don’t disappear because a drawing changes,” she said.

“No,” he replied. “People just stop admitting where the doors are.”

Meera groaned. “Wonderful. Two architecture poets. Please do not fall in love with a drainage channel before my mehendi.”

Raghav’s phone rang again.

He mouthed an apology and walked toward the colonnade.

Naina watched him go. When she turned back, Ayaan had lifted his camera, but it was aimed at the arriving musicians.

“You knew I would be here,” she said quietly.

“Yes.”

“I didn’t know about you.”

“I assumed that.”

“Why?”

He took one photograph, checked the exposure, and said, “Because you came.”

Before she could decide whether it was an accusation, Meera pulled her toward the registration desk.

The registration desk had been built from an old carved door laid across two brass trestles, which offended Naina enough to give her somewhere safe to place her attention. She examined the hinges while Meera argued about welcome hampers with a young man wearing a headset.

“They have drilled through seventeenth-century teak to hold name cards,” Naina said.

"Replica," Meera replied without looking. "I asked before permitting outrage. Your room is two-twelve. Dinner at eight. Mehendi at eleven because my family believes sleep is an insult to prosperity."

"And tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow you stop asking for schedules and allow yourself to be decorative."

Naina signed the register. The pen left a thin interruption in the final stroke of her name. She tried again beneath it, though there was no reason to sign twice.

Meera noticed. Meera noticed everything and converted most of it into jokes, a habit Naina had once mistaken for carelessness.

"He looks different," Meera said.

"Everyone looks different after nine years."

"You knew exactly whom I meant."

Naina capped the pen. "Why didn't you tell me he was coming?"

"Because you would have invented an urgent structural crisis in Hyderabad."

"I don't invent structural crises. People remove columns and create them."

"You would have found one."

The argument at the welcome table continued around them. A cousin wanted a room near the bride. An aunt wanted a room far from the band. Someone had received a hamper containing gin despite having announced, to three branches of the family, that she had renounced alcohol after an incident in Goa.

Meera lowered her voice. "I wanted you here. Both of you. I told myself adults can occupy the same palace without history becoming a natural disaster."

"That depends on the palace."

"Naina."

"I'm married."

"That is a fact, not an answer."

The words irritated her because they were accurate in a direction she did not want explored. She looked across the courtyard for Raghav and found him under the colonnade, one finger pressed to his free ear as he spoke into his phone. Even from a distance she recognized the particular stillness that meant work had taken possession of him. He would say it was only five minutes. He would believe it every time.

"The answer is that nothing happened then," Naina said. "And nothing is going to happen now."

"I did not ask what would happen."

"You arranged your face as if you had."

Meera's expression softened. "Did you ever tell Raghav?"

"Tell him what?"

"That you and Ayaan spent six months travelling together. That you nearly chose a different life."

"I chose the life I have."

"Also not an answer."

Naina felt the old defensive sentence arrive: there had been no affair, no betrayal, nothing that required confession. But an omission could remain technically innocent while growing heavier each year. She had not hidden a kiss. She had hidden the version of herself who had once wanted one.

"Raghav knows I worked on the stepwell project," she said.

"Does he know who made you stay three weeks after your fellowship ended?"

"The survey made me stay."

"Of course. A famously seductive survey."

Naina gave her a warning look, but Meera had already turned to embrace another arriving relative.

She escaped toward the lake.

The rear terrace was quieter, shaded by a line of stone screens. Below, the water had changed from silver to the green-grey of old glass. Staff members hurried along the path with rolled carpets on their shoulders, preparing for rain no one had officially admitted was coming.

Naina rested both hands on the warm parapet. She had learned, over years of meetings, dinners, and family questions, how to appear at ease while privately measuring exits. The skill had entered her marriage so gradually she could not name the day it became necessary.

"You still find the unfinished edge of every room."

Ayaan's voice came from behind her.

She did not turn at once. "You still approach people without making enough noise."

"Occupational habit."

"It was annoying before it became an occupation."

He stopped beside the next section of parapet, leaving a deliberate arm's length between them. Up close, time was less merciful and more interesting. There was grey at one temple. A narrow scar crossed the back of his right hand. The boyish impatience she

remembered had settled into something quieter, but it had not disappeared. She could see it in the way he watched the sky as though weather might confess if he waited long enough.

"How long have you been photographing weddings?" she asked.

"I don't photograph weddings."

"You are wearing two cameras at a wedding."

"I photograph families under pressure. Some of them happen to exchange garlands."

She almost smiled. The impulse felt disloyal, which made her angry with herself and then angrier with the marriage that had taught her to audit harmless pleasure.

"Meera said you are Dev's cousin."

"Our mothers are cousins. The family tree becomes theoretical after that. He asked because their original photographer broke his wrist."

"Convenient."

"Not for the photographer."

Wind lifted the end of her dupatta again. She caught it before it crossed the space between them. Ayaan's hand had risen at the same instant. He stopped without touching the fabric and lowered it.

The unfinished gesture was more intimate than contact would have been.

Naina folded the material over her forearm. "You said you knew I would come."

"Meera told me."

"That is not what you meant."

His gaze returned to the lake. "No."

"Then what did you mean?"

"You always go where a building is keeping a secret."

"I came for my friend's wedding."

"Both things can be true."

She remembered a night in Bundi when they had argued until two in the morning about a sealed chamber beneath a queen's bath. He had said buildings kept memory in darkness. She had said darkness encouraged bad scholarship. At dawn, he had brought her tea without apology, and she had accepted it without victory. Their intimacy had been built almost entirely from unresolved arguments.

"Why did you stop writing?" he asked.

The question landed without warning.

"You stopped first."

"No. I sent three emails."

"After four months."

"After you returned my notebook through Meera."

"You left it in my bag."

"I asked you to keep it."

"You asked me to finish a drawing."

"You knew that wasn't all I was asking."

The terrace seemed suddenly too narrow. Naina became aware of the faint heat of him beside her, of the clean scent of vetiver and camera leather, of how easily the body recognized what the mind had filed as concluded.

She turned to face him. "That was the problem. You never said what you were asking."

For the first time since seeing her, his composure shifted. Not much. A breath held, then released.

"Would it have changed your answer?"

Raghav called her name from the doorway.

Naina stepped back before she had decided to move.

Her husband approached with his phone still in his hand. "There you are. The room key doesn't work, and apparently only the primary guest can reset it."

"You are the primary guest."

"They disagree. Marriage has finally produced an administrative advantage for you."

He put an arm around her waist, affectionate and automatic. His palm settled at her side through silk. Naina felt Ayaan register the touch and then politely look away.

Raghav noticed the camera. "Did you get any good pictures of her? She normally disappears when someone points a lens."

"Not yet," Ayaan said.

Naina heard the lie and the promise inside it.

Raghav's hand remained at her waist as he led her toward the lobby. She matched his pace. At the doorway she looked back once.

Ayaan had raised his camera toward the rain-dark wing across the lake.

He did not photograph her leaving.

In the lift, Raghav leaned against the mirrored wall and loosened his tie.

"Should I be worried?" he asked.

The question was light enough to be withdrawn if she answered badly.

“About the weather?”

“About a man who remembers you dislike cameras.”

Naina watched the floor numbers change. “You remember I dislike coriander.”

“That is because you announce it as a moral position.”

“Perhaps I announced the camera too.”

The lift stopped at the first floor to admit an elderly couple carrying three garment bags. Raghav moved closer to make space. His hand settled at Naina's hip, fingers curved naturally around the silk. She could feel his wedding ring through the fabric.

“You never mentioned him,” he said near her ear.

The old couple faced the doors. Naina saw all four of them reflected in the brass panel: strangers politely avoiding one another's private conversation.

“I mentioned the project.”

“Projects don't usually look back.”

The doors opened on their floor.

Raghav lifted his weekender and smiled at the couple. By the time he followed Naina into the corridor, the question had been folded away with the efficiency he brought to every inconvenient thing.

She wished he had asked again.

That evening, while Naina unpacked in a room overlooking the lake, Ayaan sat in the temporary studio the wedding planners had built behind the ballroom. He transferred the arrival photographs to two separate drives, labelled the folders, and began the first selection.

Frame 1842: the groom embracing an elderly aunt.

Frame 1843: a porter losing control of a flower trunk.

Frame 1844: Naina under the arch, looking toward rain.

He enlarged it.

There were new lines beside her mouth. Her hair was shorter. A thin gold chain lay against the pulse in her throat. She looked older, naturally. But she also looked more carefully assembled, as though every visible part of her life had been approved before use.

In the photograph, one hand held her dupatta in place.

The other was open at her side.

Ayaan moved the cursor toward delete.

Then he created a folder called PRIVATE and placed the image inside it.

Outside, thunder travelled over the hills, too distant for anyone in the ballroom to hear.

Chapter Two

Rooms With Two Doors

Their suite had two entrances.

The first opened to the hotel corridor, where brass lanterns burned at perfect intervals and rose petals formed an arrow toward the ballroom. The second was narrower, painted the same pale blue as the wall and concealed behind a carved screen. It had no handle on the inside.

Naina noticed it before she noticed the champagne, the embroidered welcome cushions, or the bathtub filled with floating marigolds.

“Staff passage,” Raghav said when he found her examining it.

“Too narrow for service carts.”

“Old staff passage.”

“The hinges are new.”

He dropped onto the bed and loosened his collar. “We have been here six minutes.”

“Seven.”

“And you have already begun inspecting the hinges.”

She smiled. “You knew what you were buying.”

“Did I?”

The question could have been flirtation. Once, it would have been. Raghav reached for her wrist and pulled her gently between his knees.

“You’re quiet,” he said.

“Long flight.”

“Or old project?”

She looked at him.

“I’m not blind, Naina.”

“I never said you were.”

“You looked as if someone opened a cupboard and your twenties fell out.”

She laughed despite herself. Raghav’s talent had always been to make seriousness feel slightly foolish. It was one of the reasons she had loved him. It was also how certain conversations died.

“Ayaan and I worked together for six months,” she said. “That is all.”

“I believe you.”

“You say that like I asked.”

“You’re explaining him.”

“You asked.”

He rested his forehead against her stomach. “I’m not jealous.”

Naina placed a hand on his hair. “I didn’t say you were.”

They remained like that for a moment, married long enough to hear the repetitions and too tired to correct them.

Raghav’s phone vibrated on the bed.

He looked at the screen and sat up. “Dev’s father.”

“Already?”

“He wants ten minutes before dinner.”

“You promised this wasn’t work.”

“It isn’t work. It’s a conversation.”

“With the chairman of a hotel group.”

“At his son’s wedding.”

“About hotels.”

He kissed her hand. “Twenty minutes.”

The door closed behind him at 5:42.

At 6:25 Naina stopped pretending to unpack slowly.

She showered, changed into a green silk kurta, and stood before the mirror trying on earrings she had already chosen in Hyderabad. From the courtyard below came bursts of dhol practice, followed by the wedding planner’s amplified voice asking someone named Monty to remove a generator from the baraat route.

The storm clouds had thickened above the western wall.

Naina crossed to the window. From this height she could see the old wing more clearly: three linked structures arranged around a sunken court, reached by the causeway she had noticed at arrival. Blue plaster survived beneath years of stains. A small domed pavilion rose from the roof.

Someone stood beneath it.

Even at that distance she recognized the way Ayaan held a camera—not in front of his face, but lowered against his chest while he waited.

As if he felt her attention, he looked toward the hotel.

She stepped back from the window.

Her phone rang. Meera.

“Emergency,” the bride said.

“Blood or tailoring?”

“Emotion.”

“Worse.”

“Come to my room.”

Meera’s bridal suite occupied the corner of the zenana wing and contained eleven women, four open suitcases, one makeup artist, and a grandmother asleep through all of it. Naina found the bride in the bathroom, sitting on the closed toilet lid while her lehenga blouse was being altered outside.

“I cannot marry into this family,” Meera said.

“Is this new information?”

“They schedule feelings. Dev has given me seven minutes to be nervous because his cousins need the room for dance rehearsal.”

Naina leaned against the marble counter. “Do you want me to tell everyone to leave?”

“No. I want you to tell me this is normal.”

“It is normal.”

“You answered too quickly.”

“Pre-wedding panic is normal. Regretting your entire personality is normal. Wanting a power cut that cancels the wedding but does not injure anyone is extremely normal.”

Meera studied her through the mirror. “Did you panic before yours?”

Naina thought of a railway platform in Jodhpur. Ayaan asleep against his rucksack. Her phone bright in her hand with Raghav’s proposal, written plainly because he knew she disliked spectacle.

I know what I want. I think you do too.

She had read it three times. Then she had looked at Ayaan, waiting for him to wake.

“Everyone panics,” she said.

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the answer married people give.”

Meera took Naina’s hand. The diamonds painted into her mehendi caught the bathroom light.

“I didn’t know Ayaan was your Ayaan,” she said.

“He isn’t my anything.”

“You told me once about a photographer.”

“I told you about a project.”

“You said he could look at a ruin and make it seem like a witness.”

Naina withdrew her hand under the pretext of adjusting a towel. “That sounds embarrassingly dramatic.”

“It sounded like you.”

“Nine years ago.”

Meera’s expression softened. “I can replace him.”

“As your cousin?”

“As photographer.”

“Don’t be absurd.”

“I mean it.”

“It’s your wedding. You should not rearrange it around a story that never happened.”

The bride watched her carefully. “Those are often the stories people arrange their whole lives around.”

Before Naina could answer, the bathroom door burst open and three cousins carried in the altered blouse like a rescued patient.

By the time she returned to her suite, Raghav had sent two messages.

Running late. Fascinating property situation.

Wear the blue tonight? You look devastating in it.

Naina stared at the second message. It was affectionate. Specific. Exactly the kind of thing a wife had no right to resent.

She changed into blue.

At dinner, Raghav sat beside Dev’s father and discussed occupancy rates while the palace musicians performed beneath strings of amber lights. Naina sat between an anaesthetist from Mumbai and a woman who designed luxury pet furniture. Across the courtyard, Ayaan moved among the tables, nearly invisible despite the cameras.

He never pointed one at Naina.

That avoidance became a form of attention.

She became conscious of him each time he entered the edge of her sight: crouching to photograph a child asleep across two chairs, leaning back to frame the musicians beneath the arches, accepting a glass of water from a waiter without lowering either camera. He moved without the restless demand to be noticed that marked most men

holding expensive equipment. People forgot themselves around him. That was his advantage.

It had once been hers too.

The anaesthetist asked how she knew the photographer. Naina said they had worked together. The woman who designed pet furniture asked whether he had always looked so serious. Naina said she did not remember.

Both answers were technically respectable and emotionally false.

At the main table, Raghav laughed at something Dev's father said. He had removed his jacket and rolled his sleeves with exact symmetry. The sight of his forearms brought back the early years of their marriage: dinners eaten over floor plans, arguments interrupted by kisses, his hand closing around her ankle beneath a desk because she had refused to stop working. Desire had not vanished between them. It had been scheduled, postponed, and made efficient until spontaneity began to feel like another kind of irresponsibility.

As if summoned by the thought, Raghav looked across the courtyard and caught her watching.

His smile changed. The professional charm fell away, replaced by the private expression that had once made her cross crowded rooms without remembering who else was present.

He excused himself and came to her table.

"Dance with me," he said.

"No one is dancing."

"Then we will establish poor judgment early."

The musicians were playing a slow folk melody not intended for dancing, but he held out his hand. Guests turned with pleased curiosity. Naina wanted to refuse because the gesture was public and because part of her suspected that his attention had been sharpened by Ayaan's presence. She accepted for exactly the same reasons.

Raghav led her into the open square between the tables. One hand settled at her waist; the other held hers against his chest. For several seconds he only swayed, smiling when she tried to impose a rhythm on music that had none.

"You wore the blue," he said.

"You asked."

"I ask many things."

"That is true."

His thumb moved once against the silk at her side. The touch was small, familiar, and unexpectedly effective. Warmth tightened low in her body. He saw the change in her face and drew her a fraction closer.

"There you are," he murmured.

The words should have pleased her. Instead they made her wonder where he believed she had been.

"How long is your conversation with Dev's father going to continue?" she asked.

"Jealous?"

"Of a hotel acquisition? Constantly."

"It isn't an acquisition. Yet."

She stopped moving. "You said this was not work."

"And you said the photographer was only a project. Apparently we both summarized."

The easy cruelty of it surprised them both.

Raghav's hand tightened, then gentled. "That came out wrong."

"It came out efficiently."

"Naina."

"People are watching. Keep smiling."

He obeyed, which hurt more than an argument would have. They completed another circle for the benefit of the nearest tables. When the music ended, applause rose around them.

Raghav bent as if to kiss her cheek. His lips touched the place below her ear instead, hidden by her hair. Her breath caught. For one suspended instant she felt the man she had married: playful, attentive, capable of making her body answer before her caution arrived.

"Twenty minutes," he whispered. "Then I am entirely yours."

He returned to Dev's father.

Naina stood alone in the centre of the courtyard while the next song began.

Across the room, Ayaan lowered his camera.

She could not tell whether he had taken the photograph.

Naina left the courtyard before Raghav could return. She told herself she needed water. The truth was that her body still held the shape of his hands, while her mind had become aware of another man's attention, and occupying both sensations at once felt indecent.

The drinks table stood beneath a carved screen at the edge of the gallery. She poured water into a brass tumbler and drank too quickly.

"The blue suits you."

Ayaan stopped on the opposite side of the table. One camera hung against his chest. The other was in his hand, its screen turned inward.

Naina set down the tumbler. "Did Meera provide everyone with talking points?"

"No. Your husband did."

"You were listening."

"He said it loudly."

"Did you photograph us?"

Ayaan's thumb rested over the playback button. "Yes."

"Delete it."

His gaze lifted. "Why?"

"Because I am asking."

Without looking at the screen, he pressed two buttons. A small confirmation tone sounded.

"Done."

The immediate obedience unsettled her more than argument would have.

"You didn't even check which frame."

"I knew which one you meant."

"How?"

"It was the only time tonight you looked at me while your husband was touching you."

Heat reached her face. She glanced toward the courtyard. Raghav remained beside Dev's father, examining something on a tablet.

"That is an ugly observation."

"It isn't a judgment."

"Your photographs always pretend not to judge."

"Photographs select. That is already a judgment."

Naina reached for the water jug again, but Ayaan's hand arrived first. He filled her tumbler, careful not to touch her fingers.

"Were you happy when you married him?" he asked.

The question was so direct that for a second she heard it as rudeness rather than pain.

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He meant it. That was worse than resentment would have been.

“Did you expect me not to be?”

“I expected not to know.”

“You could have asked.”

“I did.”

She remembered the second email. *Are you happy?* Three words she had treated as if answering them would constitute betrayal.

“You asked after the article appeared with my work under your name.”

“And apologized before you knew there was a problem.”

“You knew there was a problem.”

Ayaan absorbed the accusation without defending himself. “Yes.”

The simple admission removed the argument she had kept polished for nine years.

Someone called for the photographer. Ayaan looked toward the sound, then back at her.

“For what it is worth,” he said, “you were looking at him before you looked at me.”

He walked away.

Naina remained beside the water table, furious that he had seen enough to offer mercy.

After dessert, Leela Baisa, the palace custodian, led a small group through the restored galleries. She was a narrow woman in a white sari, with silver hair coiled at the back of her head and the unhurried voice of someone who had outlasted several owners.

Naina joined because Raghav was still talking business.

“Six courtyards shaped the original residence,” Leela Baisa explained. “The first welcomed trade. The second received family. The third belonged to worship. The fourth to food, the fifth to servants, and the sixth to women.”

“And the buildings across the water?” Naina asked.

Leela Baisa stopped.

The other guests followed her gaze to the black windows of Neel Mahal.

“Storage,” she said.

“Around a sunken court?”

“Madam is an architect?”

“Interior architect.”

“Then madam knows that buildings are made to become many things.”

“What was it before storage?”

Leela Baisa’s eyes moved briefly toward Ayaan, who stood at the back of the group.

“A place for women who had too many ideas,” she said.

The group laughed, uncertain whether she had made a joke.

Naina did not.

When the tour ended, Ayaan found her beside a wall map in the gallery.

“There are only six courtyards marked,” she said.

“Officially.”

“You knew about the other one.”

“I’ve been photographing the unrestored estate for Dev.”

“Why remove it from the plan?”

“Ask the family.”

“I am asking you.”

He came closer, not intimately, but enough that they could speak without carrying their voices.

“Because the easiest way to own a place is to control the story of what happened there.”

“Still dramatic.”

“You used to like dramatic.”

“I used to be twenty-five.”

“Those are not opposites.”

Raghav called her name from the courtyard.

Naina stepped away.

“Good night, Ayaan.”

“Your room has a second door,” he said.

She turned back. “How do you know?”

“All the lake-wing rooms do.”

“Where does it lead?”

“That depends on which ones they sealed.”

Raghav called again.

Later, when he was asleep beside her, Naina crossed the dark suite and placed her palm against the blue door.

The wood was cool.

From the other side came a faint movement—not footsteps exactly, but the soft metallic complaint of a latch settling into place.

Naina waited.

Nothing followed.

Then, somewhere across the lake, a door slammed in the wind.

Chapter Three

Before the Vows

Nine years earlier, Naina had believed that thirst was the most honest architect.

It persuaded people to cut geometry into stone. It built stairs toward absence and made beauty out of the distance between the earth and water. In the stepwells of Rajasthan and Gujarat, every carved landing recorded a negotiation with heat.

She had written that sentence in the blue notebook on the morning she met Ayaan.

He read it upside down across the table of a tea stall outside Bundi and said, "Thirst doesn't build anything. People do."

Naina closed the notebook. "Do you usually read strangers' work?"

"Only when they write in public and underline twice."

He was twenty-seven, sunburnt, and irritatingly awake for six in the morning. A camera lay on the table beside a plate of untouched poha. He had been sent by an arts magazine to photograph five endangered stepwells. Naina had received a small conservation grant to measure the same structures.

By noon they had argued about documentation, objectivity, local memory, the ethics of photographing poverty, and whether a damaged bracket should be reconstructed if no drawing of the original survived.

By evening they had missed the same bus.

The project was supposed to last three weeks. It lasted six months because each place led to another place: a dry baori behind a school, a flooded vav beneath a textile warehouse, a private well whose elderly owner would admit Naina but not Ayaan, a village where women still descended two hundred steps each morning because the new pipeline had failed.

They became useful to one another before they became important.

Naina could make caretakers speak. Ayaan could make bureaucrats nervous. She measured shadows; he waited inside them. She drew what a structure had been designed to do. He photographed what people had made of it.

At night they worked in cheap guesthouses with their doors open to the corridor, trading notes and mosquito repellent.

Nothing happened.

That became, over time, the largest thing between them.

There had been opportunities. Too many for innocence to remain an adequate explanation.

In Patan, the guesthouse lost power during a night of dry lightning. The ceiling fan slowed above Naina's bed and stopped. Heat gathered instantly in the small room, thick with dust and the scent of lime soap. She carried her notebook into the corridor, where Ayaan sat on the floor beneath the emergency lamp, shirt open at the throat, sorting memory cards by touch.

"Your system is going to fail," she said.

"My system has survived three border crossings and a camel."

"The camel did not reorganize your files."

"You did. Much more dangerous."

She sat opposite him, back against the wall. Their bare feet nearly touched in the narrow passage.

Rain threatened without falling. Somewhere beyond the courtyard, a radio played an old ghazal through static. Neither of them translated the words. They did not need to. Longing was the most portable language they had encountered.

Ayaan handed her a bottle of warm water. Their fingers met around the plastic. He did not release it immediately.

Naina looked at his hand, then at him.

"What?" he asked.

"You are still holding the bottle."

"So are you."

The corridor contained four rooms, all occupied, every door standing open for air. An elderly surveyor snored behind the nearest mosquito net. The owner crossed the courtyard carrying candles. There was nothing private about the moment except the way Ayaan watched her.

She let go first.

Later, when the other guests had settled, they climbed to the roof. The stone still held the day's heat. Ayaan spread a cotton scarf over the parapet for her to sit on, an absurd courtesy when they had spent the afternoon knee-deep in mud.

"Show me the photographs," she said.

He sat beside her, shoulder touching hers, and turned the camera screen between them.

Most of the frames were what she expected: carved columns, broken landings, women carrying metal pots through bands of light. Then he moved too quickly past an image of Naina standing in the lowest gallery, head bent over her measuring tape.

"Go back."

"Bad exposure."

"You don't take bad exposures. You take unpleasantly deliberate exposures."

He returned to the photograph.

The image unsettled her. Her kurta clung damply between her shoulder blades. A loose strand of hair crossed her mouth. She was not smiling, yet she looked completely alive, absorbed in the act of understanding something.

"I look—"

"Like yourself," he said.

No one had ever offered the phrase as a compliment before.

The camera rested on his thigh. Their arms remained pressed together from shoulder to wrist. Naina could feel each breath alter the contact. She knew she should move. She also knew he was waiting for her to decide.

"You photograph me when I'm not looking," she said.

"You stop being honest when you see a lens."

"That is an accusation."

"An observation."

"You think a camera gives you permission to know people."

"No. I think attention creates responsibility."

"To whom?"

His gaze dropped to her mouth and returned to her eyes. "That depends on what you notice."

The air changed between them.

Naina's pulse became visible at the base of her throat. She hated that he could see it and wanted him to keep looking. The contradiction made her reckless.

"What have you noticed?" she asked.

Ayaan lifted one hand slowly, giving her time to refuse. His knuckles brushed the strand of hair from her lips. The touch travelled across her skin long after his fingers moved away.

"That you hold your breath before asking a question you care about," he said.

She exhaled.

His hand remained beside her face, not touching now. The restraint in it was more seductive than confidence. Naina leaned a fraction toward his palm. His thumb met the edge of her jaw.

The contact was gentle, almost formal. Her body answered with humiliating clarity. Heat moved through her chest and settled beneath her ribs. She became aware of his thigh against hers, the roughness of his skin, the scent of sun and photographic chemicals on his shirt.

"Naina," he said.

It was a question spoken in her name.

She turned her face into his hand.

His thumb traced once beneath her lower lip. Her eyes closed. For one breath, then another, she allowed the moment to become exactly what it was. When she opened them, Ayaan was closer. Not taking. Waiting.

A door opened below them.

Naina moved back.

The guesthouse owner emerged onto the stairs with two glasses of tea and no apparent awareness that he had interrupted anything. Ayaan lowered his hand. Naina accepted a glass she did not want and burned her tongue because she drank too quickly.

They returned to work.

The next morning he behaved with such careful normality that she wanted to slap him or kiss him, preferably in that order. Instead she corrected his captions. He disputed her transliteration. By lunch they had rebuilt the boundary between them using scholarship and irritation.

Neither mentioned the roof.

Three weeks later, outside Barmer, a rusted gate solved what restraint had postponed.

They had spent the afternoon documenting a community well abandoned after the water turned saline. Sand filled the upper steps. Thorn branches had been pushed across the entrance to keep animals from falling in. When Ayaan climbed over the side wall to photograph the lowest landing, the gate shifted and tore the heel of his hand on a broken iron hook.

He wrapped the cut in a handkerchief and insisted it was nothing until blood soaked through the cloth.

"Sit," Naina said when they returned to the government rest house.

"You become authoritarian near first-aid boxes."

“I become authoritarian near stupidity.”

“Then I am fortunate you remain so gentle with me.”

The caretaker had left a bottle of antiseptic, cotton, and one roll of expired gauze in the dining room. Naina sat opposite Ayaan beneath a fluorescent tube that attracted every moth in the district. She took his wrist and placed his hand palm-up on the table.

The cut was not deep, but it curved across the base of his thumb. Sand remained embedded at the edge.

“This will hurt,” she said.

“You say that as if you are looking forward to it.”

“I am looking forward to you being quiet.”

She cleaned the wound. Ayaan's fingers tightened once around hers, then relaxed. He watched her instead of the injury.

“What?” Naina asked.

“Nothing.”

“That is rarely true when you are looking at someone.”

“You are very careful with damaged things.”

“You are not a damaged thing.”

“I was speaking generally.”

She glanced up. “No, you weren't.”

The fluorescent light made intimacy impossible, which perhaps was why it arrived. A cook sang in the distant kitchen. A ceiling fan clicked above them. Ayaan's damp shirt smelled of dust and sun. Naina became acutely aware that his wrist remained inside her hand, pulse moving against her fingers.

“My father left when I was twelve,” he said.

She stilled.

He had mentioned his mother and his sisters, never his father.

“Where did he go?”

“Dubai first. Then another family, as far as we know.”

“I'm sorry.”

“I hate when people say that.”

“I can disinfect the sentence if it helps.”

His mouth curved. “My mother called him restless. For years I thought it was a compliment.”

Naina wound clean gauze around his palm. "Is that why you never stay anywhere?"

"Probably."

"At least you are honest."

"Am I?"

The question turned in the space between them.

She tied the bandage. "About leaving."

"Not always about wanting to stay."

Naina's hands stopped around his.

Ayaan stood, slowly enough that she could have released him. She did not. The table remained between them, its edge pressing into her thighs. He lifted their joined hands and turned hers over, examining the pale line where her measuring tape had rubbed the skin raw.

"You are hurt too," he said.

"That is not an injury."

"You don't get to decide that only for yourself."

His bandaged thumb passed carefully over the mark. Naina felt the touch in places far from her palm.

He moved around the table.

When he stopped before her, their hands remained joined at her waist. Naina had to tilt her head to meet his eyes. The room seemed suddenly too bright and too quiet. She could see a grain of sand caught near his collar, the slight unevenness of his breath.

"If I kiss you," he said, "will you tell me tomorrow that I misunderstood?"

The question removed every excuse except truth.

Naina wanted him. She wanted the unfamiliar pressure of his mouth, the end of months spent pretending that attention had not become hunger. Her free hand rose to his chest and felt his heart striking beneath the cotton.

Then a phone began ringing inside her bag.

Raghav's name lit the screen.

She had told him that morning they would speak after the survey. He had remembered the hour despite a client dinner in Mumbai.

Ayaan looked at the phone, then at her.

He did not let go first.

Naina stepped back.

"I have to answer."

“I know.”

She took the call in the corridor while Ayaan remained beside the first-aid box. Raghav asked about the well, her return date, whether the rest house had a proper lock. He listened to her complain about the missing survey records and offered to contact someone in the district office.

His care was practical, immediate, and freely given.

When Naina returned, the dining room was empty. Ayaan had left the used gauze folded neatly beside the bottle.

The next morning he photographed only architecture.

But afterward their restraint had texture. A hand at her back while crossing a broken stair. His knee against hers in crowded jeeps. The weight of her head on his shoulder during a six-hour train delay. Each accidental touch carried the memory of one that had not been accidental at all.

On their final assignment, they reached Chand Baori after closing with special permission from the district office. The tourists had gone. The stone descended beneath them in impossible symmetry, thousands of narrow steps crossing like folded cloth.

Ayaan set up his tripod at the eastern edge.

“Stand there,” he told her.

“No people in the documentation frames.”

“This isn’t documentation.”

“What is it?”

He looked through the viewfinder. “Proof.”

“Of what?”

“That you were here.”

She should have laughed. Instead she stood where he pointed.

The photograph took a thirtieth of a second. The waiting around it lasted years.

Ayaan checked the frame and frowned.

“Again,” he said.

“You said you needed proof, not perfection.”

“I need you to stop looking as if someone has ordered you to be here.”

“Someone did.”

He lowered the camera. “Then come down.”

They descended together through the geometric corridors of steps. Evening gathered in the well before it reached the sky. Their footsteps echoed from opposite walls, multiplying until it sounded as if other versions of them followed at a distance.

At the lowest accessible landing, a shallow pool reflected the carved balconies far above. Ayaan sat with his back against the stone and stretched his legs before him.

"The light is going," Naina said.

"It does that every day."

"We have permits until six."

"It is five-forty."

"You checked?"

"No. I know exactly how long you can remain still before becoming anxious."

Naina sat beside him, leaving a careful space that disappeared when he shifted his shoulder against hers.

"What happens after the exhibition?" he asked.

"I return to Hyderabad. I have two hotel projects waiting."

"And after those?"

"More projects."

"That sounds like an inventory, not a life."

"You are going to Delhi for one assignment and then another. Your life is literally an inventory."

"I did not say mine was better."

Above them, pigeons crossed the square of sky. Naina watched their shadows pass over the steps.

"Raghav wants to marry me," she said.

The sentence had not been planned. It entered the well and returned in pieces.

Ayaan remained motionless. "Has he asked?"

"Not exactly."

"Then how do you know?"

"Because he says what he wants before it becomes urgent."

"And what do you want?"

She turned toward him. "You ask that as if you have no stake in the answer."

His jaw tightened. "I am trying not to invent one."

"Perhaps you should risk it."

For a moment the confession seemed close enough to touch. Ayaan's hand lay on the stone between them, palm down. Naina placed her fingertips beside it, not touching. He turned his hand over.

The caretaker's whistle sounded from the upper gate.

Neither moved.

It sounded again, more impatiently.

Ayaan closed his fingers around hers once, hard enough to make the choice visible, then released them.

"Come," he said. "We should take the photograph before he arrests us."

At the eastern edge, Naina stood again where he directed. This time she looked into the lens knowing who waited behind it.

The shutter opened and closed.

"Proof," Ayaan said softly.

That night, at a guesthouse with green walls and a roof that held the day's heat, Naina received Raghav's proposal.

She had met Raghav four months before the project began, at an industry dinner in Hyderabad. He was direct without being crude, successful without apologizing for enjoying success, and interested in Naina with a steadiness that required no interpretation. While Ayaan vanished into light and work, Raghav called when he said he would. He remembered her mother's surgery date. He sent a carpenter to repair a warped window in her apartment after she mentioned it once.

He did not make her wonder.

His proposal came as a message because he knew she would dislike a public performance.

I know what I want. I think you do too. Come home and marry me.

Naina read it on the roof while Ayaan slept with his back against the water tank, exhausted after copying files until dawn.

She waited for him to wake.

When he did, he spoke first.

"Delhi called," he said. "The border assignment is confirmed."

"When?"

"I leave tomorrow."

Tomorrow was supposed to be the day they assembled their final exhibition proposal. It was also, though neither had said it aloud, the last day they would have no itinerary between them.

“For how long?” she asked.

“Three months. Maybe four.”

He looked happy. Not thoughtless—Ayaan was rarely thoughtless—but lit from within by the work ahead of him.

Naina placed the phone face down on the parapet.

“That’s good,” she said.

“It could be.”

“It’s what you wanted.”

He studied her, perhaps hearing the door close and not understanding where it was.

“Come with me to Delhi first,” he said.

“For the exhibition?”

“For—” He stopped.

The silence widened.

Say it, she thought.

He looked toward the waking town, where milk scooters moved through blue smoke.

“For a few days,” he finished.

Naina picked up her phone.

Raghav’s message remained on the screen, patient and complete.

“I’m going home,” she said.

“Home where?”

It was the wrong question.

She left that afternoon.

Three weeks later she accepted Raghav’s ring. Two months later Ayaan sent a link to the published stepwell essay. The byline carried only his name, though the photographs included measurements derived from her drawings. He had thanked “N.R.” in the acknowledgements.

She did not reply.

He wrote twice more. The first email apologized for the magazine’s refusal to add a second byline. The second asked whether she was happy.

She deleted neither. She answered neither.

On the morning of her wedding, a courier delivered the blue notebook she had left in Ayaan's camera bag.

Inside the cover he had written one sentence.

You were here.

Naina placed the notebook beneath her silk saris and went downstairs to marry a man who had never made her wait.

Now, at Surya Garh, she woke before dawn with the sentence intact in her memory.

Raghav slept beside her, one arm extended into the space she had left. His face in sleep was younger, stripped of confidence and calculation. Tenderness moved through her with painful familiarity.

She had not built a false marriage.

That would have been easier.

She had built a real marriage around one locked room.

Outside, rain began softly against the lake.

Chapter Four

The Sangeet Storm

At six-thirty, Naina stood before the mirror in their suite while Raghav attempted to fasten the back of her blouse.

"There are too many hooks," he said.

"There are six."

"That is too many for a garment designed to appear as though it contains no engineering."

His fingers brushed the bare line of her spine. The first hook caught, then slipped free. Naina watched him in the mirror: head bent in concentration, mouth tightened as if negotiating a contract. She remembered those hands unpinning her hair on their honeymoon, impatient with every clip, and the memory warmed her despite herself.

"You are enjoying my failure," he said.

"A little."

"Turn around."

She faced him. The blouse remained open at her back, held in place by one hand across her chest. Raghav looked at her, and the humour left his expression.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing."

"That is a very specific nothing."

He touched the bare skin above her waist, two fingers tracing the place where the silk skirt began. The gesture was unhurried, possessive only in the old, mutually understood way. Naina's breath shifted. His eyes followed it.

"We could miss the first dance," he said.

"Meera would have us publicly executed."

"She is distracted by jewellery."

"You have a meeting."

The words escaped before she could soften them.

Raghav's hand stopped. "Had."

"You said twenty minutes at dinner."

"It became forty. I apologized."

"You came to bed after one."

"You were asleep."

"I was pretending."

Silence settled between them, made stranger by her half-dressed body and his hand still resting against her waist.

"Why?" he asked.

"Because if I was awake, we would have had this conversation."

"And now is better?"

"No. Now you are touching me, so apparently I am easier to distract."

He drew his hand away.

Immediately, she missed it.

Raghav sat on the edge of the bed. "This weekend matters."

"To Meera."

"To us. Dev's father is considering a restoration partnership across twelve properties. If it happens, I can build the heritage division instead of spending another five years advising people who ignore me."

"You did not tell me that."

"I am telling you now."

"While I hold my clothes closed."

He laughed once, without amusement. "There is never a correct setting with you. Every conversation needs archaeological preparation."

The accusation struck because it resembled something Ayaan might once have said. Naina turned back to the mirror.

"Fasten this, please."

Raghav stood behind her again. This time his fingers were efficient. Six hooks, secured without contact beyond necessity.

She adjusted the fabric over her shoulders. "Congratulations."

"Nothing has happened yet."

"Then I will congratulate you when you decide I need to know."

He met her eyes in the mirror. "Is this really about my meeting?"

"What else would it be about?"

"You tell me."

Neither said Ayaan's name.

Raghav picked up the necklace laid across the dressing table. "May I?"

Naina lifted her hair. He placed the gold chain around her throat and closed the clasp. His knuckles grazed her nape. A shiver moved across her skin before she could prevent it.

Their eyes met again.

He bent and kissed the place his fingers had touched.

The kiss was slow enough to be an apology and practiced enough to be a warning. Naina closed her eyes. Raghav's mouth moved once along the curve where neck met shoulder. His hands settled at her hips, drawing her back against him.

For several breaths, she let desire erase the argument. She felt the hard line of his body, the familiar pressure of his fingers through silk, the quiet sound he made when she turned within his arms. Their marriage still knew this language. That was part of what made its silences so difficult to forgive.

He kissed her mouth. She answered, then deepened it with an urgency that surprised them both. Raghav's palm moved up her bare back until the newly fastened hooks stopped him.

"Too many," he murmured against her lips.

Naina laughed, breathless despite her anger.

A knock sounded at the door.

"Naina!" Meera called from the corridor. "If you are dressed, I require architectural and emotional support. If you are not dressed, become dressed."

Raghav rested his forehead against Naina's. The moment loosened but did not disappear.

"After the sangeet," he said.

She wanted to believe him. "After the sangeet."

He stepped back and straightened her necklace. By the time she opened the door, they looked like a composed married couple again.

The corridor outside had become a dressing room for half the wedding. Children raced past with LED bangles blinking around their wrists. An aunt stood before an antique mirror while two nieces argued over the position of her dupatta. Somewhere on the floor below, the groom's cousins rehearsed the same eight counts and failed at the same turn.

Meera caught sight of Raghav behind Naina and narrowed her eyes theatrically.

"You delayed my architect."

"Your architect has contractual obligations elsewhere," Raghav said.

"I was not aware she was leased."

Naina took Meera's arm before the exchange acquired meaning. "What collapsed?"

"The stage manager's confidence. Also one decorative arch, but apparently that is less important."

They walked toward the stairs. Raghav followed for several steps, then his phone vibrated.

Naina felt him stop without looking back.

"Go," she said.

He hesitated. "Five minutes."

"Of course."

She heard the disappointment in her own voice and wished she had hidden it better. Raghav slipped the phone into his pocket instead.

"No," he said. "It can wait."

He came down the stairs with them.

The choice was small enough that no one else noticed. Naina did. For the next half hour, he remained beside her while cousins practiced their entrances and a choreographer assigned married guests positions in the final dance. Raghav deliberately missed a step to make her laugh. When she corrected his wrist, he caught her fingers and kissed them.

At the far end of the ballroom, Ayaan photographed the rehearsal.

Naina became conscious of being watched, then realized his camera was aimed at Meera. The distinction should have relieved her. Instead it made her want his attention back.

The wanting arrived without permission and therefore without dignity.

During a break, Ayaan crossed behind them to reach the stage. The strap of his camera brushed Naina's bare arm. It might have been accidental. He turned immediately.

"Sorry."

"It's fine."

His gaze met hers, then moved to Raghav's hand around her waist.

Raghav nodded toward the camera. "Did she order you to delete another one?"

The question was casual. Naina felt the floor alter beneath it.

Ayaan did not look at her. "Only one."

"She has strong editorial control."

“She always did.”

The choreographer called Raghav back into position before silence could expose them. He went, smiling, but his hand left Naina's waist more slowly than before.

Meera appeared at her side. “I have made several poor decisions this week.”

“This is not the time to list them.”

“Inviting both of them may be near the top.”

“You think?”

“I thought unfinished things became less dangerous when placed in daylight.”

Naina watched Ayaan climb onto the stage and kneel to photograph the musicians tuning their instruments. “Some things only become visible.”

By seven in the evening the sky had turned the colour of bruised metal.

The wedding planners treated the weather as a lighting problem.

Technicians covered cables with plastic. Waiters moved the champagne tower three metres beneath the arcade. Someone distributed transparent umbrellas printed with Meera and Dev's initials. The sangeet stage, built on a floating platform at the edge of the lake, continued to pulse pink and gold while thunder rolled behind the hills.

“It will pass,” Dev said for the fifth time.

“That is not how weather works,” Naina told him.

“It is how weddings work. Nothing can happen unless the schedule permits it.”

Meera appeared beside them in a mirror-work lehenga. “I have scheduled the storm for after the family medley.”

She looked radiant and slightly unreal. Around her left ankle was a heavy silver anklet that had belonged to her grandmother; the right was bare.

“You lost one,” Naina said.

Meera looked down. “No. No, no, no.”

The anklets were the only family jewellery Meera had insisted on wearing. The missing one had last been seen during photographs in the old blue pavilion that afternoon.

“I'll send someone,” Dev said.

“Everyone is already doing something,” Meera replied. “And if your father finds out we entered the closed wing, he'll turn it into a committee meeting.”

“I'll go,” Naina said.

Meera caught her wrist. “Not alone.”

“It's across the causeway, not a mountain.”

“The rain—”

“Hasn’t started.”

“Take Ayaan. He knows the wing.”

The suggestion arrived too smoothly.

Naina looked at her friend. Meera’s face held only bridal panic.

“Where is he?” Naina asked.

Ayaan was photographing the groom’s cousins near the stage. When Naina explained, he glanced at the clouds, then at the causeway.

“We have twenty minutes,” he said.

“You sound very certain.”

“I’ve been watching the rain line.”

“Of course you have.”

He handed one camera to his assistant and kept the smaller one beneath his shawl. “Let’s go.”

Raghav intercepted them at the colonnade.

“Where are you disappearing?”

“Meera lost an anklet in the old wing,” Naina said.

“Send staff.”

“It will take ten minutes.”

“In that?” He pointed toward the sky.

Before she could answer, a crash sounded near the bar. An elderly man had collapsed beside a table.

The courtyard shifted instantly from celebration to alarm. Raghav was moving before anyone called for help. Years earlier, before business school and consulting, he had completed two years of medical training; in emergencies, the abandoned education returned to his hands.

“Call the hotel doctor,” he ordered. “Give him space.”

He knelt beside the man and looked up at Naina. “Stay here.”

It was not command so much as confidence that she would understand where she was useful.

She did. That was part of the problem.

The doctor arrived. The man was conscious by the time staff brought a stretcher, but his pulse remained irregular. Raghav went with them toward the main driveway, supporting the oxygen cylinder.

"I'll call you," he told Naina.

Then he was gone.

Ayaan had waited beneath the arch.

"We can leave the anklet," he said.

Naina looked at Meera, who stood barefoot on one side beneath the stage lights, surrounded by anxious relatives.

"Ten minutes," she said.

They crossed the causeway as the first drops struck the lake.

The stone path was wide enough for two people, but wind forced them toward its centre. Water slapped the lower blocks on both sides. The palace behind them glowed with the impossible colour of celebration—pink stage lights, amber windows, white bursts from guests' phones.

Ayaan walked half a pace ahead, testing each dark patch before Naina reached it. He did not offer his hand.

"You don't have to inspect the road for me," she said.

"I am inspecting it for the cameras."

"They can swim."

"You cannot."

"I can swim."

He looked back. Rain had begun to shine in his hair. "You hate deep water."

Naina nearly missed a step.

"That was nine years ago."

"Does it expire?"

"People change."

"Yes."

The single word held too much agreement.

Wind caught the loose end of her dupatta and flung it across her face. Naina pulled it free, but the embroidered edge snagged on the strap of Ayaan's camera. They stopped.

"Wait," he said.

His fingers worked at the thread near her shoulder. The path left no room to step away without moving closer to the water. Naina stood still while his knuckles brushed the fabric above her collarbone.

The touch was accidental. Her response was not.

She felt it as a tightening beneath her skin, an alertness that began at the point of contact and moved downward. Ayaan's breath changed. He lifted his gaze to hers, hand still caught between the strap and her dupatta.

Behind them, music swelled from the stage. Someone cheered. For a suspended moment the wedding seemed very far away, though its lights reflected on every wave around them.

"There," Ayaan said.

He freed the thread and let the fabric fall.

Naina gathered it against her chest. "Thank you."

"We should move faster."

"Because of the rain?"

"Yes."

Neither pretended the answer was complete.

Neel Mahal smelled of wet stone and closed rooms. Ayaan unlocked the outer gate with a key from the photography office. Inside, their footsteps disturbed months of dust.

"The pavilion is upstairs," he said.

"I remember seeing it."

"You were watching me?"

"I was looking at the building."

"Of course."

Lightning opened the corridor in white. A second later thunder shook dust from the ceiling.

They climbed a narrow staircase to the pavilion. Cushions from the afternoon shoot remained stacked against one wall. Brass lamps had been abandoned on a bench. There was no anklet.

Naina checked behind the cushions while Ayaan used his phone torch beneath the furniture.

"Nothing," he said.

"Maybe one of the assistants took it back."

Her phone showed no signal. She crossed to the jharokha.

Rain had erased the far end of the lake. The palace lights appeared as blurred gold shapes behind a moving wall of water.

"We should go," Ayaan said.

They were halfway down the stairs when every electric light in Neel Mahal went out.

Darkness closed over them.

Naina stopped. Ayaan's hand found her forearm—not pulling, only locating her.

"Step down," he said. "There's a landing behind you."

His touch was warm through the silk sleeve.

She descended. He released her immediately.

At the ground-floor arch, wind drove rain across the courtyard with such force that they had to turn their faces away. Water streamed over the flagstones.

Ayaan shone his torch toward the causeway.

For a moment Naina could not understand what had changed.

Then lightning came again.

The middle section of the stone path had vanished beneath brown, violent water.

"The lake has overtopped it," Ayaan said.

"How deep?"

"It doesn't matter. The current is crossing sideways."

"There must be another route."

"The lower road."

They ran through the gate and down the outer steps. Halfway to the road, a palace jeep approached from the far side, headlights shaking through rain. It stopped before a fallen neem tree that blocked the bend.

A security guard leaned from the window and shouted, but the storm tore his words apart. He pointed upward—back to Neel Mahal—then crossed both arms above his head.

"Road's closed," Ayaan said.

"I understood that."

The guard raised his phone and pointed to it.

Naina's phone began to ring.

Raghav.

She answered with rain running into her eyes. "We're at the old wing."

"Why?" His voice broke beneath static.

"The anklet. The causeway is flooded."

"Get inside. Now."

"The lower road—"

"Blocked. They're evacuating the lakeside stage. I'm at the clinic with Mr. Sethi. He's stable, but the ambulance can't get back yet."

“How long until the water drops?”

Someone spoke urgently near him.

“Naina, listen to me. The old residence is above the flood line. Stay inside with the staff.”

She looked at Ayaan. The guard’s jeep was reversing. There was no one else on their side of the fallen tree.

“The staff crossed back,” she said.

Static swallowed his reply.

“Raghav?”

The call ended.

A message arrived a few seconds later.

STAY INSIDE. I WILL GET TO YOU.

Naina stared at the words until rain made the screen unresponsive.

Behind them, the shutters of Neel Mahal struck the walls like applause.

“We need to secure the courtyard doors,” Ayaan said.

Naina followed him inside.

Together they pushed the heavy gate against the wind. It closed with a deep iron sound, cutting off the headlights, the palace, and every visible route back.

For the first time since she had seen him beneath the entrance arch, they were entirely alone.

Chapter Five

The Broken Causeway

The first thing they did was behave sensibly.

They checked every ground-floor room for leaks. They found two emergency lanterns in the caretaker's office, a sealed water container, six packets of glucose biscuits, a first-aid tin, three wool blankets that smelled of camphor, and a box of candles softened by summer heat. Ayaan bolted the western shutters. Naina moved ledgers and rolled drawings away from a spreading patch of damp.

Practical work gave them a language with no past tense.

They moved through the rooms in opposite directions and met repeatedly at thresholds. Each encounter required a small negotiation—who would step back, who would carry the lantern, who would hold a door against the wind. Naina became aware of Ayaan's body through its usefulness: the reach of his arms when he secured a high latch, the strength in his shoulders as he dragged a cedar chest away from the leaking wall, the care with which he lifted waterlogged papers one sheet at a time.

Once, while they were pushing the archive table beneath a dry section of ceiling, his hand closed over hers on the same edge.

"Sorry," he said.

Neither moved at first.

His palm was rougher than she remembered. The band of warmth across her knuckles seemed absurdly distinct in the cold room. Naina withdrew her hand and took the other side of the table.

"On three," she said.

They moved it without looking at each other.

When the essential work was done, Ayaan opened the glucose biscuits and divided them with the seriousness of a relief officer.

"Four for you," he said. "Two for me."

"Why?"

"You missed dinner."

"So did you."

"I ate while changing memory cards."

"That is not dinner."

“It contained carbohydrates and despair. Very similar to most wedding buffets.”

She took three biscuits and pushed the packet back. They ate standing at the table while the rain erased the view beyond the shutters. The food was dry enough to hurt her mouth. Ayaan passed her the water container before she asked.

“You still forget to drink when you are working,” he said.

“You still narrate other people's flaws to avoid your own.”

“Mine require a longer night.”

“We may have one.”

The words entered the room differently from how she intended. Ayaan looked at her, biscuit forgotten between his fingers.

Naina drank from the metal cup. “I meant the storm.”

“I know what you meant.”

The fact that he did not smile made the correction feel less successful.

“That beam is carrying more than it should,” Naina said.

“Will it hold?”

“Tonight, probably.”

“Comforting.”

“Architecture is mostly honest uncertainty.”

“You used to say it was controlled hope.”

She looked at him.

He was tying a plastic sheet over a broken lattice. “I remember things,” he said.

“That doesn't mean you understood them.”

“Also something you used to say.”

The storm deepened. Rain fell through the centre of the courtyard in a solid silver column, striking the old fountain and overflowing its basin. Water crept beneath the southern doors, but the archive room on the upper level remained dry.

At 9:18, Naina's phone found a signal long enough to deliver fourteen messages.

The wedding group had been moved into the main ballroom. The elderly guest was stable at a clinic five kilometres away. Meera had sent six apologies about the anklet and one photograph showing it fastened around her ankle.

FOUND IT IN MY DRESSING ROOM. I AM SO SORRY. PLEASE TELL ME YOU ARE OKAY.

Naina read the message twice.

"It was never here," she said.

Ayaan glanced up from his phone. "What?"

She showed him.

"Then someone remembered wrong."

"Meera said the last photograph was in the pavilion."

"It was. The anklet was on her then."

"You noticed?"

"I photographed it."

Naina typed a reply to Meera, but the message would not send.

"Raghav?" Ayaan asked.

"At the clinic."

"He'll be worried."

"Yes."

"You should keep trying."

"I know."

His restraint irritated her more than presumption would have.

"You don't have to perform decency for me," she said.

Ayaan became still. "Is that what you think I'm doing?"

"I don't know what you're doing."

"I'm standing in a leaking building, trying to send my mother a message before she sees the weather report."

The answer embarrassed her. "Fine."

"And I'm trying not to make this harder for you."

"You have no idea what is hard for me."

"No," he said. "You made sure of that."

Thunder filled the room before she could answer.

They stood on opposite sides of the table, lit by one emergency lantern. Rain rattled the shutters. The sensible tasks were finished.

Naina crossed her arms. "You published the work without me."

Ayaan blinked, as if he had expected any accusation except the old one.

"The magazine refused a joint credit."

"So you accepted a single one."

"After you stopped answering."

“You had my drawings.”

“I credited the research.”

“You used initials.”

“You were engaged. Your mother told me you didn’t want contact.”

Naina’s breath caught. “You spoke to my mother?”

“I called your apartment after the third email.”

“She never told me.”

“Would it have changed anything?”

“That isn’t the point.”

“It is exactly the point.” He came around the table, then stopped several feet away. “I sent the final layouts. I asked the editor to delay. I asked if you wanted your name, your firm’s name, or no association at all. You said nothing.”

“I was getting married.”

“Yes.”

One word. No accusation. The absence of anger made hers look theatrical.

Naina turned toward the shuttered window. “You left.”

“For an assignment.”

“The morning after our project ended.”

“The project had ended.”

“Exactly.”

He exhaled slowly. “What did you want me to do?”

She almost laughed. Nine years of marriage, two homes, four promotions between them, one father buried, one mother recovered, and the question could still split her open.

“I wanted you to know,” she said.

“Know what?”

“Without making me say it.”

Ayaan looked at her for a long time.

“That is a cruel standard,” he said quietly.

“I know.”

The admission altered the room.

He sat on the edge of the archive table. Water had darkened the shoulders of his kurta. A thin cut crossed one knuckle where the shutter latch had slipped.

"I wanted you to come to Delhi," he said.

"For a few days."

"I was afraid if I asked for more, you would say no."

"So you asked for less."

"Yes."

"And I said no anyway."

"Yes."

For the first time that night, they smiled. It was not happiness. It was recognition of the same wreck from opposite sides.

Naina's phone rang.

Raghav's name illuminated the table between them.

She answered at once.

"I'm fine," she said.

"Are you inside?"

"Upstairs. The building is dry."

"Thank God. Who is with you?"

The signal distorted his voice, but not the question.

Naina looked at Ayaan.

He turned away, offering privacy the room could not provide.

"Ayaan," she said.

There was a pause.

"The photographer?"

"Yes."

"Anyone else?"

"No."

Another pause, shorter than the first.

"All right. The security team says the causeway won't be safe before morning. They may be able to reach you from the northern road if the tree is cleared."

"Where are you?"

"Still at the clinic. Mr. Sethi's family is panicking, and Dev asked me to stay until the cardiologist arrives."

"Of course."

"What does that mean?"

“It means of course you should stay.”

“Naina—”

A burst of static interrupted him.

“I can’t hear you.”

“I said I love you.”

She closed her eyes.

“I love you too.”

The answer was true. That was what made it dangerous.

“Keep your phone dry,” Raghav said. “Call me if anything changes.”

The line died.

Naina placed the phone face down.

Ayaan remained near the window. “You didn’t have to tell him I was here.”

“Yes, I did.”

“I know.”

“Then why say it?”

He turned. “Because there are two different nights available to us. In one, the storm traps us and everything becomes an excuse. In the other, we know exactly where we are.”

Naina felt suddenly cold in her wet clothes.

“Nothing is going to happen,” she said.

“I didn’t say it would.”

“You implied it.”

“No. You heard it.”

The lantern flickered.

He crossed to the supply box, took out one of the wool blankets, and placed it on the table between them without touching her.

“There are dry clothes in the caretaker’s cupboard downstairs,” he said. “Probably uniforms. Change before you get sick. I’ll wait in the corridor.”

When he left, Naina locked the archive door.

The gesture was automatic. So was the disappointment that followed it.

She stripped off the rain-heavy silk and dried herself with the least dusty section of blanket. In the cupboard she found a white cotton kurta several sizes too large and drawstring trousers. They smelled of storage but were dry.

Her green glass bangles had cracked in the run through the rain. She removed them one by one and arranged the unbroken pieces on the table.

The woman reflected in the dark window wore a stranger's clothes and no symbols anyone at the wedding would recognize.

For one second, absurdly, she thought of the photograph Ayaan had taken at Chand Baori.

Proof that you were here.

She opened the door.

Ayaan sat on the floor across the corridor, his back against the wall. He had changed into a faded caretaker's shirt and kept his wet trousers. His eyes lifted to her face, then moved away before the borrowed clothes could become intimate.

"Better?" he asked.

"Dryer."

Water slid from the ends of her hair and darkened the borrowed kurta at her shoulders. Ayaan reached toward the supply cupboard, found a folded cotton cloth, and held it out.

"For your hair."

Naina took it without letting their fingers meet. "Thank you."

She sat at the opposite end of the corridor and began squeezing rain from the heavy strands. The practical action did nothing to reduce her awareness of him. The caretaker's shirt fit closely across his damp shoulders. One sleeve was rolled above the cut on his hand. Without the cameras, shawl, and deliberate professional distance, he looked less like the man she had encountered at the wedding and more like the one her body remembered from unfinished journeys.

"Your hand is bleeding again," she said.

He glanced at it. "It will stop."

"That is not medical care."

"Neither is staring at it."

Naina fetched the first-aid tin. She knelt before him because the corridor left no graceful alternative.

"Give me your hand."

"You don't have to."

"I know."

He placed his hand in hers.

The cut was shallow, crossing the ridge of his knuckle. Naina cleaned it with antiseptic. Ayaan's fingers flexed once around nothing.

"Does it hurt?"

"Not the antiseptic."

She looked up.

He was watching her bent head, the wet hair over one shoulder, the loose neckline of the unfamiliar kurta. His gaze rose immediately to her eyes, but not before she understood.

The understanding moved through her like heat beneath cold skin.

"Don't," she said.

"I'm not doing anything."

"That has always been your defence."

"And yours."

She wrapped gauze around his hand with more force than necessary.

"Too tight," he said.

"You survived a camel."

"The camel was kinder."

Despite herself, she smiled. Ayaan's thumb rested against the inside of her wrist. He could have claimed it was necessary to steady his hand. He did not make the claim.

Her pulse struck beneath the pad of his thumb.

Neither moved.

The corridor lamp trembled in the wind. Naina became acutely conscious of her knees between his, of the thin borrowed cloth against her skin, of how little effort it would take to close the remaining distance. She imagined his uninjured hand at the back of her neck. The image arrived complete and physical: his mouth warm against hers, the rasp of his damp beard, her fingers opening the buttons of the caretaker's shirt.

Desire was not subtle when finally allowed a room.

She tied the bandage and sat back.

Ayaan released her wrist at once.

"Say it," he said.

"Say what?"

"Whatever you need me to understand without making you ask."

The echo of their earlier argument stripped the moment of fantasy.

Naina closed the first-aid tin. "I need you not to turn restraint into seduction."

He absorbed the sentence without defending himself. "All right."

"And I need you not to agree so beautifully that it becomes the same thing."

His mouth almost curved. "That may be beyond my control."

"Try."

"I will."

She rose, carrying the tin. At the archive door, he spoke again.

"For what it is worth, Naina, wanting you is not a strategy."

Her hand tightened around the metal handle.

"That does not make it harmless."

"No."

The word held no attempt to comfort her.

Naina stood with her back to him, listening to the rain strike the courtyard. She could feel the warmth of his thumb at her wrist as if the touch remained there.

"Raghav and I were happy before we became efficient," she said.

Ayaan said nothing.

"You are supposed to tell me that does not matter."

"Why?"

"Because it would make you easier to dislike."

"I am not competing with the worst version of your marriage."

She turned. "You are competing?"

His face tightened at his own word. "No. That is not what I meant."

"It is what you said."

"Then I said it badly." He looked down at the clean bandage around his hand. "I don't want him to have failed you. If he failed completely, you could choose me without ever knowing whether you wanted me or merely wanted the nearest opposite."

The honesty removed the seduction from the room and left something more dangerous.

"You assume I am choosing," she said.

"You choose every time you stay."

"Marriage is not a series of exits."

"No. It is a series of returns."

Naina remembered Raghav asleep with one hand extended into her empty half of the bed. She remembered his mouth at her neck before the sangeet, her body answering with the ease of long practice. Desire for Ayaan did not cancel any of it. It simply refused to remain outside the account.

“I love him,” she said.

“I know.”

“You keep saying that.”

“Because you keep needing it to be true in the room with us.”

She looked away first.

She returned the first-aid tin to the table. The silence afterward was different from the ones before it. Desire had been named, and naming it had not made it smaller. It had only removed their ability to pretend they were guarding against an imaginary danger.

“The northern gate is visible from the roof pavilion. I’m going to see if the road crew has lights.”

“In this wind?”

“The inner staircase is covered.”

“The pavilion roof is not.”

“I won’t go outside.”

“You said that exactly like someone planning to go outside.”

He smiled faintly. “You still hear the unsaid part.”

“Only when it is obvious.”

They climbed together.

At the upper landing, a narrow door opened onto the domed pavilion. Wind pulled it from Ayaan’s grip and slammed it against the wall. Rain sprayed across the floor.

Beyond the parapet, the lake and sky had become a single black surface. No road lights showed to the north. The main palace glowed across the floodwater, close enough to measure and unreachable.

Ayaan stepped toward the outer ledge.

Naina caught his hand.

“Don’t.”

He looked down at their joined hands.

So did she.

This was not an accident in darkness. Neither had mistaken the other for someone else. There was no social confusion to hide inside, no innocence provided by weather.

Naina loosened her fingers but did not release him.

“There is nothing you can see from there that is worth falling for,” she said.

His thumb moved once against the side of her hand. A question, not an answer.

“That sentence has improved with age,” he said.

She let go.

Together they pulled the pavilion door shut and lowered the wooden bar across it.

When they returned to the archive, water had entered beneath the corridor windows. Ayaan spread the second blanket on the floor while Naina lit two candles. Their phones had no signal. The emergency lantern dimmed to orange.

“We should sleep in shifts,” he said.

“Why?”

“In case the water rises.”

“Or in case one of us becomes dangerous?”

He met her gaze. “Do you think I am?”

Naina considered the question honestly.

Outside, the causeway lay beneath the flood. The lower road was blocked. Her husband was kilometres away. Ayaan sat within reach, carrying a version of her life no one else had witnessed.

“Not in the way you mean,” she said.

The last of the lantern light went out.

In the candlelit room, the rain sounded less like weather than a thousand locked doors opening at once.

Chapter Six

What We Did Not Say

For several minutes after the lantern died, neither of them moved.

The candles reduced the archive room to a small circle: table, blankets, two borrowed sets of clothes, and the faces of people who had once known how to speak to each other.

Ayaan checked his phone. “No signal.”

“Mine either.”

“We should conserve the batteries.”

Naina switched hers to airplane mode. The screen went dark with Raghav’s last message still unanswered.

They divided the first watch without discussion. Ayaan would remain awake until midnight; Naina would take the hours after. She lay beneath one blanket on the dry side of the room and listened to him move the buckets whenever a new leak found the ceiling.

“You’re not sleeping,” he said.

“Neither are you.”

“I’m on watch.”

“For water or bad decisions?”

He sat against the archive cabinet. “Whichever rises faster.”

She should not have smiled. She did.

Rain hammered the palace into isolation. With no view of the main hotel, Naina began to imagine the wedding continuing without them: cousins rehearsing in corridors, Meera arguing with decorators, Raghav making himself useful to strangers. Her husband always became essential in a crisis. At home, where nothing dramatic required saving, he often seemed less certain what to do.

“Tell me about your life,” Ayaan said.

“You can find it online.”

“Your firm’s website says you create meaningful environments for premium brands.”

“That is what I do.”

“It is what your website says.”

Naina sat up. "And yours says you bear witness to lives at the edge of history. We both pay people to make us sound unbearable."

He laughed quietly.

The sound stripped nine years from the room.

"I left the firm," she said.

"When?"

"Three months ago."

"Why?"

"Because I designed the same hotel lobby in four cities and everyone called it expansion."

"Does Raghav know why?"

"He knows I wanted a break."

"That wasn't my question."

"No. He doesn't know."

Ayaan studied the candle. "Does he know you still draw?"

"I don't."

"You are lying."

"You have known me for one day in the last nine years."

"And six months before that."

"People change."

"Not everything."

The words returned from the entrance courtyard, but now there was no husband beside them and no bride to interrupt.

Naina took the broken bangles from her pocket and arranged them on the floor. "I sketch rooms sometimes. Nothing serious."

"Everything begins as something no one else considers serious."

"Including us?"

The question was out before she could recall it.

Ayaan's expression did not change. "Were we an us?"

"No."

"Then why are you angry with me?"

"Because there almost was."

"Almost is a country with no citizens, Naina."

“You seem to have kept the passport.”

He looked toward her. “So did you.”

The archive door shook in the wind. Somewhere below, something heavy fell and rolled across stone.

Ayaan stood.

“Wait,” Naina said.

He lifted the lantern although it had no light. “If a shutter has broken, the lower rooms will flood.”

“Then we go together.”

They descended with one candle inside a glass jar. The courtyard fountain had disappeared beneath a sheet of rain. At the southern passage, water pushed under the door in dark pulses.

They stacked sandbags from the caretaker’s closet. Naina held the candle while Ayaan forced the last bag into place. A gust struck the door and drove him backward. She caught his shoulder; his wet hand closed around her waist for balance.

They froze.

Neither contact nor intention could be mistaken.

The candle had gone out when the door struck him. Only lightning entered the passage, arriving in white intervals that made each position appear fixed: Ayaan braced against the wall, Naina's palm spread over his shoulder, his hand spanning the side of her waist.

Between flashes, touch supplied what sight could not.

His fingers pressed through the wet cotton, not moving, yet she felt each one distinctly. Her borrowed kurta had ridden slightly above the drawstring at her side. The heel of his palm rested against a narrow strip of bare skin.

Naina inhaled.

Ayaan's hand loosened at once but did not fall. “May I move?”

The question startled her. “You don't need permission to take your hand away.”

“I need to know whether you are steady.”

She was not. The reason had little to do with the door.

“I am.”

Another lightning flash showed his face close to hers, rain running from his hair to the edge of his jaw. Naina's thumb had shifted unconsciously against his shoulder, feeling the muscle tighten beneath his shirt.

"Your hand," he said.

She realized she was still holding him.

"For balance," she said.

"Of course."

The softness in his voice made the excuse intimate. Naina released him.

Ayaan removed his hand from her waist with deliberate care, his fingers avoiding the bare skin they had already found. The absence of contact felt colder than the soaked cloth.

He stepped back. "Are you hurt?"

"No."

"Naina—"

"Don't apologize for gravity."

"I wasn't going to."

Back upstairs, the distance between their blankets had become visible in a way it had not been before.

Naina sat with her back to the table and rubbed warmth into her arms. The borrowed kurta had soaked again at the hem. Ayaan added a candle to the jar, then placed it between them.

"You're shivering," he said.

"I'm cold."

"Those are often related."

"Thank you, doctor."

He unfolded the remaining dry blanket and offered it. Naina wrapped it around her shoulders. The wool trapped the scent of camphor and, faintly, of him from when he had carried it upstairs.

Ayaan returned to his side of the room.

"This is ridiculous," she said.

"The blanket?"

"The distance. We spent half a year sleeping on railway platforms and in jeeps without behaving like frightened teenagers."

"We were frightened adults then too. We had less vocabulary for it."

"Sit here."

He did not move. "Are you sure?"

The question, asked plainly, made her more aware of what she was offering. Not sex. Not a kiss. Proximity. Yet tonight proximity had become a currency neither of them could spend innocently.

"I am asking you to share a blanket because the room is cold," she said.

"I know what you're asking. I want to know whether you do."

Naina looked at the empty space beside her. "Yes."

Ayaan crossed the room and sat with his back against the table. He left several inches between them. Naina opened the blanket across his shoulders, closing the gap herself.

Their arms touched.

Heat gathered gradually, not dramatic enough to be called desire at first. The simple warmth of another body. The movement of breath. The friction of cloth when either adjusted. Naina watched the candle flame reflected in the black window and tried not to measure the exact length of contact from shoulder to thigh.

"Better?" he asked.

"Warmer."

"Not what I asked."

She turned her head. He was close enough that she could see a pale mark near his eyebrow she did not remember.

"Where did you get that scar?"

"Kashmir. Fell through a rotten floor while photographing a school."

"You fell through a floor?"

"Only one floor."

"And you tell this story as if the building was unreasonable."

"It had been warned."

Her laugh softened into silence. She lifted a hand before thinking and touched the scar with her fingertip.

Ayaan went still.

The skin at his temple was warm. Naina traced the short line once, then let her finger rest at the edge of his eyebrow.

"You could have died," she said.

"Many times. None impressively."

"I would not have known."

"No."

"Would anyone have told me?"

"I don't know."

Her hand moved to his cheek. Stubble roughened her palm. She had imagined this texture on the roof in Patan, then disciplined the thought for nine years until it seemed no longer hers. The body kept its own archive.

Ayaan turned his face slightly into her hand.

"Tell me to move," he said.

"You haven't moved."

"I am going to."

Consent waited between them, neither assumed nor disguised.

Naina's breathing had become shallow. "Where?"

"Closer."

She should have withdrawn her hand. Instead her thumb passed once across his cheekbone.

"Closer is not a precise measurement," she said.

"You always did require drawings."

He raised his bandaged hand and placed it lightly over hers, holding her palm against his face. With the other, he touched only the edge of the blanket near her shoulder.

"This close?" he asked.

His mouth was a breath from hers.

Every sensation sharpened: the rasp of wool at her neck, the pressure of his fingers around her wrist, the warmth of his thigh, the candle fluttering when wind entered through the cracked frame. Naina wanted to close the final distance. Wanting it felt clean. Acting on it did not.

"No," she whispered.

Ayaan moved back immediately.

He moved far enough that cold air entered beneath the blanket. His hand left hers; his shoulder no longer touched her arm. The speed of the withdrawal made Naina understand how much strength he had been using to remain still.

For several seconds she listened to both of them breathe.

"I wanted to say yes," she said.

Ayaan looked at the candle rather than at her. "I know."

"That is not permission to be pleased."

"I am not pleased." His voice was low. "I am trying not to ask you to explain a no because I prefer the feeling underneath it."

Naina drew the blanket tighter around herself. "You make everything sound considered."

"Most of this is panic with good grammar."

She laughed once, and the tension broke without disappearing.

Ayaan shifted as if to leave the shared blanket entirely.

"Stay," she said.

He stopped. "Here?"

"Here. Not closer."

"All right."

He settled beside her again, preserving a narrow space. Naina could feel his heat across it. The boundary was invisible, yet its existence made every movement legible.

She looked at the bandage on his hand. "Does it hurt?"

"Only when you are near it."

"That sounded rehearsed."

"It sounded better in my head."

Naina reached beneath the blanket and took his injured hand carefully. She turned it palm-up on his knee, avoiding the gauze.

"This is allowed," she said.

Ayaan's fingers remained open. "You do not have to label every touch."

"Tonight I do."

"Then this is allowed."

She traced the uninjured lines of his palm with one fingertip, following the curve toward his wrist. It was a small touch, easily stopped. That made its intimacy more acute. Ayaan watched her hand with the concentration he brought to a viewfinder.

"And this?" Naina asked.

His eyes lifted to hers. "You are asking me?"

"Consent is not a service only men provide."

"Yes," he said. "This is allowed."

Her finger reached the pulse inside his wrist. It beat hard beneath her touch. She left it there for one breath, then withdrew.

Neither of them mistook the gesture for innocence. Neither tried to make it more.

The absence of persuasion undid her more thoroughly than insistence might have. She stayed beneath the blanket.

"Thank you," she said.

"Don't thank me for hearing you."

"People are thanked for rarer things."

They remained beside each other, no longer touching except at the shoulder. Desire did not leave the room. It became disciplined, and therefore more present.

After a while, Ayaan said, "You can sleep."

"Can I?"

"I will stay awake."

Naina rested her head against the table, but the angle strained her neck. Ayaan shifted, offering his shoulder without comment.

She considered it, then accepted.

His body held still beneath her as if movement might constitute a broken promise. Naina closed her eyes. Under the blanket, his uninjured hand lay open on the floor between them. She placed her fingers inside it.

He did not close his hand around hers until she did first.

At midnight Ayaan lay down. Naina took his place against the cabinet.

Within minutes his breathing settled. She watched the tiredness leave his face and remembered the roof in Jodhpur, Raghav's proposal glowing in her hand while Ayaan slept through the last chance she had never offered him.

At 12:37 her phone found one bar of signal.

Three messages arrived from Raghav.

CARDIOLOGIST HERE.

ROAD CREW WAITING FOR WIND TO DROP.

I LOVE YOU. PLEASE REPLY WHEN YOU CAN.

Naina typed: I am safe. I love you too.

Before sending it, she looked at Ayaan.

Then she pressed send.

The message remained pending.

Chapter Seven

The Seventh Courtyard

At one in the morning, water began dripping onto Naina's shoulder.

She moved the blanket, then noticed the pattern. The drops were falling through a carved rosette in the ceiling, too regular to be a leak. Beneath the damp plaster, faint blue lines formed the edge of a painted plan.

She woke Ayaan.

Together they shifted the archive cabinet away from the wall. Behind it was a shallow niche sealed with warped plywood. Ayaan pried the board loose with an iron ruler.

Inside lay rolls of linen, brittle account books, and a wooden tube capped in brass.

Naina opened the tube.

The first drawing showed the palace as it had existed before the hotel restoration. Seven courtyards, not six. The erased court was labelled *Karkhana Neel*—the blue workshop.

"An atelier," Naina said. "Look at the north light, the dye drains, the storage bays."

"Not a zenana?"

"Not only that. They worked here."

On the lower corner, in faded ink, was a signature: Zohra Banu, Master of Works, 1891.

Ayaan photographed the sheet without flash.

"The official plaque credits Dev's great-great-grandfather," he said.

"She designed the expansion."

The remaining plans showed looms, stone-cutting benches, classrooms, and a covered bridge extending from the atelier toward the main palace. Marginal notes listed payments to women by name.

There were forty-three names across the sheets. Some appeared beside weekly wages. Others were followed by measurements, material orders, or terse instructions in two different hands. One woman, Sakina, had supervised the lime kilns. Another, Tara, had signed for indigo arriving from Jodhpur. Beside three revisions to the northern arcade, Zohra Banu had written the same initials until the ink grew faint.

Naina read them aloud while Ayaan photographed each line.

“They weren't merely artisans,” she said. “They were managing procurement, structure, drainage. This was a practice.”

“A firm?”

“More than that. A school, perhaps. Look at the repeated exercises in the margins.”

She found a page covered with imperfect arches, each corrected by a firmer hand. The last drawing carried a single approving mark.

For reasons she could not explain, that mark moved her more than the master plan. A woman had stood in this room more than a century earlier and taught another woman how to make a curve hold weight. The evidence had survived because someone failed to destroy every page.

“Naina.”

Ayaan's voice was gentle.

She realized she was crying.

“It is dust,” she said.

“Of course.”

He did not lift the camera. He handed her the cleanest corner of his scarf and looked away while she wiped her face.

That privacy was its own form of witness.

Naina's tiredness disappeared. She spread the drawings across the table, weighting the corners with candles and biscuit packets.

“This changes the preservation case,” she said. “If these are authentic, the family cannot describe the wing as valueless storage.”

“They can if no one sees them.”

“We'll show Meera.”

“And Dev?”

“It is his family.”

Ayaan lifted one account book. Several pages had been cut out cleanly.

“Someone found these before us.”

Naina followed the knife marks along the binding. They were recent.

“Why leave the plans?” she asked.

“Maybe they didn't know what they meant.”

“Or they ran out of time.”

A noise came from the corridor.

Not rain. A deliberate scrape, then the click of metal against metal.

Ayaan extinguished one candle. Naina rolled the main plan and held it against her body.

The archive handle moved.

Once.

Twice.

“Who is there?” Ayaan called.

No answer.

He opened the door suddenly.

The corridor was empty. At its far end, the blue service door stood ajar.

They had checked it earlier. It had been bolted.

Ayaan stepped into the corridor.

“Wait,” Naina whispered.

He raised one hand without turning, asking her to remain where she was. The gesture irritated her enough that she followed.

The blue door moved slightly in the draft. Beyond it lay a narrow passage with plaster walls and no windows. Water glistened on the floor.

“Hello?” Ayaan called.

Something answered from below: two quick footsteps, then silence.

Naina caught his sleeve and pulled him backward just as a beam of torchlight crossed the far wall. They slipped behind the open archive door. The recess was barely deep enough for both of them.

Ayaan stood with his back against the wall. Naina was pressed in front of him, one shoulder beneath his chin. His arm came around her middle to keep the door from shifting when the draft changed.

The torchlight returned.

It traveled along the corridor floor, paused at the archive threshold, then disappeared.

Naina held her breath. Ayaan's palm rested flat against her stomach through the borrowed cotton. The contact was protective, unavoidable, and devastatingly precise. She could feel his chest rise behind her, the damp heat of his body along her back, his mouth close to her temple.

Footsteps retreated down the hidden passage.

Neither moved.

“They are gone,” Naina breathed.

“Not far enough.”

His lips were so close that the words warmed the shell of her ear. Her body reacted before thought—a shiver that traveled visibly beneath his hand.

Ayaan felt it. His fingers flexed once, then became still.

“Cold?” he asked.

She could have accepted the offered lie.

“No.”

The arm around her loosened immediately. Naina stepped out of the recess and turned to face him.

His expression contained fear, desire, and the discipline to separate them. It was the discipline that made her want to close the space again.

Instead she pushed the archive door wider.

“We need to know where that passage leads,” she said.

“We need to know who is using it.”

“Same problem.”

“Not if they came for the plans.”

They looked back at the table where Zohra Banu's drawings lay beneath the candlelight.

A line of wet footprints led across the floor and ended at the stairwell.

“We are not alone,” Naina whispered.

Ayaan barred the archive door with a chair. “Or we weren’t.”

Naina examined the plan again. The covered bridge connected not only to the main palace but to a sequence of staff passages—including the concealed door in her hotel suite.

“Someone could cross without using the causeway,” she said.

“If the passage still exists.”

“Someone just used part of it.”

They took one candle and followed the footprints to the stairwell. The prints were narrow, made by a bare foot or thin-soled shoe, and already fading as the stone absorbed their edges. Ayaan went first. Naina kept one hand against the wall, reading changes in the plaster by touch.

At the ground floor, the tracks turned toward a room they had dismissed as a collapsed storeroom. Indigo stains rose along its walls like smoke. Three stone troughs

stood beneath shuttered windows, their drains cut with the same geometric precision as the channels in the recovered plan.

"The dye room," Naina said.

She held the candle near the northern wall. What had looked like a buttress was a sealed doorway, its outline disguised beneath later plaster. Someone had disturbed the dust at its base.

Ayaan crouched. "Air is coming through."

The candle flame bent toward the wall.

Naina knelt beside him. Their shoulders pressed together as they examined the seam. This contact belonged to the work, yet neither body knew how to file it so simply now.

"There," she said.

A circular depression lay beneath the plaster, exactly where a latch might have been. Ayaan brushed it with his bandaged hand.

"Don't," Naina said. "If the masonry has shifted, opening it could bring down the arch."

"You used to enjoy letting me do dangerous things."

"I enjoyed stopping you at the last possible moment."

"I remember."

The candle guttered. Ayaan cupped his hand around the flame, enclosing Naina's fingers with it. Their faces were close within the small shelter of his palms.

"There is blue thread caught in the latch," she said.

"Like Meera's anklet?"

"Her anklet had blue thread inside the clasp. I noticed when she showed me the photograph."

"Someone wanted us to connect them."

"Or someone was careless twice."

"Which do you believe?"

Naina looked at the sealed door, the footprints, and the man whose breath warmed the back of her hand. "I believe coincidence is often a story told by the person who arranged the room."

A sound travelled through the wall: a muted knock, followed by the scrape of something moving away.

The candle went out.

In the darkness, Ayaan's arm came across Naina's body, guiding her behind him. She caught his wrist.

"Do not become heroic," she whispered.

"I am positioning myself near the unstable masonry."

"Your body is not structural reinforcement."

"You have not seen me at the gym."

The absurdity nearly made her laugh. Fear and desire had begun sharing the same narrow space inside her, each sharpening the other.

They waited. Nothing else sounded beyond the wall.

Ayaan relit the candle. His arm remained across her waist for a second longer than protection required. Naina could feel the heat of his forearm through the wet cotton, the spread of his hand just above her hip.

"Ayaan."

He removed it immediately. "Sorry."

"I did not ask you to apologize."

"Then what did you ask?"

She had only said his name. The same problem, nine years later: a request implied and resented for being misunderstood.

"Nothing," she said.

Pain moved across his face too quickly to challenge.

They returned upstairs carrying the piece of blue thread in an evidence envelope from his camera bag.

They searched the archive until they found a smaller plan marking a stair above the dye room. Beside the symbol Zohra Banu had written a line in Urdu. Ayaan translated slowly.

"A room is not hidden because it is empty. It is hidden because someone fears what it contains."

Naina looked around the archive, at the surviving names, the erased work, and the man who had once returned her notebook so she would possess proof of her own presence.

"Take pictures of everything," she said.

He raised the camera. "Including you?"

"Especially the plans."

He understood the boundary and obeyed it.

But when she bent over Zohra Banu's signature, Ayaan took one photograph in which Naina's hand rested beside the dead architect's name.

This time she heard the shutter.

She did not ask him to delete it.

Chapter Eight

The Last Assignment

The footprints had dried by two.

With no safe way to follow them, Naina and Ayaan returned to the story that had waited longer than the storm.

Ayaan showed her the original emails on his phone, archived beneath years of assignments. The first carried the magazine layouts with both their names. The second documented the editor's refusal. The third contained a sentence Naina had never seen: *I will withdraw the essay if that is what you want, but I cannot keep guessing what silence means.*

"My mother deleted them," Naina said.

"You don't know that."

"She answered my apartment phone. She told you I wanted no contact."

"She thought she was protecting your marriage."

"Everyone was very committed to protecting a marriage that did not exist yet."

Ayaan put the phone away. "Would you have left Raghav?"

Naina did not answer quickly.

"I don't know."

"Then don't turn your mother into the only locked door."

The fairness of it angered her.

"And you?" she said. "You could have come to Hyderabad."

"I did."

She stared at him.

"Two days before your wedding. I stood outside your apartment for forty minutes. Your father came down and asked me to leave."

"My father knew?"

"He knew enough."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"You had chosen."

"You decided that for me."

"You accepted another man's ring."

The candles wavered in the draft.

"I wanted you to make it difficult," Naina said.

"I thought loving you meant not humiliating you on your wedding week."

"And now?"

His eyes held hers. "Now I think we called fear dignity because it sounded better."

Below them, the palace groaned as wind pressed against the old walls.

Naina sat on the floor beside the plans. "Raghav has never been cruel to me."

"I know."

"He is generous. He calls my mother. He remembers every bill. When my father died, he slept on a hospital chair for six nights."

"I know."

"You don't know anything about him."

"I know you need me to understand that he is good."

"He is."

"Then say the rest."

Naina looked at the rain-black window. "Sometimes goodness becomes a room you are ashamed to leave."

Ayaan did not move closer.

That restraint, more than touch, endangered her.

"I am not asking you to leave him," he said.

"What are you asking?"

"For you to stop making me responsible for a choice you have not made."

Naina folded the recovered plan with precise care. "You always wanted the clean version of things."

"No. I wanted the true version."

"Truth is rarely clean."

"Then let it be dirty."

The sentence settled between them with more intimacy than a confession.

Naina stood and crossed to the window because remaining seated felt too much like surrender. Rain streaked the glass, making a second, distorted room over the first. In the reflection Ayaan stayed where he was.

"Tell me the true version, then," she said.

"Of what?"

"The last nine years."

He gave a quiet, incredulous laugh. "Before dawn?"

"The parts that matter."

"You decide which parts matter. That was always our problem."

She turned. "Did you love anyone else?"

The question stripped the room of every safer subject.

Ayaan looked down at his bandaged hand. "Yes."

Naina had no right to the pain that followed. It came anyway, fast and humiliating.

"How many?"

"That is not a question I am willing to answer for your punishment or my performance."

"One, then. Tell me about one."

He considered refusing. "Samira. A journalist. We lived together for almost two years."

"Why did it end?"

"Because she wanted a home I kept treating as a place between assignments. Because I thought returning was the same as staying. Because she became tired of being reasonable."

The answer sounded practiced only because regret had polished it.

"Did you love her?"

"Yes."

"The same way?"

"There is no same way."

"That is an elegant refusal."

"It is an honest one."

Ayaan sat on the edge of the table. "Samira knew about you."

Naina's stomach tightened. "What did you tell her?"

"That there had been someone before her whom I failed to ask to stay."

"There had not been anyone. You said so yourself."

"That distinction impressed her as much as it impresses you."

Despite the jealousy she had no right to feel, Naina smiled.

"She found the Chand Baori photograph," Ayaan continued. "Not hidden. Just kept. She asked why you were the only person in my archive whose picture had no caption."

"What did you say?"

"That I knew your name."

The intimacy of the answer hurt more than any declaration.

"Did she leave because of me?"

"No. She left because of me. I missed her sister's wedding for an assignment I had promised to refuse. I came home with photographs of a flood and expected the importance of the work to excuse the smallness of what I had done."

"Did you ask her to stay?"

"Yes."

"Clearly?"

"For once."

"And?"

"She said she loved me and had become tired of living inside the future version of my apology."

Ayaan looked toward the rain-black window. "I tell you this because you should know I am capable of turning love into absence. Not because I want credit for recognizing it afterward."

Naina imagined Samira packing books into boxes while Ayaan finally found the right words. Sympathy and envy arrived together.

"Raghav stays," she said.

"Yes."

"Even when staying becomes a way of not seeing me, he stays."

"And I see you while building a life that requires leaving."

"Neither sounds sufficient."

"No."

Naina hated the maturity of the answer. She wanted proof that his life had remained suspended exactly where she had left it, an expectation so selfish she could barely admit it to herself.

"Now you," he said.

"You know whom I married."

"Marriage is not an answer to whether you loved anyone."

"I love Raghav."

"Present tense. Clear. Anything else?"

She held his gaze. "I loved you."

The past tense entered him like a wound.

"When?" he asked.

"On the train to Ahmedabad. On the roof in Patan. At Chand Baori. Possibly from the first time you corrected something you had no qualifications to correct."

"That narrows it to every day."

"I loved you when I accepted his proposal. I hated myself for that. Then I hated you because it was easier."

Ayaan rose. He approached slowly, stopping beyond reach.

"Do you love me now?"

Naina's throat tightened. "That question is not fair."

"No. It is true."

"Truth can still be used cruelly."

"Then don't answer."

"You know I do."

Neither moved.

The words seemed to alter the pressure in the room. Naina felt them in her throat, her ribs, the unsteady space behind her knees. For nine years she had treated love as if tense could contain it—past meant safe, present meant betrayal. Spoken aloud, the grammar failed.

Ayaan crossed half the distance between them, then stopped.

"Say it again," he said.

"No."

Pain flickered across his face.

Naina stepped closer. "Not because it is untrue. Because I will not turn it into something you can ask me to perform."

"I wasn't asking for performance."

"You were asking to hear what it does to you."

"Yes." He did not soften the admission. "I have imagined hearing it for so long that I don't trust the room."

She reached for his uninjured hand and placed it against the inside of her wrist. Her pulse struck hard beneath his fingers.

"Trust that," she said.

Ayaan's thumb shifted over the beat. His gaze remained on her face, searching for any retreat.

"May I hold you?"

The question entered her body before she answered it.

"Yes. Only hold me."

He drew her toward him.

Naina went without resistance. Her cheek came to rest against his chest; his arms closed around her slowly, allowing her to feel each part of the choice. One hand settled between her shoulder blades. The bandaged one rested lower, careful at her waist.

For the first few seconds the embrace was almost formal. Then Naina's hands gripped the back of his shirt and the years between them collapsed into sensation. Ayaan exhaled against her hair. His chin touched her temple. She felt the hard rhythm of his heart beneath her cheek and the answering tremor he tried to control when she moved closer.

This was not the accidental press of bodies in a corridor or the borrowed warmth of a blanket. It was chosen contact, permitted and limited by the words she had given it.

His mouth touched her hair.

Naina's body tightened.

Ayaan stopped. "That was not only holding."

"No."

"Do you want me to move?"

She considered the truth. "Not yet."

He remained still.

The restraint gave her room to notice what she wanted: to lift her face, to feel his mouth against her forehead and then lower, to learn whether the kiss she had postponed for nine years would resemble memory or destroy it. Want did not arrive as a command. It arrived as knowledge.

Naina stepped out of his arms before knowledge became action.

Saying it did not create the feeling. It only exposed how long it had been shaping the room.

Ayaan closed his eyes briefly. When he opened them, desire and grief had stripped the calm from his face.

"I want to kiss you," he said. "Not because the storm permits it. Because you said that, and I need to know whether I am standing in a memory."

Naina's pulse struck hard against her throat. "You are not."

He did not approach. "That is not permission."

"No."

She moved toward him instead and placed her palm at the centre of his chest. Beneath the damp cotton, his heart beat hard and uneven. Ayaan's hand covered hers, holding it exactly where she had placed it.

"Not a memory," she whispered.

"No."

Naina lifted her other hand to his shoulder. She moved closer until her forehead met his. Their mouths were inches apart. His breath warmed her upper lip, and for one disorienting second she felt the kiss as clearly as if it had already happened.

"If I kiss you," she said, "I will make tonight responsible for a decision it cannot make."

"Then don't kiss me tonight."

"You make restraint sound easy."

"It is not easy."

His voice roughened on the final word. The sound travelled through her palm.

They stood together until the ache became almost unbearable. Then Naina stepped away again.

This time the distance was not a failure. It was a choice they had both felt being made.

At 2:21, her phone vibrated. The pending message to Raghav had finally sent.

Under it appeared his reply.

GOOD. TRY TO SLEEP.

Naina imagined his relief, his trust, and the ordinary tomorrow he believed awaited them.

She placed the phone beside her wedding ring, which she had removed only because her wet fingers had swollen.

Ayaan saw it and looked away.

Chapter Nine

Three Calls

For nineteen minutes after Raghav's message arrived, Naina watched the small word *sent* beneath her reply.

The phone lay beside her wedding ring on the archive table. Moisture had swollen her fingers enough that removing it had been sensible. In candlelight, however, the ring looked less like an object temporarily set aside than evidence placed for examination.

She picked it up and dried it with the edge of her sleeve.

Ayaan remained across the room, cataloguing the damaged account books. He did not look at her, yet his refusal to look acknowledged the ring more completely than a question would have.

Naina slid it back onto her finger. The skin resisted at the knuckle. She worked it down until it reached its familiar place.

"You will hurt yourself," Ayaan said.

"It belongs there."

"I did not say it didn't."

"You thought it."

"No. I thought you wanted it there badly enough to accept pain as proof."

She stopped turning the ring.

Her phone lit with a photograph from Raghav. The main ballroom had been converted into a dormitory. Elderly guests slept on sofas beneath ceremonial garlands; children lay in rows of banquet chairs pushed together. At the edge of the frame, Meera sat on the floor in her sangeet lehenga, forehead against Dev's shoulder.

Raghav had written: *Everyone safe here. Road crew moving now.*

No demand. No suspicion. Only information chosen to make her less afraid.

Naina pressed the phone to her sternum for a moment.

"He is trying to reach you," Ayaan said.

"He always tries when something is broken."

"That sounded unkind."

"It was."

At 2:40, the screen brightened with Raghav's name.

The cardiologist had arrived. Mr. Sethi would be transferred at dawn. The northern road crew had cleared half the fallen tree.

"They say another two hours," he told her.

"The wind is still strong."

"Ayaan knows the building?"

"Better than I do."

"Stay together."

The irony passed through her so sharply she almost laughed.

"Do you have dry clothes?" Raghav asked.

"Caretaker's clothes."

"Food?"

"Biscuits."

"Blankets?"

Naina looked at the one spread beside the table. "Yes."

Each practical question approached the truth without knowing it. Dry clothes. Shared warmth. A man who knew the building and the version of her that had once moved through ruins beside him.

"Is he close enough to hear me?" Raghav asked.

"He is in the room."

Across the archive, Ayaan lifted another damaged ledger and carried it farther from the candle.

"Put me on speaker."

Naina hesitated. "Why?"

"Because I want to thank him for keeping you safe."

The gratitude was sincere. That made it impossible to refuse without revealing a reason.

She touched the speaker icon.

"Ayaan?" Raghav's voice filled the archive.

Ayaan came closer but stopped on the other side of the table. "Yes."

"Thank you for staying with her."

His eyes met Naina's. "She is the reason the archive is still dry. I am mostly moving what she tells me to move."

"That sounds like her." Raghav gave a tired laugh. "The northern route should open before dawn. If anything changes, call me. My phone will stay on."

"I will."

Two men made a promise about Naina's safety while she stood between them. She knew both intended care. She also heard how easily care could become custody when no one asked what she intended for herself.

She took the phone off speaker.

"We found old architectural plans," she said. "The closed wing was designed by a woman named Zohra Banu."

There was a pause. "That's interesting."

"It could change the redevelopment."

"What redevelopment?"

"The property situation you were discussing."

"Naina, this isn't the time."

"It is exactly the time. The building may be historically significant."

"We can discuss it when you are safe."

His voice was patient, loving, dismissive.

"Fine," she said.

After the call, Ayaan asked, "Why didn't you tell him about the footprints?"

"Because he would try to come through the storm."

"And why didn't you tell him about the passage?"

Naina looked toward the barred archive door.

"Because we haven't found it yet."

Ayaan studied her but did not challenge the answer.

"He trusts you," he said.

"Yes."

"That sounded like an accusation."

"It isn't."

"Then why are you angry?"

Naina walked to the table and began aligning the plans for the third time. "Because trust can become another way of not looking. Raghav trusts that I will be where he left me. He trusts that if I am unhappy I will produce a properly scheduled complaint. He trusts the version of me that makes his life coherent."

"And is that version false?"

"No. That is the problem. She is real. She is simply not all of me."

Ayaan leaned against the cabinet. "You keep saying the problem is that good things are not enough. Maybe the problem is that you expect one life to contain every possible self."

"You think I am greedy."

"I think you are alive. Greed depends on what you take."

The distinction settled uneasily.

"Raghav and I were happy," she said.

"Past tense again."

"Not entirely. There are mornings when he brings coffee and sits on the bathroom floor while I get ready because it is the only ten minutes we have. There are nights when he wakes and reaches for me before he knows he is awake. He can make me laugh when I have already decided not to forgive him."

Ayaan's expression remained attentive, though hearing the intimacy cost him something.

"Then why did you leave the firm without telling him the real reason?" he asked.

"Because the last time I said I felt invisible, he booked us a holiday."

"That sounds expensive."

"It was beautiful. He chose the hotel, flights, restaurants, and a private tour of buildings I had once mentioned wanting to see. Every hour arrived perfected. I came home more invisible than before."

"Did you tell him?"

"I thanked him."

"You are both talented at constructing the wrong thing."

Naina looked at him sharply, then conceded the point with a tired breath.

"He is going to ask what happened here," she said.

"What will you say?"

"The truth."

"Which part?"

She looked at the blanket they had shared. "That we found the plans. That someone entered the passage. That we talked."

"And that you told me you loved me?"

Her eyes lifted to his.

"I said loved."

"You said I know you do."

"Do not use exact language against an architect."

"Then give me a correction."

Naina could hear Raghav's last instruction - stay together - and the impossible tenderness of it.

"I love the man you were," she said. "I want the man you are. I do not yet know if those are the same feeling."

Ayaan accepted the answer, though it brought him no comfort.

"That is true enough for tonight," he said.

"And tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow truth will have witnesses."

The second call came at 3:16. Raghav had returned to the palace. The wedding guests were asleep in improvised rooms. Meera was crying from guilt.

"Tell her I'm fine," Naina said.

"She wants to speak to you."

Meera's voice arrived breathless. "I swear the anklet was missing. I don't understand how it returned to the dressing room."

"Who had your phone?"

"Everyone. Why?"

"Did you message me to take Ayaan?"

"I told you in person."

"Did anyone suggest it?"

Meera went silent.

"My aunt said he knew the wing," she answered finally. "I didn't think—"

The call dropped.

Meera sent three photographs before the signal disappeared again.

The first showed the dressing room in the confusion before the sangeet: open jewellery cases, curling irons, garment bags, cousins reflected in every mirror. The second was a close view of the recovered anklet fastened around Meera's left ankle. The third had been taken earlier that afternoon in the roof pavilion.

Naina enlarged them side by side.

"Look," she said.

Ayaan crouched beside the table.

In the pavilion photograph, a strand of blue silk was caught inside the anklet clasp. In the later dressing-room image, the thread was gone. The silver surface also carried a smear of pale plaster near one bell.

“Someone removed it after the pavilion,” Ayaan said.

“And returned it before the sangeet ended.”

“Why send us here?”

“Maybe the anklet was not meant to send both of us. Meera chose you after it went missing.”

“Her aunt suggested me.”

Naina searched the crowded dressing-room photograph. Near the open door stood Leela Baisa, speaking to a woman whose face was turned away. The woman's sari was pale gold with a narrow blue border. One hand rested on the frame of the hidden service door.

“Who is Meera's aunt?” Ayaan asked.

“I don't know.”

“We need a guest list.”

“We need daylight.”

The photographs vanished from the screen when the signal failed, but Naina had already taken screenshots.

She saved them in a folder beside the images of Zohra Banu's plans.

The wedding and the archive no longer felt like separate accidents.

The third came at 3:52.

Raghav's voice had changed. “Security says there may be an old staff bridge.”

Naina looked at the plan in her hand.

“Do they know where?”

“No. Dev's father says it was sealed decades ago. Do not look for it. The northern road is almost open.”

“Who told security?”

“I asked about the second doors in the lake wing.”

“How did you know about those?”

“You mentioned yours yesterday.”

She had not.

Naina remembered telling Ayaan, not Raghav, that the hinges were new. She remembered the soft movement beyond the blue door while her husband slept.

“Raghav,” she said, “has anyone entered our suite?”

“The hotel moved luggage away from the windows. Why?”

The archive handle shifted behind the chair.

Ayaan stood soundlessly.

“Naina?” Raghav said.

“Someone is here.”

The line crackled.

The handle stopped.

Ayaan pulled the door open. Again the corridor was empty, but this time a small brass key lay on the floor. A strip of blue thread was tied through its bow.

On the key was stamped the number seven.

Chapter Ten

The Dry Room

The key opened a cabinet built into the archive wall.

Inside were six dry cotton robes, a hurricane lamp, and a ledger dated 1978. The final entries recorded the removal of paintings, looms, and “materials unsuitable for the hotel narrative.” The receiving signature belonged to Dev’s grandfather.

Tucked into the back was a recent survey proposing demolition of Neel Mahal. The consultant’s name appeared on the cover.

Raghav Rao.

Naina read it twice.

The report was preliminary, unsigned, but its recommendations were unmistakable: preserve the visible facade, remove the unstable interior, construct twelve premium lake suites.

Naina turned the pages slowly.

Raghav’s firm had described the atelier as “architecturally subordinate service fabric.” The phrase was his; she had heard him use it in presentations. But beneath it appeared another sentence: *Later interventions possess no independent cultural value and may be removed without material loss.*

That language was hers.

She had written a version of it years earlier in an assessment of a shopping arcade added to a colonial warehouse. Raghav had admired the clarity of the sentence. He had repeated it in meetings until neither of them remembered where it originated.

Here it had been applied to rooms whose history no consultant had bothered to investigate.

“He used my work,” she said.

Ayaan came beside her but did not take the report. “Did you contribute to this?”

“No.”

“Could someone at his firm have copied the language?”

“Of course. That is almost worse.” She touched the line with one finger. “My words have been living in his documents while I have been wondering whether my career mattered.”

The next page contained photographs taken during a dry-season inspection. Furniture had been moved in front of the archive door. The blue atelier plan was absent from the appendix. Under *stakeholder consultation*, the report listed Dev's father, the hotel manager, and a conservation adviser whose name Naina did not recognize.

No custodian. No textile historian. No women from the local trust.

"This survey was designed not to find anything," she said.

"Can you prove that?"

"I can prove what they failed to inspect."

"That may be enough."

Naina looked at the date. Raghav had taken her to dinner that night in Hyderabad. He had arrived late, apologized with wine, and listened while she described leaving the firm. She remembered how relieved she had felt when he did not immediately offer a solution.

He had already been planning a project that required her expertise.

He had chosen not to ask for it.

"He knew," she said.

Ayaan did not answer.

"He knew what the property conversation was about."

"The report may be old."

"It is dated last month."

Raghav had told her the trip was purely social. He had packed presentation shoes. He had taken calls before they reached their room.

Naina's anger was disproportionate only if measured against one lie. Measured against years of decisions gently made on her behalf, it felt exact.

"Don't," she told Ayaan.

"I haven't said anything."

"Don't become the man who understands me because my husband failed a test he didn't know he was taking."

"I won't."

She turned on him. "That is too easy."

"What do you want me to do?"

"Be selfish. Be angry. Stop standing at a respectful distance as if that makes this harmless."

He crossed the distance then, stopping close enough that she could see rain caught in his eyelashes.

"You want the selfish truth?" he asked.

"Yes."

"I have imagined this night in a hundred dishonest ways. None included a flood, and in every one you were already free."

Naina's breath changed.

"I am not free."

"I know."

"Then move back."

He did.

The obedience hurt more than refusal.

Naina kept her eyes on the space he had opened between them.

"Do you ever get tired of doing exactly what I ask?"

"Often."

"Then why do it?"

"Because wanting you does not make your boundaries negotiable."

"You didn't always believe that."

"No." He looked toward the report. "At twenty-seven I believed patience entitled me to an answer. I made every silence mean what protected my pride."

"And now?"

"Now I know silence is only silence."

Naina crossed the distance he had created.

She did not touch him. She stood close enough that the front of her robe almost brushed his damp shirt, close enough to see the muscle move in his jaw when she lifted her face.

"I am not silent," she said.

"No."

"I want you near me. I also want you to move when I ask."

"Both can be true."

"They do not feel true together."

"That does not make either a lie."

Ayaan's hands remained at his sides. The restraint gave her full control of the distance and made control feel less safe than she expected.

Naina reached for his bandaged hand. She turned it over and placed his palm against the fabric over her waist, exactly where it had rested in the corridor.

His breath stopped.

"This is me asking," she said.

His fingers curved carefully, warmth spreading through the thin cotton. "For what?"

"For you not to pretend distance is the only decent thing."

"And if I want more than this?"

"Then want it."

"Naina."

"Wanting is not the promise."

They stood with his hand at her waist and no other contact between them. The simplicity of it became more intimate than an embrace. She felt each change in pressure when he breathed, the rough edge of the bandage, the deliberate stillness of his thumb.

Then plaster cracked in the outer room.

Ayaan removed his hand before the ceiling came down.

A section of ceiling plaster collapsed in the outer room. They carried the plans, ledger, blankets, and lamp into the cabinet chamber, the driest space in the archive. It was barely wide enough for both of them to sit without their knees touching.

For an hour they spoke only of evidence. Ayaan copied every page. Naina annotated the plan from memory. Together they built a record strong enough to survive if the originals disappeared.

At 4:30, the storm weakened. In the new quiet they heard water travelling through hidden channels in the walls.

"The building is telling us where the passage is," Naina said.

"You always did trust buildings more than people."

"Buildings show their cracks."

"People do too. You just call them flaws and renovate around them."

She leaned her head against the cabinet. "I am tired of being interpreted."

"Then tell me plainly."

Naina looked at him.

"I wanted to see you again," she said. "Not because I planned anything. Because I needed to know whether the person I was with you had been real."

"She was."

"How can you know?"

"Because she is asking the question."

They sat with their knees touching now. Neither moved away.

The cabinet chamber had narrowed around them while they worked. Ledgers crowded the shelf above Ayaan's shoulder. Rolled plans pressed against Naina's back. The hurricane lamp warmed the air until the cotton robe clung faintly at her throat.

"You knew Raghav consulted for the family," she said.

"I knew his firm had visited. I did not know he wrote the survey."

"Would you have told me?"

"At the entrance? Hello, Naina, I still love you and your husband may demolish a historically significant atelier?"

"It would have been memorable."

"You already looked ready to leave."

"I was looking at the building."

"Of course."

The old phrase brought a reluctant smile to her mouth. Ayaan saw it and became very still.

"What?" she asked.

"I had forgotten that expression."

"Which one?"

"The moment before you allow yourself to be amused."

"You photograph people too much."

"I photograph them because memory edits without permission."

He lifted his camera but did not raise it to his eye. "May I?"

Naina looked down at herself: borrowed robe, damp hair, wedding ring absent, knees against the man she had once loved and had just admitted she wanted. The image would not be innocent merely because the frame contained no touch.

"No," she said.

Ayaan set the camera aside.

She changed her mind almost immediately. "Wait."

He looked at her.

"Not my face. Photograph the report beside Zohra Banu's plan. Evidence, not confession."

"Sometimes they are the same thing."

"Not tonight."

He arranged the documents without moving his knee from hers. Naina kept it there deliberately, a contact she could name and therefore control.

Chapter Eleven

A Door Above Water

The drainage sound led them to the dye room.

Behind a collapsed shelf, the wall carried a vertical crack exactly where the plan marked a stair. Naina pressed the brass key into a concealed lock. A section of blue plaster released with a sigh of dust.

Beyond it, steps climbed inside the wall.

“The service bridge,” Ayaan said.

They followed the stair to a narrow gallery above the courtyard. At its end, an iron door opened onto the roofline. Across a twelve-foot gap, the remains of the covered bridge reached toward the main palace. Half its wooden floor had fallen into darkness.

A stone ledge continued along the outer wall, slick with rain.

Below it, floodwater moved through the courtyard with enough force to carry branches, cushions, and one overturned brass lamp. The drop was not high enough to guarantee death. It was high enough to make rescue impossible if either of them fell badly.

Ayaan found a coil of maintenance rope in a wall recess. He tied one end around an iron ring and pulled until rust flaked beneath his hand.

“That ring is decorative,” Naina said.

“It is set into masonry.”

“Masonry that has spent a century collecting rain.”

He leaned his weight against it.

The ring shifted half an inch.

Naina seized the back of his robe and dragged him away as a section of mortar broke free. It struck the ledge, bounced once, and vanished into the water.

They stood inside the doorway, breathing hard.

“Still want to trust the building?” Ayaan asked.

“It showed us the crack.”

“After trying to kill me.”

“You pulled it out.”

“This feels like a familiar disagreement.”

Naina kept hold of his robe. Her fist rested between his shoulder blades, cloth gathered inside it. When she released him, her fingers dragged inadvertently down his back.

Ayaan turned.

Wind pushed rain through the opening, flattening the borrowed clothes against them. His gaze passed over her face, the robe clinging at her shoulders, the bare line of her throat. He looked away with visible effort.

The effort heated her more than the look.

"I can cross," Ayaan said.

"No."

"The wind has dropped."

"The stone is wet and there is no rail."

"I can take a rope and alert security."

"They are already clearing the road."

"Someone entered the archive. We do not know if they are still here."

"That is not a reason to fall off a palace."

He tested the first stone with his shoe.

Naina caught his wrist. "I am asking you to stay."

He turned.

The storm no longer drowned the meaning.

"Because it is dangerous?" he asked.

She could have said yes and preserved the shape of the night.

"Because I don't want to be alone again."

Ayaan stepped back from the ledge.

They closed the iron door.

On the inner wall, scratched beneath generations of paint, were names and dates—women who had worked in the atelier. The final inscription was from 1978: *We were here before the rooms forgot us.*

Ayaan raised his camera, but Naina touched the lens.

"Wait."

She stood beside the names. "Now."

He photographed her openly.

The shutter clicked three times.

In the first frame Naina stood straight, one hand at her side. In the second she turned toward the inscription, reading the names. In the third, taken after she had forgotten the camera, her fingers rested against the cut plaster and her eyes had closed.

"Show me all of them," she said.

Ayaan came beside her. They reviewed the images shoulder to shoulder. In the final photograph, damp cotton outlined the slope of her waist, but the intimacy came from something else: she looked as though she belonged to herself.

"Delete the first two," she said.

"Why?"

"They are performances."

He deleted them without argument.

"Keep the last?" he asked.

Naina studied the woman on the screen. "Yes."

When Ayaan lowered the camera, the strap caught beneath her hair. He lifted it carefully, his knuckles passing along the back of her neck. The contact was necessary for only a second. It lasted two.

Naina turned.

His hand remained near her nape. "May I?"

"Move the strap?"

"Touch you."

The directness left her nowhere to hide except inside an honest answer.

"Yes."

Ayaan placed his palm against the back of her neck. His thumb rested beneath her ear, where Raghav had kissed her before the sangeet. Memory and present sensation collided. Naina's eyes closed.

His hand was warmer than the dawn air. The pressure was gentle, no more than the weight required to acknowledge her answer, but her body responded as if he had drawn her against him. Heat moved beneath her skin. Her shoulders loosened. Her head tilted slightly into his palm before she could decide whether the movement revealed too much.

Ayaan's thumb passed once beneath her ear.

"This?" he asked.

"Yes."

He traced the edge of her jaw, then returned to the pulse at her throat without touching it. The pause was deliberate. Naina felt the withheld contact as clearly as a caress.

She opened her eyes.

"You can touch my face," she said.

Something unguarded crossed his expression. His free hand rose slowly and cupped her cheek. Held between both hands, Naina became conscious of every route available to them: one step closer, one turn of her mouth, one word that would change permission into action.

She placed her palms against his wrists.

"You are shaking," she said.

"So are you."

"I am cold."

"No, you're not."

The truth of it entered the narrow gallery and left nowhere to retreat.

Ayaan leaned forward, stopping before their foreheads touched. "Tell me what this is."

Naina could smell rain and candle smoke in his hair. His mouth was close enough that she could have closed the space without asking again.

"A touch," she said.

"Only?"

"For now."

He nodded and moved back, but his hands remained where she had allowed them until she lowered his wrists herself.

Naina's gaze fell to his mouth. Ayaan saw it. Wanting was naked in his face; so was restraint.

"Not here," she said.

"All right."

The imprint of his palm remained long after the skin cooled.

"Show me," she said.

In the image, borrowed clothes hung loosely from her body. Her hair had dried without order. There was no jewellery, no practiced smile, no husband's hand at her waist. Behind her, erased women had cut proof of themselves into plaster.

Naina barely recognized the face.

“Do I look unhappy?” she asked.

“No.”

“Do I look guilty?”

“Not yet.”

She handed back the camera.

“That was cruel.”

“It was true.”

They returned to the archive as the first grey suggestion of dawn touched the high windows. Rescue was no longer impossible. The passage existed. The road would open.

The storm had stopped choosing for them.

Chapter Twelve

The First Truth

In the archive, Naina put on her wedding ring.

"I accepted Raghav the day after waiting for you to ask me to stay," she said.

Ayaan sat across from her. "I know."

"No. You know the order. You don't know the choice."

She told him about the proposal, the roof, and the morning light in which his assignment had sounded like an answer. She told him how relieved she had felt when Raghav offered a future that did not require translation.

"I loved his certainty," she said. "Then I spent years blaming him for being certain."

She told Ayaan about the first year of the marriage, when certainty had felt like shelter. Raghav had cleared a room in his apartment for her drafting table before she moved in. He learned which side she slept on and never complained that rolls of tracing paper occupied the dining chairs. Their desire had been easy then, threaded through ordinary days: his mouth at her shoulder while she cooked, her hand beneath his shirt in elevators, laughter muffled against pillows because the neighbours complained.

"He did not steal a life from me," she said. "I brought him one and then resented him for believing it was complete."

"Did he ask whether it was?"

"At first. Then the answers became predictable. We were busy. We were successful. We wanted the same apartment, the same holidays, the same acceptable future."

"Children?"

Naina looked down at the ring. "We tried for a year. Quietly. Then I stopped tracking dates and he stopped asking. Neither of us admitted the relief."

Ayaan absorbed the intimacy of the disclosure with care. "Does anyone know?"

"No. Families prefer a medical tragedy or a firm decision. Ambivalence is difficult to bless."

She remembered the last month they had tried. Raghav had arranged a specialist appointment without telling her, believing efficiency would spare them another cycle of uncertainty. Naina had found the confirmation email while searching their shared calendar for a client dinner.

They had argued in the kitchen.

"You said you wanted answers," he had told her.

"I said I wanted time."

"Time for what?"

She had been unable to answer without admitting that each negative test brought grief followed by relief, and that the relief frightened her more.

Raghav cancelled the appointment. He never booked another. For months they avoided the subject with perfect mutual consideration. When relatives asked, he absorbed the questions before they reached her. At home, neither thanked the other for the silence.

"He protected me," Naina said now. "Even from conversations I needed to have with him."

"Did you ask him not to?"

"No."

"Then some of the locked doors are yours."

"I know."

The answer came without anger. That was new.

"And now?"

"Now I don't know whether I was protecting my work, my freedom, or a marriage that had no room left for another person."

"You do not owe me that answer."

"I am not giving it to you. I am finally saying it where I can hear it."

Ayaan rubbed his injured knuckle. "I had planned to ask you to come with me after Delhi."

"After."

"Yes."

"Work first."

"I was twenty-seven."

"Those are not opposites," she reminded him.

He smiled without humour. "No."

"Would you have married me?"

"Then? I don't know."

The answer hurt, and because it was honest she trusted it.

"Would you now?" she asked.

“That is not a fair question while you are wearing his ring.”

“Nothing about this is fair.”

“Then the honest answer is that I don't know what marriage to me would look like.”
Ayaan kept his eyes on the ring. “I know how to arrive. I am less skilled at remaining.”

“Samira taught you that.”

“She tried.”

“And I am supposed to believe you would be different with me?”

“No.”

The answer struck harder than reassurance would have.

“No?”

“I am asking you not to believe anything tonight that I have not lived long enough to prove.”

Naina folded her arms. “That is very responsible.”

“It is also the only way I know not to turn you into a reward for finally understanding myself.”

She looked at him across the narrow room. “What can you offer, then?”

“The truth that I want a life in which you are not an unfinished sentence. The truth that I may still fail at the ordinary parts. The truth that you should not leave a man who knows how to stay merely because I have learned how to speak.”

“You think I am choosing between virtues.”

“I think you are trying to make either of us simple enough to choose without grief.”

Naina sat beside him. Their shoulders touched.

“And if grief is unavoidable?”

“Then it should not be mistaken for proof that the choice is wrong.”

“Then I will not make it worse by pretending one night can answer a life.”

Naina stood and paced the narrow room. “You want truth, but only the kind that leaves you innocent.”

“I am not innocent. I came to this wedding because Meera told me you would be here.”

She stopped.

“She invited you for me?”

“She hired me because Dev needed a photographer. But when I refused, she said your name.”

“And you came.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because almost is a country with two citizens.”

He had saved her own accusation and returned it without defence.

Naina crossed the room until only inches remained between them.

“Tell me to go back to my husband,” she said.

“You should go back to your husband.”

“Tell me you want me to.”

Ayaan’s face changed.

“I can’t.”

That was the first truth neither could survive unchanged.

Chapter Thirteen

Almost

Naina kissed him.

There was no stumble, no darkness deep enough to mistake intention. She placed one hand against his face and crossed the remaining distance herself.

For one suspended second Ayaan did not respond.

Then his hand settled at her waist and the nine lost years narrowed to breath.

His mouth answered hers with a restraint that lasted only until she moved closer. Naina's fingers slid into his hair. The sound he made was quiet and involuntary, and it broke something open in her.

She kissed him again without breaking contact, changing the angle, learning the man time had made from the one memory had preserved. His beard roughened her skin. His bandaged hand stayed at her waist while the other rose slowly along her back, pausing between her shoulders as if waiting for a refusal.

Naina gave him none.

Instead she guided the uninjured hand higher, until his palm rested against the bare skin at the nape of her neck. Ayaan's breath broke against her mouth.

The sound gave her a fierce, unfamiliar confidence. She had imagined him composed for so long—watching, waiting, surviving every silence—that discovering she could undo that control felt almost like anger.

She kissed him more slowly.

Without urgency to disguise them, each movement became specific. The first touch of her lower lip against his. The careful angle of his mouth in answer. His fingers spreading beneath her hair while his thumb traced the edge of her ear. The taste of bitter tea and rainwater. The brief pause in which they looked at one another and chose to begin again.

“Is this what you imagined?” Naina whispered.

“No.”

She drew back enough to see his face. “No?”

“I was more articulate in every version.”

Her laugh touched his mouth. Ayaan smiled, then kissed the sound from her with a tenderness that lasted only until she leaned into him.

His hand at her waist tightened. The borrowed robe had loosened at the neck; his fingertips found the strip of skin above the fabric and stopped.

“Here?” he asked.

Naina covered his hand with hers. She could have moved it away. Instead she slid it beneath the loose edge until his palm rested fully against her side.

“Here.”

The heat of his touch made her inhale sharply. Ayaan waited, watching her expression. When she remained close, his thumb moved once over her skin, a small arc that seemed to gather every unacted desire of the night into a single point.

Naina's hands traveled from his shoulders to his chest. The damp shirt clung beneath her palms. She felt the hard beat of his heart and the uneven breath that lifted it. One button had come loose near his throat. Her fingers found it, then the next.

Ayaan caught her hand gently.

“Are you opening this because you want to,” he asked, “or because you want me to stop you?”

The question exposed an impulse she had not examined.

“Both,” she admitted.

He brought her fingers to his mouth and kissed the tips, one after another, then set her hand flat against his chest without opening another button.

“Then not yet.”

Frustration moved through her with desire. “You don't get to make every decision because you ask the better question.”

“No.” His gaze held hers. “You can open it.”

Naina's fingers returned to the button. She slipped it free deliberately.

The small reveal of skin beneath felt more intimate than it should have. She touched the hollow at the base of his throat. Ayaan closed his eyes. His head lowered until his forehead rested against hers.

“One,” she said.

“One.”

The limit made room for the wanting rather than reducing it.

She pressed closer. The borrowed cotton offered little distance between their bodies. Desire moved through her with a force that was both new and remembered: the heat of his palm, the firmness of his chest, the way his breath failed when her mouth travelled to the corner of his.

Ayaan drew back barely enough to speak. "Tell me if you want me to stop."

"I know."

"Say it anyway."

The insistence was not caution performed for virtue. It was a boundary he needed them both to hear.

"If I say stop, you stop."

"Immediately."

"And if I don't?"

His eyes darkened. "I still ask."

Naina kissed him before he could say more.

This time his hand tightened at her waist. He turned them gently until her back met the archive wall, careful of the cracked plaster and of her, even while the kiss deepened. She felt the full length of him without ambiguity. Her body answered, arching toward the contact before thought could supervise it.

Ayaan stopped moving but did not step away.

"Still yes?" he asked.

Naina answered by drawing him back to her mouth. "Still yes."

His bandaged hand remained firm at her hip while the other moved along her side, following the seam of the robe rather than slipping beneath it. The restraint was maddening. She took his wrist and guided his palm across her back, showing him the pressure she wanted.

He understood. His arm tightened, fitting her closer against him.

The wall was cool through the cotton at her shoulders. Ayaan was heat everywhere else. Naina felt divided between sensation and consequence, each sharpening the other: his mouth opening against hers, the scrape of his beard, the ring on her hand caught briefly in his hair.

She turned her face for air. Ayaan kissed the corner of her mouth, then her jaw. Each kiss slowed as it descended, leaving her time to stop him and making it harder to pretend she had been carried anywhere.

Her fingers slipped beneath the open collar of his shirt and rested against warm skin. He shuddered.

"Naina."

Her name sounded less like a warning than an admission.

"What?"

“If you keep touching me like that, I am going to ask for more.”

“Ask.”

He lifted his head and searched her face. “May I kiss your neck?”

The precision of the question sent a deeper pulse of heat through her.

“Yes.”

His mouth moved from hers to her cheek, then to the pulse below her ear.

The kiss at her throat was slow, open, and devastatingly specific. Naina gripped his shoulders. For a moment there was no husband, no storm, no nine-year argument - only sensation and the dangerous relief of being wanted by someone who waited for every answer.

Then her wedding ring pressed cold against Ayaan's cheek.

Naina felt it like an alarm.

"Stop."

He released her at once and stepped back far enough that no part of them touched.

The speed of his obedience left her dizzy.

The kiss had not been gentle because restraint had already consumed all the gentleness they possessed. It had held railway roofs, unanswered emails, her wedding morning, his unmade journey upstairs. It had held anger alongside desire and had not pretended they were different things.

Now they stood apart, breathing hard.

Ayaan's shirt remained open at the one button she had chosen. His mouth was reddened. The sight of both made the moment impossible to convert into an accident.

Naina pulled the robe closed at her neck. Ayaan turned slightly away, giving her privacy he had no reason to pretend remained intact.

“Look at me,” she said.

He did.

There was no triumph in his face. No expectation. Only desire still painfully present and concern that did not ask to be rewarded.

“Are you all right?” he asked.

“No.”

His expression tightened.

“That does not mean you did something wrong,” she said. “It means I did something that changes what happens when I go home.”

“You don't have to decide that before morning.”

“Morning is already here.”

Pale light had begun to gather at the high window, turning the black glass grey.

Naina touched her throat where his mouth had been. The skin felt tender. She imagined Raghav seeing the mark and shame moved through her—not shame at wanting, but at the private knowledge she would carry into his embrace.

“Did you leave a mark?” she asked.

Ayaan took a step forward, then stopped. “May I look?”

She lowered the robe slightly at the collar.

He examined the skin without touching. “No mark. A little red.”

“It will fade?”

“Yes.”

The relief hurt. Some part of her had wanted evidence; another wanted the night erased from every surface except memory.

“I chose that,” she said.

“I know.”

“The storm did not.”

“I know.”

“And you wanted it.”

“Yes.”

The clarity steadied her.

She sat on the floor. Ayaan remained standing until she looked up.

“Sit,” she said.

He sat opposite her.

“Nothing else happens tonight,” Naina said.

“All right.”

“Not because I don’t want it.”

His eyes closed briefly. “All right.”

“I will not turn Raghav into the last obstacle between me and a life I have not had the courage to name.”

“Then don’t.”

She touched her lips and almost laughed at the uselessness of undoing.

“You make restraint look noble,” she said.

“It doesn’t feel noble.”

“Good.”

They remained awake beside each other as the archive brightened. Once, Naina placed her head on his shoulder. He did not draw her closer. Once, his hand found hers beneath the blanket. Their fingers stayed linked until a vehicle horn sounded from the northern road.

Morning had arrived.

Chapter Fourteen

The Hidden Plan

The vehicle could not reach the gate. A fresh mudslide blocked the last bend, and security shouted that workers needed another hour.

Naina and Ayaan returned to the passage.

In daylight they saw what darkness had concealed: the bridge plan showed a second route beneath the roof, a service tunnel joining the lake-wing suites. Its entrance lay behind the dye vats.

Naina folded the detail inward before Ayaan saw it.

The act was so quick it felt instinctive. She covered the inked passage with her thumb and rolled the paper toward herself.

No noble explanation arrived. She was not protecting the plans or testing the route. She wanted to preserve the sealed world for a few minutes longer—the archive, the blanket, Ayaan's mouth, the version of herself who had spoken without first calculating what the truth would cost.

She also knew the desire was dangerous precisely because it resembled freedom.

Freedom would have required an exit she chose to take.

This was delay.

The concealment lasted seven minutes.

"There's another route," he said, watching her face.

"Maybe."

"Show me."

She handed him the plan.

His disappointment was quieter than anger. "Why hide it?"

"Because the moment we find a safe exit, the night ends."

"It has ended."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Naina looked toward the archive where their blankets lay side by side. "I needed one more minute in which returning was not the only respectable choice."

"You asked for truth."

"This is the truth."

"No. This is using danger to postpone it."

He opened the dye-room panel and found the tunnel. Electric conduit installed during renovation ran along the old stone. The route was dry and passable.

The tunnel was lower than either expected. Ayaan moved ahead with the hurricane lamp while Naina carried the plans inside her robe. The walls narrowed until they had to turn sideways around a collapsed support.

"Give me your hand," he said.

"I can manage."

"That answer has nearly killed you twice tonight."

She took it.

He guided her over the broken stones. At the tightest point, she slipped. Ayaan caught her against him, one arm around her ribs, the lamp held away from their clothes.

For a breath they remained fitted together in the dark.

Naina felt the aftershock of their kiss in every place his body touched hers. Ayaan felt it too; she saw the knowledge cross his face.

"Are you hurt?" he asked.

"No."

"Can I let go?"

The question was almost unbearable.

"Yes."

He did.

They continued with more distance than the tunnel allowed. Their restraint had become a third presence, moving between them, touching everything they refused to touch.

Behind them, stone scraped.

They stopped.

Ayaan lowered the lamp wick until the tunnel went dark. Naina heard his breathing ahead of her and another sound farther back: the careful displacement of rubble beneath a shoe.

Someone had entered the passage.

Ayaan reached for her hand. This time she took it before he asked.

They moved without light, one palm against the wall. The tunnel descended, turned, then divided around a central support not shown on the plan. In darkness both openings felt identical.

“Which way?” Ayaan whispered.

Naina touched the stone. The left passage was dry but carried no air. The right wall was cooler, crossed by the faint vibration of service machinery from the hotel.

“Right.”

They had taken three steps when a torch appeared around the bend behind them.

“Go,” Ayaan said.

They ran bent beneath the low ceiling. The plans pressed against Naina's ribs inside the robe. At the next collapse, Ayaan pushed the lamp through first and climbed after it, then turned to pull her over the broken support.

Naina caught her sleeve on exposed iron. Fabric tore. Ayaan reached for her, but she freed it herself and followed.

The torchlight grew brighter.

“Stop!” a voice called.

Male. Unfamiliar.

Neither stopped.

At the first turn, a steel door blocked the way. The brass key opened it.

Beyond lay a modern service corridor ending at the blue door of Naina's suite.

Someone had left it unlocked.

On the carpet inside, their luggage stood open. Nothing valuable was missing, but Naina's architecture portfolio had been searched.

The intruder had worked carefully. Jewellery cases remained zipped. Cash lay untouched inside Raghav's wallet. Naina's passport was exactly where she had left it.

Only paper had been disturbed.

Her portfolio sat open to the Neel Mahal sketches she had made from the window. The blue notebook lay beneath it, elastic strap removed. Several pages had been photographed or handled while damp; faint thumb-shaped ripples marked the paper.

“They were looking for the plans before we found them,” Ayaan said.

“Or for proof that I knew the building mattered.”

Footsteps sounded faintly in the service corridor behind them.

Ayaan closed the blue door and turned the interior latch. It held, though Naina now understood a key existed on the other side.

“We need to copy everything before someone takes it,” he said.

“Already done.” She touched the plans inside her robe. “Your photographs.”

“Two cards. One in the camera, one in my pocket.”

“Give me one.”

He removed the backup card and placed it in her palm. Naina slipped it beneath the insole of her shoe.

The preparation steadied them. They were no longer merely two people returning from a compromised night. They were witnesses carrying evidence someone had already tried to erase.

Raghav’s laptop sat on the desk.

On its screen, left awake, was the signed redevelopment contract.

The document history showed it had been opened at 1:14 a.m., while Raghav was still at the clinic. The account belonged to Dev’s father. Someone had used Raghav’s saved access to place the contract where Naina would see it—or where it could later be claimed she had seen it and agreed.

Her name appeared in the appendix under *independent conservation review*, followed by a blank line for professional registration details.

No one had asked permission to include her.

Demolition approval depended on a declaration that Neel Mahal contained no significant archival material.

The signature field for consulting architect was blank.

Beside the laptop lay Naina’s fountain pen.

“He brought me here to sign it,” she said.

“Did he ask you?”

“Not yet.”

“Then don’t decide what he intended before you ask him.”

Naina looked at Ayaan. “You are defending him.”

“I am defending the question. We have spent nine years paying for assumptions.”

The fairness of it made her angrier and also prevented the anger from becoming certainty.

She photographed the screen with her phone, including the document history and account name. Then she closed the laptop without signing out.

The service-door latch moved behind them.

Whoever had followed them had reached the suite.

From the corridor came the sound of a key entering the main suite door.

Chapter Fifteen

No Accident

Leela Baisa entered.

She showed no surprise at finding Naina and Ayaan in the room.

“You left the brass key,” Naina said.

“Yes.”

“You entered the archive.”

“To see whether you had found what was waiting.”

“You could have told us.”

“Would the family have allowed you to look?”

Leela admitted moving the anklet and suggesting Ayaan through Meera’s aunt. She had planned only to bring Naina into Neel Mahal before the contract was signed. The storm had not been part of it.

“You planned coincidence,” Naina said.

“I planned access. Coincidence is what wealthy families call the labour they do not wish to acknowledge.”

Leela lowered herself into the desk chair. Without the authority of the corridor around her, she looked older. Rain had silvered the hem of her sari. One thumbnail was split, and a fresh scrape crossed the back of her hand.

She had served Surya Garh for forty-two years, first as a kitchen apprentice, later as housekeeper, archivist without title, and the person sent whenever a member of the family needed an inconvenient room emptied. Her mother had worked there before her. Neither woman had been permitted to sign the inventories they maintained.

“I found Zohra Banu’s name in a wage ledger when I was nineteen,” she said. “The next season the ledger disappeared. I began hiding copies after that.”

“Why wait until now?” Ayaan asked.

“Because memory does not stop a bulldozer. An architect might.”

Naina looked at the scrape on her hand. “You were in the passage last night.”

“For part of it. I opened the lower grille after the water rose. I did not enter this suite.”

“Who else knows the route?”

“Anyone who studied the old maintenance maps. Anyone who paid the right servant. Anyone who watched me too closely.”

The answer turned the opened drawers from intrusion into warning. Someone had not merely searched for papers. Someone had known exactly where the papers could emerge.

“You stranded us,” Ayaan said.

“The water stranded you. I opened the way out.”

Naina held up the demolition survey. “Did you search my luggage?”

“No.”

Someone else had known about the passage.

“The survey erased the atelier before the machines could,” Leela said. “That is how demolition begins now. Not with hammers. With a sentence written by someone who will never meet the wall.”

Naina felt the accusation even though it was not aimed only at her. She had written sentences like that. Structurally compromised. Limited heritage value. Adaptive reuse not economically feasible. Sometimes the conclusions had been true. Sometimes a deadline had made certainty convenient.

“If I authenticate these plans,” she said, “the hotel may still win. Heritage status can delay a project. It does not guarantee preservation.”

“Then delay it long enough for people to see what they are losing.”

Leela’s faith was unreasonable. Naina trusted it more than Raghav’s polished assurances.

Leela asked for the plans. Naina refused.

“They stay with me until they are copied and authenticated.”

For the first time, the older woman smiled. “Then Zohra chose correctly.”

“Zohra is dead.”

“Buildings choose through whoever still listens.”

Leela left to alert Meera discreetly.

At the door, she paused. “The passage was built so women could carry their work without crossing the men’s court. Do not let anyone turn it into a lovers’ story. It is larger than that.”

After she left, the rebuke remained.

Naina and Ayaan were alone in the marital suite. The bed remained unmade from the previous night. Raghav's jacket hung over a chair. Ordinary objects made the kiss in the archive feel more real, not less.

"I won't ask you for anything," Ayaan said.

"That has always been your safest sentence."

"What do you want?"

Naina stepped toward him. "I want daylight to know what the dark does."

She kissed him again, slowly this time. When she drew back, she rested her forehead against his.

Daylight changed the kiss. Nothing concealed the bed behind her, Raghav's jacket on the chair, her jewellery open on the dressing table. Ayaan's mouth was gentler than it had been in the archive, but gentleness did not make the choice smaller.

Naina held the front of his shirt and kissed him once more without haste. His hands remained at her waist, waiting. When she moved closer, he spread one palm across her back.

"Is this all right?" he asked.

"Yes."

He kissed the corner of her mouth, then her cheek. Naina tilted her head before he asked again, offering the line of her throat. His lips touched the place below her ear.

The sensation was quieter than the first kiss and more dangerous. There was no storm to blame for how her body softened toward him, no darkness to exaggerate the intimacy. Morning light lay across the marital bed. Somewhere beyond the door, staff rolled breakfast carts through the corridor.

Ayaan's thumb moved beneath the edge of her kurta at her waist, touching bare skin. He stopped there.

"Naina?"

She covered his hand with hers. For a moment she pressed it more firmly against her body, admitting the depth of what she wanted.

Then she guided it back over the fabric.

"This is where we stop," she said.

"Because of him?"

"Because of me. If there is ever more, it will not happen inside a lie."

Ayaan touched her cheek once and lowered his hand.

"Then make the truth large enough to live in."

Neither moved away immediately. Stopping did not dissolve the desire; it gave the desire edges. Naina could feel his breath settle, the discipline in his hands as they released her, the almost painful courtesy with which he stepped out of reach.

“I do not want you to regret me because I was available during a storm,” he said.

“You were never merely available.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the most honest one I have.”

He glanced toward Raghav’s jacket. “Honesty arrives with terrible timing.”

“No. We arrive late to it.”

Naina crossed to the dressing mirror. Her face did not reveal a transformed woman. Her hair was untidy, her mouth slightly swollen, her eyes too awake. She fastened the top button of her kurta and watched Ayaan turn away to give the gesture privacy, though he had just kissed the skin beneath it.

The restraint moved her more than pursuit would have.

“When we leave this room,” she said, “you do not wait for me to choose you.”

His reflection met hers. “I know.”

“You continue your life.”

“I was doing that before yesterday.”

“Were you?”

He considered the question. “Not as successfully as I claimed.”

The admission contained no request. That was why she believed it.

They changed into their own clothes. Naina placed the plans inside her portfolio, closed Raghav’s laptop, and opened the suite’s main door.

Before stepping out, she photographed the disturbed drawers, the contract metadata, and the unsigned appendix that used her name. She sent encrypted copies to a cloud folder, then to an old colleague at the conservation institute with a single instruction: **If I ask whether the rain reached Hyderabad, open everything.**

“Insurance?” Ayaan asked.

“Witness.”

He lifted both cameras. “I understand the distinction.”

They walked into the corridor separately.

Chapter Sixteen

Evidence of Rain

The wedding videographer caught them emerging from adjacent ends of the lake-wing corridor.

In the footage, Naina carried a portfolio and Ayaan carried two cameras. Both wore yesterday's clothes. Nothing about the image proved intimacy. Everything about their faces suggested a shared event.

Raghav arrived minutes later, soaked from the northern road.

His car had stopped beyond the flooded bend. He had crossed the last half kilometre on foot with two hotel workers, wading through water that reached their knees. By the time he entered the courtyard, news of his arrival moved ahead of him: the husband had come, the road had opened, the crisis had acquired the ending everyone preferred.

Naina watched guests turn toward him with relief. Raghav knew how to enter a room carrying resolution. It was one of the qualities she had loved first.

He pulled Naina into his arms.

She held him with the plans trapped between them.

"You came through the passage?" he asked.

"Yes."

His eyes moved to Ayaan. "Thank you for keeping her safe."

Ayaan answered, "She kept herself safe."

The sentence irritated Raghav. Naina saw it register and vanish.

"We need to talk," she said.

"After you sleep."

"Now."

The wedding planner interrupted: the haldi ceremony had been delayed, the groom's father was furious, and Meera refused to begin until she saw Naina.

Raghav touched Naina's face. "One hour. Then we talk."

Again, a conversation was assigned a time slot around someone else's urgency.

Naina let him go.

As Raghav was pulled toward the groom's father, his hand remained at the small of Naina's back for a second longer than necessary. The gesture was familiar, protective, and faintly proprietary. Yesterday she would not have separated those meanings.

Ayaan had already moved toward the equipment room. He did not look back. A smear of dried blood marked one sleeve where the iron ring had cut his palm.

Naina almost called after him. She did not.

Meera reached her first, barefoot beneath a borrowed shawl. "You are alive."

"Apparently that is today's dress code."

Meera tried to laugh and failed. Her gaze went from the portfolio to Naina's face. "Leela told me about the plans."

"Only the plans?"

Confusion answered before words did. "What else is there?"

"Later."

For once, Naina was the person postponing a conversation. The resemblance to Raghav unsettled her.

Raghav caught her hand before she could follow Meera. "Two minutes."

He led her into an empty breakfast alcove and closed the carved screen. Without the audience, his control loosened. He touched her arms, shoulders, and face as if checking for injuries the embrace had missed.

"You are freezing," he said.

"I changed twice. Everything got wet."

His hands stopped at her waist. "Did anything happen?"

The question contained fear before suspicion.

Naina looked at the man who had driven through storm debris to reach her. Mud marked his trousers. A shallow cut crossed his forehead. She wanted to place both hands around his face and return to the uncomplicated part of their marriage.

So she did.

Raghav closed his eyes against her palms. "I thought the road would take another hour. I kept imagining the roof coming down."

"It didn't."

"I know that now."

He kissed the inside of her wrist, then drew her against him. Naina held him. The body recognized marriage differently from desire: as repetition, shelter, grief, and the deep knowledge of how another person fit.

Raghav kissed her mouth.

She answered from habit and tenderness. Then the memory of Ayaan's mouth arrived, not as comparison but as fact. Her response faltered.

Raghav drew back. "What is it?"

"We need to talk."

"You keep saying that as if you are about to resign."

"Maybe I am."

His expression sharpened. "From what?"

The wedding planner called his name from the corridor.

Raghav looked toward the screen, then back at Naina. "One hour. I promise."

She had begun to understand that his promises were sincere at the moment he made them. That did not make them reliable.

The planner called again, more urgently. Raghav swore under his breath.

"Go," Naina said.

"You say that as if it is a test."

"It is information."

He studied her, not understanding. Then he left because the groom's father was waiting and because, in Raghav's world, the most powerful urgency in the room naturally became his responsibility.

Naina stayed behind the screen until the sound of his steps disappeared.

On the breakfast table someone had left a silver pot of tea, cold toast beneath a linen cover, and a newspaper swollen by damp. The normality of it made her suddenly hungry. She ate half a piece of toast standing up, her hands trembling only when they were no longer needed for danger.

Her phone found a weak signal. The encrypted files showed as delivered. Her colleague replied with a question mark, then: **Understood. Call when safe.**

Safe had become a word with too many meanings.

Through the carved screen, Naina saw the videographer replaying the corridor footage for two assistants. On the small monitor she and Ayaan appeared a few seconds apart, both turning at the sound of Raghav's arrival. The image did not show a kiss, a promise, or a hand under wet fabric. It showed only aftermath. Viewers would supply the story they preferred.

She stepped out.

"Please preserve that clip," she told the videographer.

He blinked. “Madam?”

“Do not delete it, crop it, or give it to anyone without Meera’s permission.”

His eyes sharpened with curiosity. “Of course.”

“And make a second copy.”

Evidence could accuse her. It could also establish when she had emerged, what she carried, and who arrived afterward. Shame asked to be hidden. Architecture had taught her to document load paths.

At the far end of the courtyard, Ayaan was binding his cut palm with black camera tape. Their eyes met. Naina did not smile, but she held his gaze long enough to let him know she had not retreated into denial.

Then she went to dress the bride.

Chapter Seventeen

The Haldi Smile

At haldi, everyone praised Naina's composure.

She wore a pale green sari borrowed from Meera's mother because her own clothes were still damp. A beautician had covered the exhaustion beneath her eyes. Turmeric, rosewater, and marigold filled the courtyard with a brightness that felt almost aggressive after the archive.

Women asked about the storm in delighted fragments. Was the roof truly falling? Had there been snakes? Was the photographer brave? Naina gave answers that were accurate enough to stop further questions. The passage became an adventure before breakfast was over.

No one asked what had been worth hiding beneath the palace for more than a century.

Meera embraced her hard enough to crease both their clothes. "I am so sorry."

"We will discuss your talent for manipulation after you are married."

"My talent?"

Naina realized Meera did not yet know the full design. Leela had protected her.

Across the courtyard, Ayaan photographed turmeric flying through sunlight. He never aimed at Naina until Raghav joined her.

Then the shutter clicked.

Raghav's palm settled at her waist for the photograph. Naina felt the exact place where Ayaan's hand had rested hours earlier. Her body remembered both touches without confusing them, which seemed more disloyal than comparison.

"Smile," Raghav murmured.

She did. The camera captured an exemplary marriage.

Raghav told guests how Naina had rescued historical plans. He sounded proud, as though her discovery belonged naturally inside the property deal.

"The documents need independent custody," she told him.

"Of course."

"And the demolition recommendation must be withdrawn."

His smile held. "We have not made any recommendation."

"I saw your report."

For the first time in their marriage, Naina watched Raghav decide whether to lie.

"It was preliminary," he said.

"You brought my pen."

"Because I hoped you would consult. Your signature would have strengthened the preservation review."

"The contract says the interior has no significance."

"Based on the information available then."

"Information you did not ask me to verify."

Guests moved around them, laughing and yellow with turmeric.

Raghav lowered his voice. "This is not the place."

"You chose the place when you brought the contract to a wedding."

A camera shutter sounded again.

Raghav looked toward Ayaan. Something changed in his face.

It was not recognition of the kiss; he could not know that yet. It was recognition of attention. Raghav had spent years entering rooms certain that Naina's awareness would reorganize itself around him. Now he saw another man refusing to look away from what she had become.

He waited until the next burst of turmeric drew the guests' attention, then took Naina by the elbow and guided her behind a floral screen.

"Did he know about the survey?" Raghav asked.

"No."

"You are certain."

"I asked him."

"When? During the night you spent alone together?"

Naina removed his hand from her arm. "Do not reduce what happened because you are afraid of it."

"Then tell me what happened."

Meera's cousins ran past them carrying bowls of turmeric. Music covered the silence.

"We found the archive. Someone entered through the service passage. We recovered plans your survey said did not exist."

"That is not what I asked."

"It is what matters to the building."

"I am not married to the building."

"No. You only made decisions about both of us without consultation."

Raghav flinched as though she had struck him. "I brought the contract because I wanted your expertise."

"You brought my pen."

"Because you always use it for important documents."

The tenderness of the detail made his presumption worse.

"You had already promised them my agreement," she said.

"I said you would review it."

"Did you tell them I might refuse?"

He did not answer.

Across the courtyard, Ayaan lowered his camera. He did not intervene, did not rescue her from a conversation he had helped make unavoidable.

Raghav followed her gaze. "You look at him before answering me."

"I looked because you did."

"Naina, I drove through a landslide to reach you."

"And I am grateful. But courage in a storm does not erase secrecy in daylight."

"Was he courageous?"

The question was ugly and wounded. She refused it.

"We will speak after the ceremony," she said.

"You demanded now an hour ago."

"An hour ago I still thought you wanted the truth."

Raghav's face closed. "Do not perform this in public."

"I am trying to prevent your contract from becoming public fact."

"And he is photographing every moment."

"Ayaan is working."

"He has always been very professional around you."

The sarcasm landed because it contained history. Naina remembered the Delhi exhibition, the unanswered message, Raghav arriving with flowers after missing her opening talk. For years she had treated those memories as separate rooms. The storm had opened doors between them.

"Do not use what you suspect to avoid what you know," she said.

"What I know is that my wife disappeared overnight with a man who once loved her and returned unwilling to let me touch her."

The accusation was quiet enough that no guest heard. It still felt public.

“You touched me,” she said. “I held you. I kissed you. My confusion does not cancel what was real between us this morning.”

Raghav’s anger faltered. He had expected denial or confession, not precision.

“Then help me understand.”

“I have been asking you to make room for that conversation.”

“There is a wedding happening.”

“There is always something happening.”

A child pushed through the floral screen and pressed a turmeric-covered hand against Raghav’s white kurta. The boy’s mother apologized profusely. Raghav smiled, told her it was auspicious, and returned to Naina with yellow fingers printed over his heart.

The image was so absurdly tender that she nearly cried.

“After the ceremony,” he said again.

This time Naina did not agree. “At lunch, the plans go into independent custody. Your firm issues a written hold on demolition. Then we speak.”

“You are giving me conditions?”

“I am telling you what I will do.”

That distinction had been missing from their marriage long before either of them noticed.

She returned to Meera. Ayaan lifted his camera, then lowered it when Naina shook her head. The moment remained undocumented.

During the next ritual, Meera’s aunts rubbed turmeric along Naina’s cheeks despite her protests. Raghav watched from across the courtyard, stained hand curled at his side. Ayaan photographed the bride.

For twelve minutes, everyone performed the roles assigned to them.

Chapter Eighteen

The Missing Anklet

Meera learned the truth from Leela before the wedding ceremony.

She found Naina in the dressing room and locked the door.

Outside, cousins called for missing safety pins and someone tested the wedding music at twice the necessary volume. Inside, the air conditioner rattled above racks of red silk. Meera's veil lay across the bed like spilled colour.

"I did not send you there to be alone with Ayaan," she said.

"I know."

"Leela used me."

"She used all of us."

"I gave her his number," Meera said. "I told her which train he was taking. I thought I was arranging one honest conversation, not building a trap."

"You were arranging a version of me you preferred."

Meera accepted the sentence without defending herself.

"You kept talking about Delhi," she said. "Not him exactly. The person you were there. You sounded alive even when you complained. Then you married Raghav and became so competent at happiness that no one knew whether you felt it."

"Including me."

"Especially you."

"Did anything happen?"

Naina looked at her friend.

"That is not your question to ask today."

Meera sat beside her. "Then I'll ask the question I have earned. Are you going to lie to Raghav?"

"No."

"Do you know what the truth will cost?"

"No."

"Good. People who know the cost usually purchase the cheaper version."

Meera took Naina's hands. Bridal bangles clicked against the plain gold ring on Naina's finger.

"Did you want something to happen?" she asked.

Naina could have protected them both with anger. Instead she said, "Yes."

Meera's breath left her slowly.

"And did it?"

"We kissed."

"Once?"

"Twice. We stopped."

Meera stood and crossed the small dressing room. For several seconds she adjusted flowers that did not need adjustment.

"I invited him because I thought you deserved closure," she said.

"Closure is what people call a door they want someone else to shut."

"I did not think you would be stranded."

"I know."

"I did not think you would—"

"Want him?"

Meera turned. "You love Raghav."

"Yes."

"Then how can both be true?"

"That is the first useful question anyone has asked me."

Meera removed one earring and began fastening it again merely to have a task. "I am about to promise one person the rest of my life, and you are telling me love can remain true while something else becomes true beside it."

"I am telling you nothing that useful. I do not know whether wanting Ayaan is a truth about him, about me, or about the life I stopped choosing."

"Does the difference matter?"

"It matters to everyone I might hurt."

Meera met her eyes in the mirror. "And what about the person you keep hurting by refusing to know?"

Naina had no answer that did not sound selfish. She was beginning to suspect that adulthood contained necessary selfishness as well as cruel selfishness, and that no one could distinguish them in advance.

The bride sat again, her anger dissolving into fear. "What are you going to do?"

"Tell Raghav. Preserve the plans. Refuse the contract. After that, I don't know."

"And Ayaan?"

Naina remembered his hand withdrawing the instant she said stop. "He is not a reward for leaving my marriage."

"That sounds rehearsed."

"It is the only sentence keeping me honest."

Meera squeezed her fingers. "I am sorry I arranged people as if feelings were seating cards."

"You are getting married in an hour. We can discuss your crimes after photographs."

"You are still coming?"

"I will not punish you during your wedding because I have finally become inconvenient."

Meera laughed through tears. "There she is."

Naina wondered which version her friend meant.

Meera reached for her veil and stopped. "Dev and I have not agreed about children."

Naina looked at her.

"He thinks we have agreed because I said not now and he heard later. I think we have agreed because he said we will decide together and I heard maybe never."

"Meera."

"I know. Excellent day to discover language has consequences."

The bride sat on the edge of the bed, suddenly smaller beneath the jewellery. "I arranged you and Ayaan because unfinished love seemed romantic. My own unfinished conversation was apparently less decorative."

Naina sat beside her. "Tell him before the vows."

"Today?"

"Before everyone claps loudly enough for you to pretend agreement happened."

Meera gave a frightened laugh. "You have become unbearable."

"The condition may be contagious."

For several seconds they held hands, two women in a locked room refusing the efficient lies waiting outside.

Together they examined the anklet. Inside the clasp was a curl of blue thread identical to the one tied to the brass key. Leela had marked the path deliberately.

The erased atelier, the blue doors, the thread, the key: a chain of evidence designed to be found by an architect who understood that circulation was a form of power.

Naina turned the anklet over beneath the dressing lights. Fine scratches crossed the inner surface beside the thread. They were not random wear. Seven short lines had been cut into the silver, followed by two longer ones.

“Measurements,” she said.

“Of what?”

She took a lipstick from the table and copied the marks onto tissue paper. Their proportions matched the narrow bays shown along the atelier’s western wall. The seventh bay opened onto the passage.

Zohra Banu had reduced a route to jewellery: architecture worn against the body, portable enough to survive an inventory.

“Leela did not invent the trail,” Naina said. “She completed it.”

Meera stared at the anklet she had treated as a family ornament. “How long have we been wearing evidence without knowing what it said?”

“Most buildings are full of answers no one has learned to read.”

Naina photographed the marks beside a scale, wrapped the anklet in acid-free tissue from her portfolio, and wrote the date, time, room, and names of both witnesses on the envelope.

Meera signed beneath hers in bridal henna.

“Save the building,” Meera said. “Then save yourself.”

“In which order?”

“Whichever one is still standing.”

A knock came at the door. Dev’s voice asked whether Meera was ready.

The bride and Naina looked at one another.

“Five minutes,” Meera called.

Then she opened the door only wide enough to pull her future husband inside.

Naina left them with the conversation they should have had months ago. In the corridor, she placed the sealed anklet beside the plans and understood that preservation was not the opposite of change. Sometimes it was the condition that allowed change to happen honestly.

Chapter Nineteen

The Offer

Dev's father announced the partnership at the wedding lunch.

The announcement came between the final toast and dessert, when guests were relaxed enough to applaud anything described as legacy. A screen descended over the carved doors. Renderings appeared: infinity pool, glass-roofed restaurant, twelve suites occupying the atelier wing. In each image, the old stone survived only as texture behind new furniture.

Naina recognized Raghav's presentation style. Clean sightlines. Sparse captions. Problems translated into opportunities before anyone could mourn them.

Surya Garh would become the flagship of a luxury heritage chain. Raghav would lead the transformation. Twelve new suites would open the following year.

Applause filled the courtyard.

Raghav did not stand. His surprise was genuine, but the partnership logo already shared space with his firm's name on the screen. Surprise had not prevented preparation.

Dev's father raised a glass toward him. "To the man who knows how to honour history without being imprisoned by it."

The sentence clarified the entire project.

Naina remained seated.

Raghav had not known about the announcement, but he had known about the offer. The distinction no longer mattered.

When he reached for her hand, she placed the signed 1891 plan on the table between them.

"There will be no twelve suites," she said.

The microphone at the lectern was still live. Her voice carried farther than she intended.

Conversation thinned across the courtyard.

Dev's father smiled as though humouring a guest. "The wing is structurally unsound."

"Parts of it are. It is also the only surviving women's industrial atelier of its period in the region, designed by a named female master builder."

"A charming theory."

“With payroll records, plans, inscriptions, and photographic documentation.”

Naina stood and walked to the screen. “The rendering places bathrooms through the load-bearing bays of an 1891 atelier. It removes the lime channels that carried water to the dyeing floor and cuts new drainage through the only intact series of workstations.”

The architect in her took over where the wife might have hesitated. She pointed to the glowing image.

“Those irregular walls are not failed hotel rooms. They were built for looms. The narrow openings control heat and dust. The service passage allowed workers to move finished cloth without crossing the public court. Every feature described as an obstacle in the report is evidence of use.”

Several guests lifted their phones. Dev’s father glanced at the event manager, who hurried toward the sound desk.

“Leave the screen on,” Meera said.

She had entered beside Dev, her veil slightly crooked and her eyes swollen from a private conversation. Dev looked unsettled, but he remained beside her.

The man’s smile vanished.

Raghav leaned toward her. “Naina, let us verify before making claims.”

“I am an architect. Verification is what I did while you were preparing to erase it.”

Guests had begun to listen.

Dev stood. Meera took his hand and kept him standing beside her.

“The wedding trust owns the old wing jointly,” she said. “Nothing will be demolished until the archive is reviewed.”

The groom stared at his bride, discovering a negotiation inside the ceremony.

Then he took the microphone from his father.

“Meera is correct,” Dev said. “The trust requires both our signatures after today.”

His father’s expression hardened. “This was settled.”

“It was discussed before I became a trustee. That is not the same thing.”

Meera’s fingers found his. Whatever they had said behind the dressing-room door had not solved their future. It had at least made agreement visible.

Raghav rose. “No responsible decision should be made from documents recovered in a flood without authentication.”

“Agreed,” Naina said. “So issue a preservation hold.”

He looked at her across the table. The request was professionally ordinary and personally devastating. If he agreed, he threatened the partnership. If he refused, he confirmed that verification had never been the goal.

“Seventy-two hours,” he said. “No intervention in the old wing until an independent conservator reviews the material.”

Dev’s father began to object.

“In writing,” Naina said.

Raghav’s jaw tightened. “In writing.”

It was not victory. It was time, which in preservation work was often the first form victory took.

Raghav asked Naina to come outside.

At the lake, his control finally broke.

Wind disturbed the floating marigolds left from the morning rituals. Behind them, applause restarted uncertainly as the band attempted to rescue the lunch. The celebration continued because celebrations were machines built to absorb private catastrophe.

“Do you understand what you just did?”

“Yes.”

“You humiliated me in front of the board.”

“You asked me to sign away a building without telling me.”

“I was going to show you everything.”

“When?”

“After the wedding.”

“After the announcement.”

“I did not authorize the announcement.”

“You authorized everything required for it to be possible.”

“That is how proposals work. We prepare before certainty.”

“You prepared my consent before asking for it.”

Raghav dragged both hands through his wet hair. “Your name was in an internal appendix because you are the best conservation architect I know.”

“Then you knew I might disagree.”

“I knew I could persuade you.”

There it was: not malice, not fraud in the form he would recognize, only confidence so complete it had made her autonomy seem procedural.

He looked toward the old wing. "This partnership changes our lives."

"You mean improves them."

"Is that a crime?"

"No. But you keep improving my life until there is no part of it I chose."

Raghav stared at her as though she had spoken in a language he had funded but never learned.

"This is about him," he said.

"Not yet."

The answer frightened them both.

Raghav looked back through the arches. Ayaan remained near the far wall, camera lowered, making no claim on the confrontation.

"Not yet means eventually," Raghav said.

"Not yet means this marriage was already in trouble before he returned."

"We were not in trouble."

"I left my firm three months ago. Do you know why?"

"You were exhausted."

"I could no longer recognize my own work."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because you would have solved it."

"That is what partners do."

"Sometimes partners listen while the problem remains unsolved."

Raghav paced to the water's edge and back. "So this is my failure? I worked too much, planned too much, tried to give us too much?"

"No. My failure was accepting every plan and calling my silence agreement."

The answer interrupted the defence he had prepared.

"Did you kiss him?" he asked.

Naina's heart struck once, hard. The wedding music continued behind them. She could have told him here, before guests and cameras, but truth used as a weapon was only another form of control.

"We will speak in private."

"That is a yes."

"It is a boundary. You are not the only person allowed to choose when a conversation happens."

His face changed from anger to something more frightened. "Are you leaving me?"

"I don't know."

"For him?"

"For myself, if I leave. That is the only answer I can give you honestly."

Raghav looked at the palace they had entered as a successful married couple less than two days earlier. "I thought we were happy."

"We were. Sometimes. That is why this hurts."

Raghav sat on the low parapet. For the first time since arriving, he looked tired rather than controlled.

"When your father was ill," he said, "I rearranged six months of work. When your firm delayed your partnership, I told you to leave because they did not deserve you. When you could not sleep, I learned every tea you would drink after midnight. I thought that was love."

"It was."

"Then why are you speaking as if I erased you?"

Naina sat at the opposite end of the stone. "Because love can be real and still become a room where one person keeps deciding where the doors belong."

He looked toward the lake. "And Ayaan gives you doors?"

"Ayaan asks before touching a handle."

She regretted the sentence as soon as she heard it. Not because it was false, but because it gave Raghav a fragment of the confession without the dignity of the whole.

His head turned slowly. "Touching what?"

Naina's pulse climbed.

Wedding guests moved behind the lattice. A camera lens flashed and vanished. Whatever she said here could become evidence stripped of tenderness and context.

"Not beside a lake where anyone can record us," she said.

"You expect me to attend the rest of this wedding beside you?"

"No. I expect neither of us to turn pain into theatre."

Raghav stood. "You already did that at lunch."

"I challenged a demolition in public because it was announced in public. Our marriage is not a development proposal."

He laughed once, without humour. "You found your voice in one night."

"No. I found evidence of how long I had been refusing to use it."

The cruelty would have been easier if either could make the marriage entirely false. Neither could.

From the courtyard came the first notes of the bridal procession. Raghav offered Naina his hand automatically to help her rise. They both stared at it.

After a moment, she took it.

His fingers closed around hers with the old competence. He released her as soon as she was standing.

“After the vows,” he said.

“In our room. Door closed. No interruptions.”

“And you will answer me?”

“Yes.”

They walked back separately, carrying the knowledge that the next private room would not protect their marriage from the truth. It would only protect the truth from spectators.

Chapter Twenty

The Photograph

The preview slideshow began after dinner, when the reception had softened from ceremony into celebration.

The temporary screen stood between two carved pillars in the lake courtyard. Fairy lights trembled in the wind. Guests held silver bowls of saffron ice cream and called out when they recognized themselves: Dev attempting a dance step his cousins had taught him, Meera laughing beneath a fall of marigolds, Leela scolding a waiter while secretly stealing a sweet from his tray.

Naina sat beside Raghav in the second row. His knee touched hers. They had not yet resumed the argument from the haldi courtyard, and the contact between them felt like a treaty neither had signed.

The images moved through jewellery, dancing, rain.

Then the hidden gallery filled the screen.

Naina stood in Ayaan's borrowed clothes beside the names carved into the wall. Her hair was damp and uncombed. One shoulder of the grey shirt had slipped lower than the other. She was not smiling, yet something in her face was open—attention without performance, fear without surrender.

A collective murmur passed through the guests.

Ayaan had not selected the photograph. Naina knew that before she looked toward the technical table and saw him go still.

The image remained for six seconds. It felt longer.

It was beautiful. That was its danger. It made their night inside the sealed wing look less like an emergency than a private country. Naina appeared more alive than she did in any of the reception photographs, and everyone in the courtyard had been invited to wonder why.

Raghav watched her watching herself.

The next image appeared.

At first it seemed to be another view of the carved wall. Then the eye found the old rectangle of glass at its edge. In that dark reflection stood Ayaan, his camera lowered, looking at Naina rather than through the lens.

The courtyard quieted so completely that Naina heard the projector fan.

The slideshow went black.

For one second the dark screen reflected the courtyard back at itself: rows of guests, silver bowls paused halfway to mouths, the newly married couple standing beneath flowers, Naina and Raghav seated together like the subject of an accusation.

Whispers began before the lights returned.

Someone behind Naina said Ayaan's name. Someone else used the word *affair* with the satisfaction of a person identifying a familiar plot. The image had offered no proof of touch, yet it had made restraint look more intimate than exposure.

Dev's father rose and ordered the equipment removed. His anger traveled instantly toward the nearest employee, then the next. Meera crossed the courtyard in front of everyone and demanded the laptop. A cousin began telling guests it was a technical mistake. The explanation spread with the speed of scandal and convinced no one.

Ayaan was already checking the drives at his workstation. Naina saw him open one folder, then another. His face changed.

"The private folder was accessed," he told Meera. "The export history has been cleared."

"When?" Naina asked.

Ayaan looked at the file directory. "Between the haldi and lunch. The original is still locked. Someone copied the preview cache."

"Who had the password?"

"Me, my assistant, and the media coordinator appointed by Dev's family."

Across the courtyard, the coordinator was already removing a cable from the projector. When he noticed them watching, he bent lower over the equipment.

The slideshow had not humiliated them by accident. Someone had seen the growing dispute over Neel Mahal and understood that a suggestive photograph could turn an architectural objection into the revenge of an unfaithful wife.

Naina felt shame rise automatically, hot and obedient. Then anger replaced it. Whatever she had done to her marriage, the image belonged to neither the hotel nor the guests.

"Can you prove who did it?"

"Not yet."

Raghav stood.

He did not look at Naina before walking away.

She followed him through the musicians' corridor and up the stairs. The palace had absorbed the reception's sound; by the time they reached their suite, the drums were only a pulse inside the walls.

Raghav entered, took off his jacket, and laid it across the back of a chair with unbearable care.

"Close the door," he said.

Naina did.

The room was still dressed for a wedding. Jasmine lay in bowls on the tables. Gold thread gleamed along the coverlet. Someone had left two glasses and a bottle of champagne in a silver bucket, as if any marriage entering this room must naturally have something to celebrate.

Raghav stood before the window. His reflection floated over the black lake.

For several moments he said nothing. Naina heard the faint clink of melting ice, the air conditioner, the distant band beginning another song as though rhythm could restore order.

"Was that how he saw you all night?" Raghav asked.

"No."

"How did he see you?"

The question was not about clothing. It was about the face on the screen—the unguarded woman Raghav feared had existed for someone else and never for him.

"He saw me frightened," she said. "Angry. Unreasonable. Interested. He did not require one version to cancel the others."

"And I did?"

"Sometimes I helped you."

"Did he touch you?"

The question came quietly. Its quietness made it worse.

Naina could have answered no in the way he meant. She could have said that no clothing had been removed, that she had slept alone, that Ayaan had stopped each time she asked. She could have offered details like legal clauses and hoped their narrow accuracy would disguise the truth.

She refused the simplicity of the question.

"I kissed him."

Raghav turned.

For a moment he looked as if he had not understood the language. Then he sat on the edge of the bed, elbows on his knees.

“Once?”

“Twice.”

His gaze went to the carpet. “The first night?”

“Yes.”

“And today?”

“In the archive.”

He breathed in through his nose. “Did you sleep with him?”

“No.”

Raghav closed his eyes briefly. Relief entered his face before he could prevent it, followed by shame at the relief.

“How far?” he asked.

Naina understood the cruelty of inventory. He wanted a boundary he could place between betrayal and catastrophe. She also understood that refusing every detail would leave imagination to become its own violence.

“We kissed. He touched my waist, my back, my neck. I asked him to stop. He stopped.”

“And then you kissed him again.”

“Yes.”

“So stopping was temporary.”

“It was still real.”

Raghav laughed without humour. “You are defending his manners to your husband.”

“I am telling you what happened.”

“You are choosing language that makes him safe and me controlling.”

“I am trying not to choose language that makes anyone simpler than they were.”

“Did you want to?”

Naina’s throat tightened. “Part of me did.”

Raghav flinched as if she had struck him.

“Do you love him?”

Her silence was not an answer, but it injured like one.

He covered his face with both hands. Naina remained beside the door, hating the distance between them and afraid of what closing it would imply. When he looked up, anger had arrived to protect whatever the shock had exposed.

"You told me you were safe."

"I was."

"With him."

"Yes."

"Do you hear yourself?" Raghav stood. "You were trapped overnight with a man you nearly left me for, and you decided that was safety?"

"I was safe from the storm. I was safe with him because he listened when I said stop."

Raghav stared at her. "Is that accusation meant for me?"

"It is an answer."

"And while I crossed a flooded road to reach you—"

"I did not kiss him because you failed to rescue me."

"Then why?"

There were kinder answers. Loneliness. History. Fear. Rain. The belief that they might die before morning. Every one of them was true, and none was the center of it.

"Because I wanted to."

The honest answer was brutal. She let it remain honest.

Raghav crossed the room, stopped, then crossed back. "You keep talking as if honesty makes this noble."

"It does not."

"As if wanting something is a defense."

"It is not."

"Then say you are sorry."

Naina looked at the man whose hand she had held through her mother's surgery, whose shirts she had chosen on rushed mornings, whose sleeping face she knew better than her own. Grief did not erase responsibility. Love did not make confession clean.

"I am sorry I betrayed what we promised," she said. "I am sorry you learned in a room full of people. I am sorry I waited until an image forced me to speak."

His eyes shone. "But not that you kissed him."

"I don't know how to be sorry for feeling awake."

"You could be sorry that you needed another man to wake you."

"I am."

The answer stopped him.

"I am sorry I let my life become so quiet that desire felt like rescue," she continued. "I am sorry I did not speak before silence became resentment. I am sorry I made you responsible for needs I refused to name. But I will not claim the feeling was false merely because acting on it hurt you."

Raghav sat again. His hands hung between his knees.

"I would have changed," he said.

"If I had asked?"

"Yes."

"For how long?"

His head lifted sharply.

"That was unfair," Naina said. "But I do not know. We changed things after every argument. Then work became urgent, family became urgent, the next plan became urgent, and I became efficient enough not to interrupt."

"You are describing a marriage, Naina. People become ordinary to each other."

"Ordinary is not the same as invisible."

The cruelty of it entered the room and stayed there.

Raghav turned away. "Were you asleep with me?"

"No. Not always."

"That is not what I asked."

"Then yes," she said, and her voice broke. "In some parts of my life, yes."

He stood at the blue door that opened into the service passage. His fingers rested on the old brass latch.

"All these years, I thought you chose me."

"I did."

"Apparently not enough."

"A choice made once does not survive without being made again."

"I made it every day."

"You made decisions every day. That is not the same thing."

He looked at her then, and beneath the anger she saw the man who had believed his competence was tenderness, that providing answers was the same as asking questions. She also saw how often she had rewarded the mistake because it was easier than naming what she needed.

“Maybe you should go find out what you choose now,” he said.

Naina’s eyes filled. “Do you want me to leave?”

“I want the last two days not to exist.”

“That is not an answer.”

“Now you want answers.”

The bitterness was deserved. She accepted it.

Raghav crossed to the wardrobe and pulled down his overnight bag. He folded shirts with the same concentration he brought to project meetings. Naina watched him place socks beside a laptop charger, domestic order surviving the collapse of its purpose.

“I did not leak those photographs,” he said without turning.

“I did not think you did.”

“Part of you did.”

Part of her had wondered. The contract on his laptop, the disturbed drawers, the professional usefulness of discrediting her. Trust had fractured so quickly that even rejecting the suspicion required effort.

“Part of me no longer knows what you would justify as necessary,” she said.

Raghav stopped folding.

“And part of me no longer knows which truth you will call freedom,” he replied.

They looked at each other across the open suitcase. Neither accusation was wholly fair. Neither was invented.

He opened the door and disappeared into the service passage.

At the threshold he paused without looking back. “I crossed the road because the thought of losing you was unbearable.”

Naina pressed a hand to her mouth.

“I know.”

“That does not make me good enough to keep you.”

“No.” Her voice broke. “But it was love.”

He nodded once and left.

Naina remained in the flower-scented room until the ice melted around the unopened champagne.

Chapter Twenty One

Meera's Secret

By morning, the wedding was over and the preservation fight had begun.

Workers dismantled the floral canopy while government offices opened in Jaipur. The lake courtyard smelled of extinguished lamps and wet rope. Families who had danced together hours earlier divided into legal camps over breakfast.

Naina had slept for less than an hour. Raghav's suitcase was gone when she returned to the suite. His message contained four words: *I am going home.*

No accusation. No instruction. The absence of both frightened her.

Meera found her in the seventh courtyard, photographing the cracks that ran above the atelier door. The bride had replaced her embroidered lehenga with a plain cotton kurta. Henna still covered her hands; the design made every document she carried look ceremonial.

"I need to tell you something before somebody else does," Meera said.

"That sentence has not served anyone well this week."

Meera accepted the rebuke. She confessed that Naina's invitation had not been innocent. Dev's family had pressured her to surrender the trust's share of Neel Mahal as part of an informal marriage settlement. The signatures were supposed to happen after the reception, quietly, while the families were still gathered and refusal could be treated as insult.

Meera had needed an independent architect to see the sealed wing before demolition erased whatever it contained. She had hoped Naina would inspect it casually, find enough structural or historical concern to force a delay, and never know she had been recruited.

"Dev knew?" Naina asked.

"He knew I was delaying the trust transfer. He did not know I brought you here for that reason."

"So you began your marriage with a secret plan to stop his family."

Meera looked toward the courtyard where Dev was speaking to lawyers beneath the dismantled canopy. "I began it by telling him before the vows. He was furious."

"And he still married you."

“After we agreed that staying was not the same as forgiving. We postponed the trust signatures. We also finally said what we meant about children.”

“What did you decide?”

“That we have not decided.”

For the first time, Meera seemed relieved by uncertainty rather than ashamed of it.

“I never planned the storm or Ayaan,” Meera said. “But I knew he would come if you did.”

Naina lowered her camera.

“You arranged that too.”

“I asked him to document the wedding because he is good, and because—”

“Because you wanted us in the same place.”

“I thought you deserved one honest conversation.”

Naina laughed once, without amusement. “Everyone keeps arranging my choices and calling the result fate.”

Meera looked down at the henna-darkened names on her hands. “You are right.”

“You endangered my marriage.”

“You are right.”

“You endangered our friendship.”

“Yes.”

“That does not repair it.”

“No.”

Naina had wanted resistance, something against which anger could remain simple. Meera’s unqualified guilt left her with nowhere to place it.

“Why didn’t you ask me?”

“Because I thought you would say no.”

“Then you knew you did not have my consent.”

Meera closed her eyes. “Yes.”

“You do not get to call the outcome good enough to justify the method.”

“I know.”

“And if the building had contained nothing?”

“I would still have used you.”

Naina turned away. The precision of the confession cut deeper than excuse would have. Meera had not merely reunited two former lovers. She had treated Naina's marriage, history, and professional instinct as materials available for a rescue plan.

"I may forgive you," Naina said. "But not today, and not because you are sorry."

Meera nodded. "I will not make your forgiveness another thing I arrange."

The admission cost them both. Naina turned back to the wall, measured the crack, and wrote the figure in her notebook.

"Give me the trust papers," she said. "After that, do not ask me to forgive you because we saved the building."

Meera transferred digital copies of the estate documents. The trust deed contained a clause no one at breakfast had mentioned: any discovery of historical significance required review by the state heritage board before alteration, sale, or demolition.

For the next five hours, they worked.

Leela recorded a sworn statement about the sealed rooms and the attempts to remove the trunks. Ayaan supplied photographs with timestamps and untouched metadata. Naina prepared an emergency architectural assessment describing the water damage, the eighteenth-century paint layers, and the risk of deliberate loss.

Meera called a lawyer. Dev called another. Dev's father threatened to have every outsider removed from the property, but the first email had already reached the heritage directorate.

Ayaan's assistant recovered a device log from the presentation laptop before the media team could wipe it. The private preview cache had been copied to an external drive registered to Dev's father's communications consultant. The consultant claimed the images had entered the slideshow accidentally.

"Accidents do not clear export histories," Ayaan said.

Dev read the report twice. Then he dismissed the consultant in front of his father.

The older man called it an overreaction.

"You tried to make Naina's evidence look like revenge," Dev said. "You used my wedding to do it."

"I protected this family from a public attack."

"No. You created one."

The confrontation moved behind closed doors, but the distinction remained. Naina's betrayal of Raghav was real. So was the deliberate use of that betrayal to discredit her work. Refusing one truth would not strengthen the other.

Raghav supplied nothing.

He had checked out before dawn and returned to Hyderabad. His phone went directly to voicemail. Naina recorded no message.

By late afternoon, she was alone in the courtyard, kneeling beside a fallen fragment of plaster. The wedding decorations had vanished. Without flowers and music, the space appeared larger and more severe, as if celebration had merely been a costume the building had tolerated.

Ayaan entered without his camera.

He stopped several feet away. "How is he?"

"Gone."

"Naina—"

"Do not apologize to me for my decision."

"I was going to ask whether you had eaten."

She looked at him. "No."

He set a covered plate on the stone ledge and did not press it into her hands.

It held dal, rice, and two pieces of the wedding sweet she had watched Leela steal the night before. Naina ate because he remained far enough away not to turn care into courtship.

"Did you know the photograph was in the cache?" she asked.

"I knew every photograph was in the cache. I did not know anyone else had copied it."

"Why did you keep that one?"

Ayaan looked toward the gallery entrance. "Because it was beautiful."

"That is not enough."

"Because you looked like yourself before deciding whether anyone would approve."

The answer disturbed her because it resembled what Raghav had feared.

"You do not know which face is most myself."

"No," he said. "Neither do you yet."

He accepted the rebuke without surrendering the observation.

"Come with me," he said.

For one dangerous moment she wanted him to mean forever. She imagined leaving through the gate with him, getting into whatever car waited beyond it, allowing motion to disguise itself as choice.

He led her only to the hidden gallery.

Morning and afternoon light entered the room differently. At this hour, the sun passed through a high lattice and struck the wall beneath the carved names. A line of shallow letters appeared where they had seen only scratches during the storm.

Together they cleared the loose dust with soft brushes.

No door is freedom if another person holds the key.

Naina read it twice.

“Did you know?” she asked.

“I noticed marks in the photograph. I did not know what they said.”

She touched the brass key in her pocket. Leela had given it to her as evidence and as a burden. “All week people have been opening doors for me.”

“Then perhaps the next one should stay closed until you decide.”

Ayaan’s restraint moved through her more dangerously than persuasion would have. She stepped closer. He did not move.

“If I asked you to take me away from here,” she said, “would you?”

His face changed, desire and caution arriving together.

“Yes,” he said. “And tomorrow I would ask whether you had chosen me or merely escaped with the nearest open door.”

She looked at his mouth and remembered it against hers. The wanting remained—warm, specific, no longer protected by darkness. But wanting was not yet a life.

“I need to go home.”

Ayaan nodded.

His hand lifted, then stopped between them. Naina closed the distance and placed her palm against it. Their fingers held for one breath, two. No secret room. No stolen kiss. The contact was almost chaste and therefore unbearably intimate.

“Do not wait for me,” she said.

“I have already made that mistake once.”

“Is that a yes?”

“It is me trying to have a life without pretending I don’t want you in it.”

Naina let go.

Before leaving the gallery, she took the brass key from her pocket and placed it on the ledge between them.

“Leela gave this to me,” she said.

“Keep it.”

“I do not want to confuse possession with freedom.”

Ayaan considered the key. "Then give it to the archive."

Together they found an evidence envelope. Naina labelled it with the same pen she had used for the anklet. Ayaan signed as witness. Their names appeared beside each other without secrecy or promise.

At the palace gate, a hired car waited to take her to the station. Ayaan carried the portfolio but not her suitcase. The distinction was deliberate: he helped protect the work and left her capable of leaving under her own weight.

"Will you tell me when you arrive?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Because I am worried, not because I have a claim."

"I know."

She touched the tape around his injured palm. The contact lasted only a second.

"Let it heal," she said.

Neither of them pretended she meant only the cut.

He did not ask her to come to Delhi.

Chapter Twenty Two

Husband and Wife

Their Hyderabad apartment looked staged after the palace.

The cushions were square. The glass table held no dust. The painting above the sofa—chosen because its blue matched the rug—hung exactly where it had hung when they left. Naina stood in the entrance with her suitcase and understood that order could be another way a room refused to testify.

Raghav's shoes were beside the console. One pair, neatly aligned.

She found him at the dining table with the blue notebook open before him. He wore the shirt he had traveled in. A cup of coffee had gone cold by his hand.

A wedding ring lay beside the cup.

For one startled second she looked at her own hand. The ring was still there. The one on the table was his.

"Are you ending this before we speak?" she asked.

"I took it off because I kept looking at it as if it could tell me what happened."

He turned it once against the wood. "It could not."

"You took this from the palace," he said.

"It is mine."

"I know."

He turned the notebook so that she could see the page. It held sketches from the year before their wedding: courtyards, staircases, a train platform, the outline of Ayaan's hand around a paper cup.

"I knew about him."

Naina set down her bag. "How?"

"Your father told me before the wedding. He said a photographer had come to the apartment. He said you were confused, but that you had chosen stability."

"Stability." The word sounded like a feature listed in a property brochure.

"He asked me not to embarrass you by bringing it up."

"And you never asked me."

"I thought not asking was kindness."

"It was certainty."

“Your father said you needed someone who would not make your life unstable.”

“And you believed him.”

“I wanted to.” Raghav looked at the sketches. “I was twenty-nine and already successful enough to confuse being chosen with being correct. He offered me the role of reliable husband. I never asked what it cost you to make me fit it.”

Naina sat opposite him. “I helped.”

“Yes. You made gratitude look so much like love that I stopped checking which one I was receiving.”

“It was love.”

“And gratitude.”

“Yes.”

They had spent years demanding that feelings arrive one at a time. The marriage had become crowded with truths they had treated as mutually exclusive.

Raghav rubbed his thumb along the edge of the notebook. “You loved that about me.”

“I did.”

There had been relief in his certainty. During their engagement, he had known where they would live, which bank would give them the best loan, when they should tell their families about trying for a child. Naina had mistaken the absence of doubt for the presence of safety. Sometimes it had been safety. Sometimes it had merely left no room for her uncertainty.

He pushed the notebook toward her. “I built our marriage around being the man who stayed. I thought your sacrifice proved you loved me.”

“It proved I was afraid.”

“Of marrying me?”

“Of wanting a life I could not explain. Of disappointing everyone. Of choosing a person who could leave.”

“And I could not leave.”

“That is what I believed.”

Raghav’s eyes filled, though his voice remained steady. “Was any of it real?”

Naina pulled out the chair across from him. Between them lay the table where they had eaten late dinners, argued about curtains, signed mortgage papers, and once made love on an anniversary after the candles burned down. Ordinary intimacy lived everywhere in the apartment. Betrayal could not retroactively evict it.

“All of it,” she said. “That is why this hurts.”

He looked toward the kitchen. "Do not give me a beautiful answer."

"I don't have one."

For the first time since the reception, they spoke without an audience or an emergency. It took hours.

Raghav told her about the redevelopment proposal in full. His firm had been competing for the Surya Garh partnership for eleven months. When the first survey mentioned inconsistent records, a senior partner had instructed the consultant to assess only commercially accessible rooms. Raghav had recognized Naina's phrasing in an older report and allowed it to be reused because he believed he would bring her in later and correct whatever mattered.

"I told myself I was creating the opportunity first," he said. "Then you would improve it."

"You used my credibility before giving me authority."

"Yes."

The word came without qualification.

He had not ordered anyone to enter the suite or manipulate the slideshow. He had, however, packed the contract and her pen expecting persuasion to become signature. He had treated consent as the last step of a plan rather than the condition that permitted planning.

"I am sorry," he said.

Naina believed him. Belief did not repair the damage, but it allowed the damage to have an accurate name.

Naina did not blame his work, his ambition, or the contract for the kisses. She did not turn years of small loneliness into permission. She told him what had happened in the blue room and in the archive, including the moments she had moved toward Ayaan rather than merely failed to move away.

Raghav asked questions that injured them both. Had Ayaan touched her waist? Yes. Had she imagined going further? Yes. Had she stopped because she remembered her husband? Not only. She had stopped because she needed desire to remain a choice rather than become another current carrying her somewhere.

"He listened when you said stop," Raghav said. "You keep mentioning that."

"Because it mattered."

"Have I ever forced you?"

"No."

"Then what are you telling me?"

Naina searched for words that did not exaggerate him into a villain. “You often heard silence as agreement. About the apartment. About my work. About children. About where we spent holidays. Even in bed sometimes—not because you ignored a no, but because you stopped asking what I wanted once you thought you knew.”

Raghav looked down. “The fertility appointment.”

“Yes.”

“I cancelled it when you said you were not ready.”

“After booking it without telling me.”

“I thought the delay was making you anxious.”

“The appointment made my body feel like a project whose timeline you were managing.”

Pain moved across his face. “I wanted a child with you.”

“I know.”

“Did you?”

Naina answered slowly. “Sometimes. Sometimes I wanted the future everyone described when they asked us. Sometimes I wanted only more time. I never stayed with the uncertainty long enough to tell you the difference.”

Raghav leaned back. “We might have built an entire life on answers neither of us had given.”

“We already did.”

His face tightened. “And you let me.”

“Yes.”

“That belongs in this room too.”

“Yes.”

They sat with the shared failure. It was less satisfying than blame and more useful.

At dusk, Raghav opened the balcony doors. Traffic rose from the avenue. Somewhere below, a pressure cooker released steam in a neighboring kitchen. The world continued its ordinary domestic life while theirs became unrecognizable.

“Do you want a divorce?” he asked.

Naina looked at the wedding photograph on the bookshelf. She remembered the confidence with which her younger self had placed a garland around him, believing a decision made publicly became permanent through witnesses.

“I want time in which the answer is not another reaction.”

“How much time?”

“I do not know.”

“A month? Six?”

“If I give you a number, you will turn waiting into a schedule and good behaviour into a proposal.”

He almost objected. Then his mouth tightened in recognition.

“Separate homes,” she said. “No decisions made for each other. No asking friends to carry messages. We speak once a week if we both want to. We continue the preservation work separately.”

“And exclusivity?”

The word entered the room carefully.

“I will not begin a relationship with Ayaan while I am asking whether this marriage can continue.”

“Because you owe me?”

“Because I owe myself a decision that is not made inside overlap.”

Raghav nodded. “I can accept that.”

“Do not accept it if you mean endure it until I return.”

“I do not know what I mean yet.”

It was one of the first uncertain answers he had ever given her. She loved him for it and could not stay because of it.

“And him?”

“I am not leaving you for him.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“I don’t know.”

Raghav nodded as if the answer confirmed something. “Where will you go?”

“A hotel tonight. Then I’ll find a studio.”

“You don’t have to leave tonight.”

“Neither do you.”

He gave a small, exhausted laugh. “We are still being polite about doors.”

They divided the apartment with practical tenderness. Naina packed work clothes, drawings, medicines, and the blue notebook. Raghav found the charger she had forgotten and coiled it carefully into the outer pocket. She left the wedding jewellery in the safe and took her mother’s thin gold chain.

In the bedroom, she reached for a green sari at the same moment Raghav reached for the suitcase lid. Their hands touched.

Both froze.

He turned his palm upward. It was a familiar gesture, one he had used in crowded streets and dark cinemas. Naina placed her hand in his.

Raghav drew her toward him.

The embrace was not graceful. Her cheek pressed against his shoulder; his breath caught in her hair. For several seconds they held each other with the old instinct of husband and wife, bodies recognizing home before memory supplied the damage.

He kissed her temple. Then her cheek. When his mouth found hers, the kiss carried eight years of fluency—gentle at first, then desperate. Naina responded. Her fingers closed in the fabric at his back. Grief and desire moved together, each making the other harder to trust.

Raghav's hand slid to her waist, fitting the place it knew. She felt the question in him before he spoke it.

"Stay tonight."

Naina rested her forehead against his. Her body wanted the comfort of the known room, the known hands, the temporary mercy of not deciding.

"If I stay," she whispered, "tomorrow we will use it as evidence."

"Evidence of what?"

"Whatever each of us needs it to prove."

His hand loosened. He stepped back first.

At the front door he lifted her suitcase and carried it to the corridor.

"I still love you," he said.

"I still love you too."

Naina removed her ring. The skin beneath it was pale, a narrow circle of evidence.

She did not place it in his hand. She set it beside his on the dining table.

Two rings, separate and touching.

This time the truth did not preserve them.

It allowed them to separate without pretending love had failed to exist.

Chapter Twenty Three

The Restoration

Naina rented a small studio above a printing shop in Banjara Hills.

The first room served as office, kitchen, and bedroom. The second was narrow enough that she could touch both walls if she extended her arms. The windows rattled whenever the press downstairs began its morning run, and by noon the air smelled of ink and hot paper.

She loved it immediately, then distrusted herself for loving it.

There was no one to object when she placed the drafting table across the best light. No one to ask why dinner was late or why plaster samples occupied the sink. Freedom arrived not as triumph but as a series of small silences: one cup drying beside the basin, one towel on the hook, one side of the bed remaining cold.

For six months she worked on Neel Mahal.

The first month was triage. Tarpaulins over the dye rooms. Humidity loggers inside the archive. Numbered trays beneath fragments of painted plaster. Naina spent three nights a week at Surya Garh and the remaining days persuading officials that stabilization was not cosmetic repair.

The second month was argument. Engineers wanted steel where lime and timber could still carry the load. The hotel wanted the courtyard reopened for events before the monsoon. Scholars wanted every surface preserved exactly as found, including damage that would destroy it if untouched.

Naina learned to refuse all of them in different vocabularies.

By the third month, the building had stopped feeling like the place where her marriage ended. It became work: difficult, physical, occasionally dull. She loved it more for losing its symbolism.

The heritage board issued an emergency stay within forty-eight hours. Scholars authenticated Zohra Banu's plans and established that her work predated several features credited to the men in her family. Newspapers carried the story of the erased architect and the wedding storm. Dev's family challenged the trust, then negotiated when public attention made demolition expensive.

The romance of preservation disappeared as soon as the work began. Roof tiles had to be catalogued. Damp maps had to be redrawn. Lime mixtures failed. Budgets shrank.

A senior official praised Naina's passion, then addressed all technical questions to the male conservation engineer standing beside her.

She answered anyway.

Meera and Dev entered counselling before their honeymoon. Meera sent messages for weeks that required no response: photographs of labeled boxes, updates from the lawyer, an apology without a request attached. Naina read each one. It took three months before she sent back a single word: *Received*.

Two weeks later, Meera came to a public site meeting and sat in the last row. She did not approach Naina afterward. She left a folder containing the original trust inventories, indexed in her own hand.

Naina sent two words that evening: *Thank you*.

Repair began at that scale.

Leela became the official archive custodian and terrorized every researcher who entered with a pen instead of a pencil.

Raghav withdrew his firm's proposal. Then he provided internal correspondence proving that senior partners had known about the atelier records before recommending demolition.

It cost him the partnership.

Naina learned about it from a business article. She began three messages before sending one.

Thank you for doing the right thing.

His reply arrived the next morning.

It was the first useful thing I did without deciding what it should mean for us.

She saved the message and did not mistake it for reconciliation.

Ayaan sent photographs through formal project channels. His emails contained captions, dates, lens information, and no invitations. He documented peeling frescoes, rain channels, hinges, fingerprints in old lime. People appeared only for scale.

They met twice at professional reviews. The first time, eight people sat between them at a long table. Ayaan presented his documentation without once referring to the storm. Naina challenged the colour calibration on a set of plaster images. He corrected it the next day and copied the entire team.

The second time, they found themselves alone for four minutes beside the restored blue door.

"How are you?" he asked.

"That question is too large for a corridor."

“Then give me the corridor answer.”

“Working.”

“So am I.”

Neither mentioned Raghav, the kiss, or the message Naina had sent upon reaching Hyderabad: **Arrived. Safe. Thank you.**

When the others returned, Ayaan stepped aside to let her pass. His sleeve brushed her arm. The small contact stayed with her through the entire meeting, proof that distance could sharpen desire without granting it authority.

Naina sometimes stared at his name in her inbox before opening the files. Desire did not diminish simply because she had decided not to obey it. It altered. It lost the urgency of forbidden rooms and became something steadier, more difficult to romanticize.

One evening she found a new folder in the archive transfer.

PRIVATE contained only the first photograph from the entrance arch—the image he had taken before the ceremonies began, before the storm and the blue door. She stood under the carved stone in her green sari, head turned toward the gathering clouds.

He had added a note in the metadata.

You were already looking toward the storm.

Naina placed her fingers on the screen. Then she closed the folder.

She did not reply.

Instead she completed the restoration plan under a new practice bearing her own name. Its first project was the seventh courtyard. Its second was a public library in Warangal. Its third was the life she arranged room by room without asking anyone to approve the circulation.

There were bad nights. Nights when the freedom she had demanded resembled abandonment. Nights when she nearly called Raghav because a pipe burst, or Ayaan because rain struck the windows. She learned that independence did not mean never reaching for another person. It meant knowing why she reached and accepting that the answer might be no.

She began therapy on a Wednesday at four because the hour fit between site calls. For the first three sessions she described architecture. In the fourth, the therapist asked why Naina spoke of every choice as though a committee might reject it.

She cried with such fury that the printing-shop owner downstairs later asked whether a pipe had burst.

Naina learned to name the pleasure she had taken in being considered dependable. Silence had not only been imposed on her; it had protected her from the risk of wanting

visibly. She learned that responsibility did not require permanent punishment, and forgiveness did not require reunion.

Raghav visited the studio once in late winter.

He stood among rolls of tracing paper and plaster samples in a charcoal shirt she had never seen. He looked thinner and, somehow, less defended.

"I brought the final disclosure statement," he said.

"You could have emailed it."

"I could have."

She made tea. They sat on mismatched chairs beside the window while the printing press vibrated through the floor.

"You look happy," he said.

"Sometimes."

"That is more honest than always."

"You look different."

"Unemployed?"

"Less rehearsed."

He accepted the description. "Therapy has made pauses very expensive."

"Mine keeps asking what I want."

"Unreasonable profession."

They laughed. The ease frightened her until she understood that comfort was not a command to return.

She smiled despite herself. "Unscheduled."

He told her he had joined a smaller firm that specialized in adaptive reuse. The salary was lower. He had begun therapy, a word he pronounced without apology. He had also learned to cook three meals, although two relied heavily on the same tomato sauce.

Naina told him about the library and the funding problem at Neel Mahal. For an hour they spoke as people who knew each other well and possessed no automatic right to anything more.

When he rose to leave, Raghav saw the draft divorce petition beneath a folder on her desk.

"Is that what you want?" he asked.

"I think it is what is true."

He nodded, but his eyes closed briefly.

Their divorce petition remained unsigned for another month—not because they expected the marriage to heal, but because ending a shared life involved ordinary cruelties no revelation had prepared them for. Which books belonged to whom. Whether to sell the apartment. Who would keep the brass lamp from their first Diwali. What reason to give on a form that offered boxes but no history.

They signed at the same lawyer's table on a Tuesday afternoon.

The lawyer read the clauses in a neutral voice: mutual consent, division of property, withdrawal of claims. Language reduced eight years to arrangements enforceable by strangers.

When the papers reached Naina, she held the pen above the signature line.

Raghav did not urge her. He did not say they had come too far to stop or ask whether she was certain. He waited.

Naina signed because the waiting allowed the choice to remain hers.

Outside the office, Raghav handed Naina the blue fountain pen he had used.

"Keep it," she said.

"I bought it for our fifth anniversary."

"Then it belongs to both versions of us."

He slipped it into her bag.

"Did you ever hate me?" she asked outside the office.

"Yes."

The answer relieved her.

"Do you now?"

"Sometimes for ten minutes. Then I remember something irritatingly specific, like how you label leftover food with dates, and hatred loses discipline."

"I hated you too."

"For the contract?"

"For making it possible to miss you."

He looked away toward the traffic. "Good. I would hate to be forgettable."

They shared tea at a roadside stall before leaving in separate cars. It was not reconciliation. It was the final ordinary act of their marriage, and therefore the one Naina remembered most clearly.

Neither treated the signature as proof that the marriage had been a mistake.

Some buildings could not be restored to their original use.

They could still be honoured for having sheltered a life.

Chapter Twenty Four

The Next Monsoon

One year after the wedding, rain returned to Surya Garh.

The seventh courtyard opened as the Zohra Banu Residency for Women Artists and Designers. The old dye rooms became studios with northern light. The archive occupied the driest upper chamber. The names in the hidden gallery remained untouched beneath protective glass, each translated on a small brass plate.

Naina arrived before sunrise and walked the building alone.

She began at the lower grille where floodwater had once blocked the passage. The new gate stood open, fitted with a sensor and a manual release anyone could operate from either side. In the atelier, reconstructed looms occupied only three bays; the remaining floor stayed clear for work. Brass lines marked the foundations of walls removed decades earlier without pretending to rebuild what could not be known.

On the western wall, Zohra Banu's plan hung beside a list of every artisan whose name survived in the ledgers. Leela had insisted the list begin with workers rather than patrons.

Naina touched none of it. She walked as an architect does before handover, searching for failures: a sticking latch, moisture at a sill, a label placed too high for a child. She found seven defects and felt reassured. Completion without flaws would have seemed like another lie.

Restoration had not made it new. That was never the purpose. The replaced stone remained slightly paler. Hairline fractures crossed the fountain basin. Along the western wall, conservators had left a square of unrestored plaster so visitors could see what weather and neglect had done.

At ten, the gates opened.

Students, journalists, officials, and villagers entered the courtyard. Leela led the first tour and corrected the printed brochure twice. Meera came with Dev, their hands linked but not displayed. When she reached Naina, she stopped uncertainly.

"It is beautiful," Meera said.

"It is standing."

"Will you let me hug you?"

Naina considered the question. The asking mattered.

“Yes.”

Their embrace did not restore the old friendship. It began a different one, slower and less innocent.

“Dev and I are still in counselling,” Meera said when they stepped apart.

“You do not owe me a report.”

“I know. I am telling you because I want to, not because progress should purchase forgiveness.”

Naina looked at her friend—the woman who had manipulated her, protected evidence, altered her own wedding vows, and learned to ask before embracing.

“Would you like tea after the speeches?” Naina asked.

Meera’s eyes filled. “Yes.”

It was not the old intimacy. It was enough for one afternoon.

Raghav attended alone.

Naina saw him listening to the keynote from the back row. When the applause ended, he waited until the officials had finished congratulating her before approaching.

They stood beside the restored fountain while guests moved through the court.

“You kept the cracks,” he said.

“The building earned them.”

“So did we.”

They smiled. There was grief in it, but no unfinished negotiation.

“Are you well?” she asked.

“Sometimes.”

“That is more honest than always.”

He gave her a small package. Inside was the brass lamp from their first Diwali.

“I thought the studio needed something that survived us,” he said.

“Thank you.”

Raghav touched her shoulder, waited, then kissed her forehead. The gesture belonged neither to marriage nor regret. It was simply farewell performed with affection.

“The stay order became permanent last week,” Naina told him.

“I saw.”

“Your disclosure mattered.”

“So did your refusal.”

For years they had treated gratitude as a debt. This time it passed between them and remained only gratitude.

He left before the rain began.

At dusk, Naina climbed to the roof pavilion. Clouds pressed low over the lake. The causeway below had been raised and reinforced; drainage openings lined its side. Water could cross it, but no longer erase it.

Footsteps sounded on the stair.

Ayaan arrived without a camera.

Naina had imagined this meeting too often and in contradictory forms. In one version she ran to him. In another she greeted him with professional calm and made him suffer for the months of restraint. In several, he had changed his mind.

The actual man paused on the final step to catch his breath.

“Your restored staircase is very long,” he said.

Her rehearsed composure broke into laughter.

He stood beneath the dome, older than the man at Chand Baori and less protected than the man in the storm. His hair was shorter. A thin scar crossed one knuckle. Naina wondered about the months contained in those small changes and felt the distance between knowing an old love and knowing a present person.

“You’re late,” she said.

“The flight was delayed.”

“Still blaming weather.”

“Only for flights.”

They looked across the lake. Music from another wedding drifted over the water. Below them, guests ran laughing beneath the arches as the first drops fell.

“You received my invitation,” Naina said.

“It contained a date, time, dress code, and no personal message. Very difficult to misinterpret.”

“You came.”

“You asked.”

Rain darkened the stone at the pavilion’s edge.

“I am divorced,” she said.

“I know.”

“Raghav and I signed four months ago.”

“I know that too.”

“Meera?”

“Leela. She believes privacy is a colonial invention.”

Naina laughed, and the sound released something in both of them.

Then she became serious. “I did not do it for you.”

“I know.”

“Say more than that.”

Ayaan leaned against the pillar. “I know because you told me not to wait. Because you did not call when you were lonely. Because you built all of this before you invited me back into a room with you.”

“Were you angry?”

“Often.”

“At me?”

“At time. At Raghav. At myself for wanting you to make an enormous decision quickly so I would not have to live with uncertainty.”

“And now?”

“Now I am trying not to turn patience into a debt you owe me.”

The rain thickened, a silver curtain beyond the dome. Naina stepped nearer, close enough to see the pulse in his throat.

“I don’t want an old story resumed,” she said.

“Neither do I.”

“I don’t want to be forgiven into becoming the woman I was at twenty-seven.”

“Good. She frightened me.”

“She frightened herself.”

“I would like to know the woman standing here.”

“She is more difficult.”

“I had gathered.”

“She keeps her own apartment.”

“So do I.”

“She may choose work over dinner.”

“I have survived airports.”

“She does not want patience quoted back to her during arguments.”

Ayaan’s expression sobered. “If I ever make restraint into a receipt, leave the room.”

“I would rather stay and tell you.”

“Better.”

This, more than the romance of waiting, was what she wanted: not a man incapable of error, but a relationship in which error did not become authority.

“She cannot promise where this goes.”

Ayaan held out his hand, palm open, offering no direction.

“Then don’t promise.”

Naina looked at the hand, at the safe causeway, and at the courtyard below where Zohra Banu’s name had returned to the official plan.

She placed her hand in his.

Ayaan’s fingers closed gently. He did not pull her closer. That choice remained hers.

Naina stepped into him.

His free hand rose to her face, paused beside her cheek, and waited. She turned into the touch. The restraint that had once kept them apart now became the space in which she could move without fear of disappearing.

She kissed him.

For an instant neither breathed. Then his mouth answered hers, warm and careful, the carefulness giving way only when her hand slid around his neck. He drew her closer by the waist. Rain-cooled air moved over her skin while heat gathered beneath his palm.

The kiss deepened without becoming hurried. It contained memory—the blue room, the archive, the years before her marriage—but it did not belong to any of them. Naina felt the difference in the way Ayaan waited for each small return, each movement that said yes again.

Her fingers slid into his hair. His hand travelled from her cheek to the back of her neck, then down the line of her spine, stopping at her waist. The familiar restraint no longer felt like distance. It felt like attention.

“Still?” he murmured against her mouth.

“Yes.”

She kissed him before the word had fully left her. Ayaan answered with a hunger he had kept disciplined for a year. He drew her against him, close enough that the months between them became physical—felt in the sharp breath he took, in the way her body recognized him and also recognized change.

Rain struck the dome more heavily. Naina tasted water at the corner of his mouth. His thumb moved along her waist beneath the edge of her jacket, warm against bare skin, and paused.

She placed her hand over his and guided it farther around her back.

“You can touch me,” she said.

Desire altered his face, but he did not hurry. “Here?”

“Here.”

His palm settled against her. The question and answer remained inside the touch.

They kissed until laughter rose from the courtyard below and reminded them where they were. Naina drew back first, breathing hard, her forehead against his.

“There are two hundred guests downstairs,” she said.

“I counted fewer.”

“You were always unreliable with crowds.”

“Only when you are in them.”

She smiled, unwilling to pretend the line did not work.

When they parted, his forehead rested against hers.

“Was that an old story?” he asked.

“No.”

“Good.”

“It may require revision.”

“I can work with notes.”

They descended together after the rain, not hiding from the guests and not hurrying toward an ending.

At the entrance arch, the event photographer raised her camera.

Naina saw her.

This time she did not turn away.

Epilogue

Proof

Months later, a framed photograph hung in Naina's studio.

It showed the entrance of Surya Garh in monsoon light. Naina and Ayaan stood beneath the arch, shoulders touching, both looking directly at the camera. Behind them, the seventh courtyard was invisible but no longer erased.

Visitors often assumed it was an engagement portrait.

It was not.

Ayaan kept his apartment in Delhi. Naina kept the studio in Hyderabad. They missed flights, disagreed about work, and learned that longing was less photogenic when it involved calendars and laundry. Sometimes he stayed for a week. Sometimes she needed him to leave after three days. Neither treated distance as abandonment or closeness as ownership.

On the first anniversary of the opening, Ayaan arrived after midnight.

Naina woke to his knock and found him in the corridor with rain on his jacket and exhaustion beneath his eyes. He held no flowers, only a paper bag of samosas gone cold during the drive from the airport.

"This is not a grand gesture," he said.

"Good. I'm hungry."

They ate on the studio floor beneath the framed photograph. He told her about an assignment in Ladakh. She told him the library roof had leaked again. Their knees touched. Conversation thinned into silence, not empty but chosen.

Ayaan took off his damp jacket and hung it over the chair where Naina usually kept tracing paper. She moved the rolls before the water could reach them. He knew where the towels were now, which cupboard held tea, which window required a folded receipt beneath the latch to stop it rattling.

These small competencies pleased her differently from Raghav's certainty. Ayaan had not entered the studio already knowing how it should work. He had learned because she had shown him, and because he asked again when something changed.

"You moved the bed," he said.

"The press is quieter against that wall."

"May I complain that it ruins my navigation?"

“You may submit a written objection.”

“Will it be reviewed independently?”

“No.”

He smiled. The laughter faded slowly, leaving them aware of midnight, rain, and the fact that they had not seen each other for six weeks.

Ayaan brushed a crumb from the corner of her mouth.

“May I?” he asked.

Naina smiled. “You flew across the country and still ask.”

“Those are unrelated facts.”

“Yes.”

He kissed her slowly.

The first kiss was a greeting. The second admitted how long they had been apart.

Naina took his face between her hands and felt the cold rain still caught along his jaw. Ayaan’s palm settled at her waist, familiar now but never assumed. When she leaned closer, he drew her across the small space between them until her knees rested on either side of his hips.

“All right?” he asked.

“Very.”

He laughed against her mouth, and she kissed the sound away.

Desire no longer arrived with the panic of a forbidden room. It gathered through details she could choose: his fingers spreading across her back; the pressure of his mouth beneath her ear; her own hand opening the first button of his shirt and then the second. When she paused, he paused with her.

“I am not changing my mind,” she said.

“You are allowed to.”

“I know. I am looking at you.”

“That is alarmingly intimate.”

She touched the scar on his knuckle, the one the iron ring at Surya Garh had left. Then she brought his hand to the buttons at her shoulder.

“Help me,” she said.

He searched her face before obeying. The fabric loosened slowly beneath his fingers. There was no darkness to protect either of them from being seen. Naina felt the old instinct to become graceful, certain, easy to want. She let it pass.

Ayaan kissed the exposed curve of her shoulder. “You can tell me what you like.”

“I am still learning.”

“Then we have no deadline.”

She guided his mouth back to hers.

The studio lights remained on. There was no storm to conceal them, no marriage ceremony below, no locked room making desire feel exempt from consequence. Naina touched his face, his shoulders, the rain-damp hair at his neck. When he drew her onto his lap, she went willingly and felt him smile against her mouth.

They moved toward the narrow bed without urgency. Clothes loosened and fell in an untidy path. Ayaan paused whenever her breathing changed; Naina answered with words, hands, and the unambiguous movement of her body toward his. Their intimacy was neither rescue nor reward. It was tenderness with responsibility left intact.

At the bed, he stopped again. “Do you want the light off?”

Naina looked at the lamp, the open sketchbook, the photograph above them, and the man waiting without disguising how much he wanted her.

“No.”

The word changed the room.

She pulled him down with her. The mattress complained beneath their combined weight, making them both laugh until Ayaan kissed her throat and laughter became breath. His hands moved with patience over skin he had once touched only at its edges. Each time he found a place that made her tense or soften, he waited for her to tell him which it was.

Naina discovered that asking could be erotic, that a pause could intensify rather than interrupt. She told him closer. Slower. There. She said his name without whispering it. Ayaan answered with the same honesty, letting her learn him rather than performing certainty.

For a while the printing press, the leaking library, the flights between cities, and the history that had brought them there fell beyond attention. They did not disappear. Nothing was absolved. But consequence no longer had to stand inside every touch as punishment.

When pleasure overtook language, Naina held him close and trusted the wordless response because words had built the path to it.

Afterward they remained tangled across the narrow bed, one of Ayaan’s feet still on the floor because there was nowhere else to put it.

“Your furniture remains hostile,” he said.

“The bed has boundaries.”

“I respect them. I resent them, but respectfully.”

She moved closer and made room.

Afterward, rain tapped the windows above the sound of the printing press beginning its early run.

Ayaan lay beside her, one hand open on the sheet between them.

“Should I look for a place here?” he asked.

Naina considered the question instead of fearing it.

“Look,” she said. “Do not sign anything without showing me.”

“That sounds dangerously like a future.”

“It sounds like a viewing.”

He laughed and brought her fingers to his lips.

Morning did not transform them into a finished couple.

Ayaan left wet towels on the chair. Naina answered two work messages while he was making tea and missed half of a story about Delhi. He wanted to book his return flight for Sunday; she had assumed Saturday. The disagreement was small enough to ignore and therefore exactly the kind she had promised herself she would not ignore.

“I need Sunday morning alone before the site review,” she said.

Disappointment crossed his face. He did not hide it behind generosity.

“Then I will leave Saturday night,” he said. “I wish I did not have to.”

“So do I.”

The truth caused no collapse. They drank tea beside the open window while rain washed ink-scented heat from the street.

The photograph above them was not proof that love had conquered circumstance. It did not absolve them of the harm that had preceded it or promise that they would never fail each other.

It was proof of something simpler and more difficult.

They were there.

And when morning found them, they were still choosing to be.